



The Atlantic

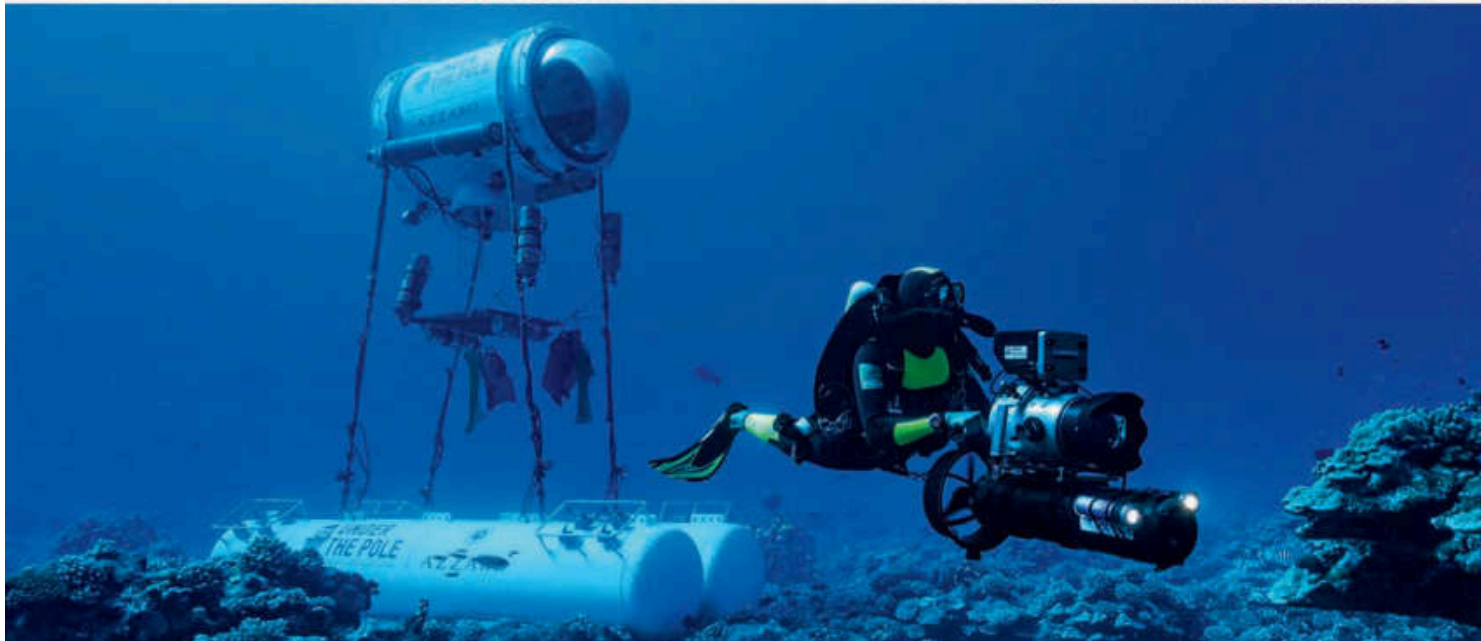
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Twenty Years Gone

One family's struggle to make sense of 9/11

By Jennifer Senior





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Photographs by Eugene Richards

A construction supervisor calls to his crew working on scaffolding near Ground Zero, in December 2001.

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 DANNA SINGER FOR
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THE COMMONS

DISCUSSION

&

DEBATE

The War on Nostalgia

*The myth of the
Lost Cause is passed
down like an heirloom,
Clint Smith wrote
in June. What would
it take for the truth to
break through?*

Letters

I am a southern white male. I was born in 1953, so I am old enough to remember my paternal great-grandmother, born in 1877 in Langley, South Carolina; my paternal grandfather, born in 1900 in Augusta, Georgia; my paternal grandmother, born in 1898 in Blakely, Georgia; and many other southern kinfolk from a bygone era. My parents taught us that hate was a sin and that Jim Crow was wrong. So I grew up thinking I was not bigoted or racist in any way.

Your article was something of a slap in the face, a wake-up call to recognize how embedded

in the world of white privilege and power I actually am.

My father and I got interested in family genealogy in 1998, and we quickly discovered that one of his ancestors had served as a private in the 20th South Carolina Volunteer Infantry from 1863 to 1865. We thrilled at finding microfilm records documenting his service, and learned that he had been taken prisoner at the Battle of Cedar Creek in Middletown, Virginia, on October 19, 1864, and spent the remainder of the war at a prison camp in Point Lookout, Maryland. We also

learned that a large Civil War reenactment takes place on the third weekend of October in Middletown. We attended the reenactment every year from 1999 to 2011 and took my son (now 28) and his best friend many of those years. We proudly wore Confederate symbols so that folks would know which side we were on.

My wife had an uncle, now deceased, who was active in a Texas branch of the Sons of Confederate Veterans; circa 1999, he talked me into attending a meeting of a chapter near Atlanta. The members discussed their ongoing projects of placing or maintaining monuments and historical markers at old skirmish sites or rumored grave sites. I did not feel at all comfortable with the clannish, secret-handshake vibe and never went again. But I look back now and say, *Oh my God! I attended an SCV meeting! Good old progressive, liberal me.*

It is startling to me to come to terms with the fact that I am not where I thought I was on the racial-awareness spectrum.

Jimmy Hair
Charlotte, N.C.

“Confederate history is family history, history as eulogy, in which loyalty takes precedence over truth,” Clint Smith writes. Perhaps the Sons of Confederate Veterans should consider this advice from Voltaire: “We owe respect to the living; to the dead we owe only truth.”

George Kovac
Miami, Fla.



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BEAUTY IS A POWERFUL FORCE THAT MOVES US.

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and in our relationships with others.

L'ORÉAL
G R O U P E

My great-great-great-grandfather's second cousin was a Confederate general. I don't loathe him. He did what was expected of him in his time. But I would be embarrassed to honor him at his grave site.

Richard Sibley
Phoenix, Ariz.

I was raised as a first-generation Cuban American in Miami in the 1960s and '70s, with limited exposure to southern Confederate history. I moved to Jacksonville, Florida, in 1994 and within a few years visited the Olustee Battlefield Historic State Park to witness a reenactment of the 1864 conflict where the Confederacy defeated the Union soldiers. I will never forget sitting in the bleachers with my then-5-year-old son and his best friend, who were not particularly interested in watching all these men in wool uniforms strutting about with bayonets amid cannon fire. There were two white men in their 50s near us, passionately discussing how, if General Robert E. Lee had done this maneuver or conducted that battle differently, "we could have won the war." I was in total shock to realize that, more than 130 years after the horrific Civil War, there were still Southerners (white, of course) who tried to envision another outcome. I left that battle reenactment in disgust.

We still have a ways to go to right the wrongs of this mythology.

Leo Alonso
Jacksonville, Fla.

More than 20 years ago my family went to Charleston, South Carolina. We saw a brochure for Middleton Place plantation and thought it might be

instructive to see how a working plantation, well, worked. The grounds were immaculate and the guides enthusiastic.

It became too much as we were being shown the gorgeous back lawn leading down to the river. I looked to our guide for more information. With a smile she said, "It took 100 slaves 10 years to do this work!"

I will never look at a beautiful plantation again without wondering in anger and sadness who built the home, who planted and tended the garden, who wept at night over the forced labor, and who made southern life possible by being brutalized daily. I look forward to visiting the Whitney

Plantation with my eyes and heart open to listen to the stories told there.

James A. Gibson
Pittsburgh, Pa.

CLINT SMITH REPLIES:

I'm so appreciative of the letters and emails I've received in response to "The War on Nostalgia." The article is adapted from my new book, How the Word Is Passed, in which I explore how different historical sites reckon with or fail to reckon with their relationship to slavery. Sometimes, an article or a book arrives in a moment when the topic you've explored for years is a central part of the

public discourse. Today, we are having a national conversation about how we should study, remember, and account for the shameful parts of this country's history. Many people are asking: How different might our country look if all of us, collectively, understood the full truth of what has happened here? I hope that this story, and my book, can continue to help those attempting to make sense of this question and others like it.

To respond to *Atlantic* articles or submit author questions to The Commons, please email letters@theatlantic.com. Include your full name, city, and state.

Behind the Cover: In this month's cover story, Jennifer Senior looks back on a national tragedy through the lens of one family's loss. After Bobby McIlvaine was killed on 9/11, at 26, police returned his debris-covered wallet to his father, who kept it sealed in a biohazard bag. The wallet

is a symbol of an individual life cut short, and a stand-in for the enduring grief of thousands of families who, like the McIlvaines, are still struggling to make sense of what happened that day.

— Luise Stauss, *Director of Photography*
Christine Walsh, *Contributing Photo Editor*

THE FACTS

What we learned fact-checking this issue

In 2011, a collapsing storefront in Money, Mississippi, became the first stop on the state's Freedom Trail, which commemorates civil-rights history. A sign was unveiled outside the former Bryant's Grocery, where, in 1955, 14-year-old Emmett Till whistled at a white woman; later,

he was murdered by the woman's husband and his accomplices. In the right-hand corner of the sign was a quotation attributed to Rosa Parks: "I thought of Emmett Till and when the bus driver ordered me to move to the back, I just couldn't move." This oft-cited quotation lent credence to the idea that Till's murder sparked the civil-rights movement. Six years later, however, the quotation was removed from the sign

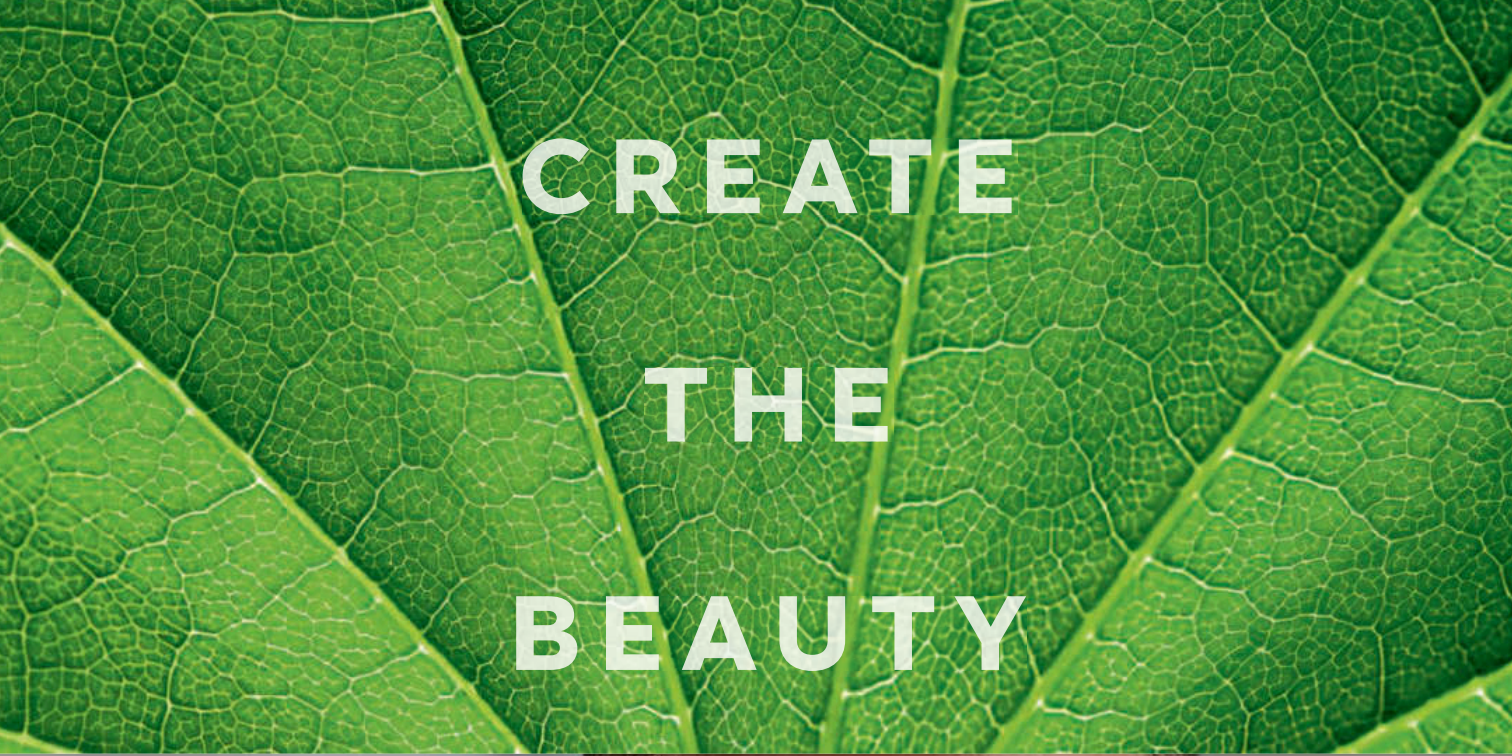
because its origin could not be determined.

There seems to be no record of Parks uttering these exact words. But historical evidence suggests that Till's murder was on her mind when she refused to give up her seat on the bus, as Wright Thompson notes in his article about Till (p. 68). According to the scholar Dave Tell, the idea can be traced back to the 2003 book *Death of Innocence*, by Till's mother, Mamie

Till-Mobley. She describes meeting the activist for the first time in 1988: "Rosa Parks would tell me how she felt about Emmett, how she had thought about him on that fateful day when she took that historic stand by keeping her seat." Others, including the Reverend Jesse Jackson, have since noted that Parks privately told them the same thing.

— Stephanie Hayes,
Deputy Research Chief

Corrections: "Bust the Police Unions" (July/August) misstated the duration of the video showing George Floyd's death. The article also incorrectly stated that George Wallace sought the Democratic presidential nomination in 1968. In fact, Wallace ran as a third-party candidate that year. "Can Bollywood Survive Modi?" (July/August) misstated the nationality of a suicide bomber in Kashmir. Though a Pakistan-based extremist group claimed responsibility for the attack, the bomber was not Pakistani.



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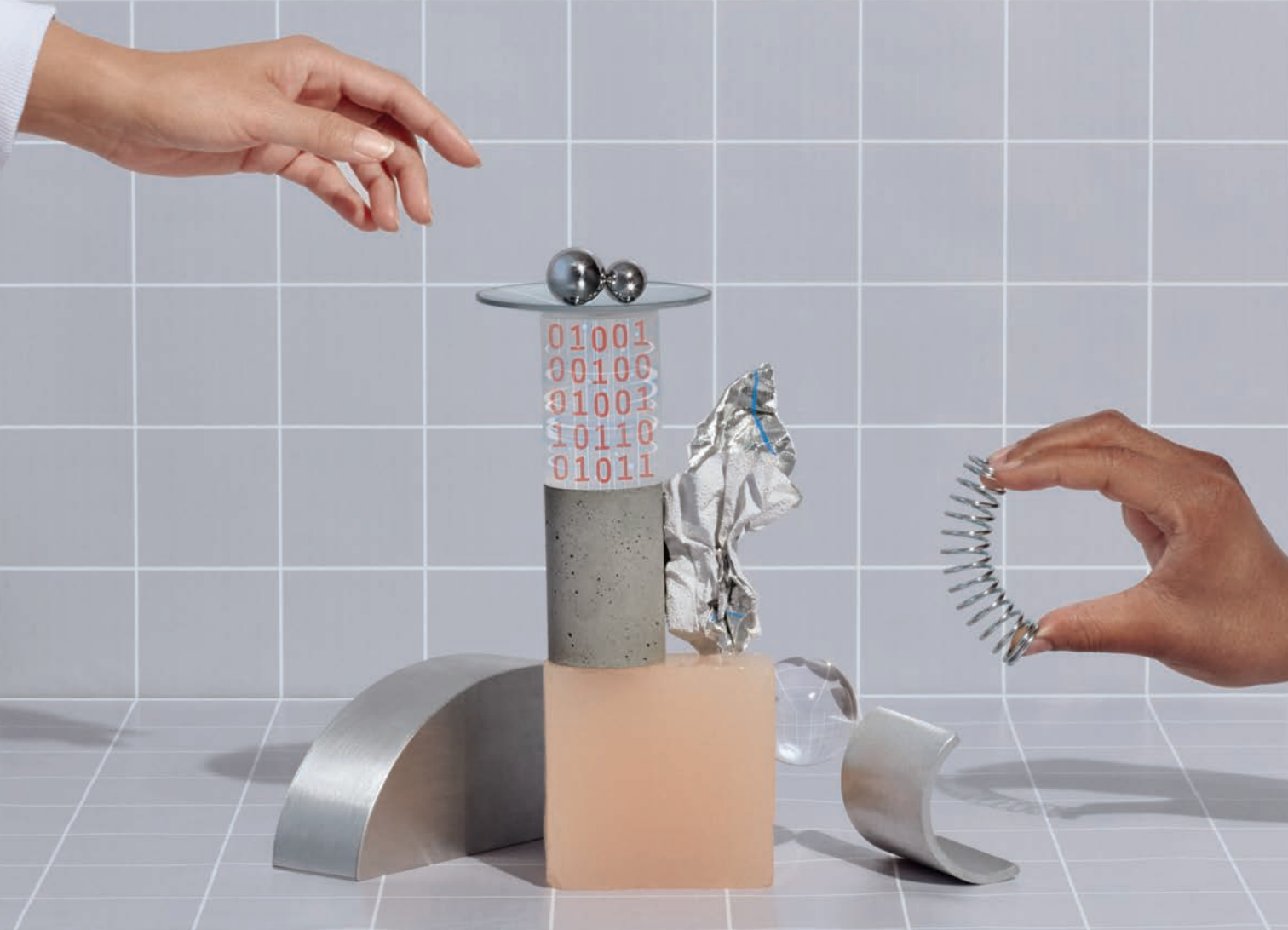


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DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

THE 9/11 CENTURY

*Twenty years on, how
should we think about
the worst terrorist attack
in American history?*

BY GEORGE PACKER

September 11 is buried so deep under layers of subsequent history and interpretation that it's hard to sort out the true feelings of that day. But I remember one image with indelible clarity. It's the face of a young woman in a color photograph on a flyer that appeared at the entrance to my subway stop in Brooklyn, around my neighborhood, and then all over the city. WE NEED YOUR HELP, the flyer said.

Giovanna
'Gennie' Gambale
27 years old 5'6"

Brown hair, brown eyes
Last seen on 102nd fl of
World Trade Center ...
Call with any information.

The sign was posted right after the attacks and stayed up long after it stopped being an urgent request to locate a missing person who might be wandering through the ashes of Lower Manhattan, and became a tribute to a lost daughter. The early hours and days were like that. The facts were incomprehensible. How many people died, how many survived, did any survive? When would the next attack come? Who had done it, and why?

Through most of September 12 and 13, I waited to give blood with other New Yorkers in a long sidewalk line. "I volunteered so I could be a part of something," an unemployed video producer named Matthew Timms told me. "I've been at no point in my life when I could say something I've done has affected mankind. Like, when the news was on, I was thinking, *What if there was a draft? Would I go?* I think I would." A teenager named Amalia della Paolera was passing out cookies. "This is the time when we need to be, like, pulling together and doing as much as we can for each other," she said, not "sitting at home watching it on TV and saying, like, 'Oh, there's another bomb.'"

Only on the second day did we begin to understand that there would not be any need for our blood, and even then no one left the line until we were told to go home.

The presence of other people—vigils around melted

candle wax on the Brooklyn Heights promenade, crowds at barricades on Canal Street offering foil-covered pots of food to rescue workers—was all that made the days bearable. Safe and hypercivilized people in cities like New York are generally embarrassed by expressions of strong feeling—irony comes more naturally. But right after September 11, strangers on the subway would

THE LIVES
SCARRED,
DESTROYED,
OR PREVENTED
FROM EXISTING
BY THE
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MUST NUMBER
IN THE
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THOUSANDS.

fall into intense conversations for six minutes, embrace, then never see each other again.

I remember Gennie Gambale because of her smile, which was radiant. Its light exposed the enormity of the crime. The hijackers had set out to end her life as she went about her morning in the heart of a great city. If they could have killed 30,000 human beings, or 3 million, they would have done it greedily. She would be 47 years old today. The youngest victim, a toddler on United

Flight 175, would be 22. The lives scarred, destroyed, or prevented from ever existing by the murder of 2,977 people must number in the hundreds of thousands. It's impossible to understand what America got wrong after September 11—the panic, the hubris, the lies, the endless wars, the two decades of national deterioration—without first letting that knowledge jam hard roots into the psyche.

ONE-THIRD OF AMERICANS alive today were children or not yet born on September 11, 2001. What, they must wonder, was it all about?

During the 10 years between the end of the Cold War and the terror attacks, the United States enjoyed a level of power, wealth, and safety that—except perhaps for Britain in the years before World War I—has no parallel in history. "Where do you want to go today?" asked a Microsoft commercial. Heady confidence and flabby comfort characterized a decade of rising stock prices and accelerating microprocessors. The information economy seemed to have repealed the business cycle. The U.S. could go to war with cruise missiles and without suffering casualties. Americans didn't have to worry that we might wake up one morning to rubble and corpses in our streets. The unipolar decade licensed us to waste an entire year on Oval Office sex. In the 2000 election, a lot of people voted, or failed to vote, as if it didn't really matter who was president. So much power, so little responsibility.

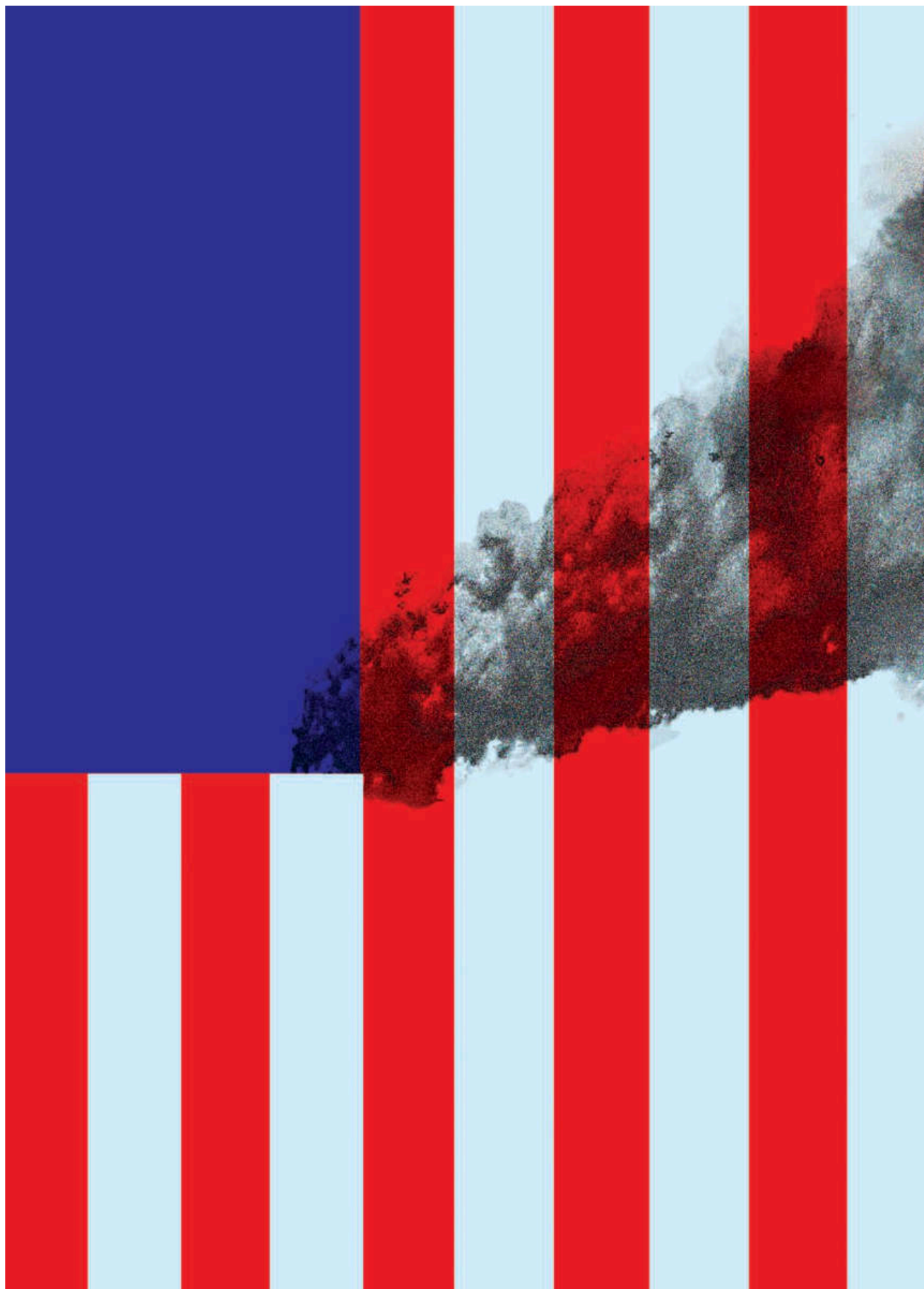
September 11 dissolved this dream of being exempt from history. It had been a childish dream, and its end forced many Americans, perhaps for the first

time, to consider the rest of the world. That morning, an investment banker escaped Ground Zero and staggered uptown into a church in Greenwich Village, where he began to shake and sob. A policeman put a hand on his shoulder and said, "Don't worry, you're in shock." The banker replied, "I'm *not* in shock. I like this state. I've never been more cognizant in my life."

We had not been thinking about the hijackers, but they had been thinking about us. For almost a decade, radical Islamists had been trying to get America's attention—declaring war on U.S. citizens; bombing our embassies, ships, and the World Trade Center itself—with little success. President Bill Clinton lobbed long-range missiles at jihadist training camps, impressing almost no one; the phrase *wag the dog* entered the lexicon. When the name al-Qaeda surfaced on September 11, very few Americans had even heard it before. The strategy of asymmetric warfare was unfamiliar, the enemy's goals opaque.

The late Lynne Stewart, a left-wing lawyer who defended clients accused of terrorism, before going to prison herself for providing them with material aid, once told me that the people in the towers "never knew what hit them. They had no idea that they could ever be a target for somebody's wrath, just by virtue of being American. They took it personally. And actually, it wasn't a personal thing ... In a war or in an armed struggle, people die."

The attacks brought a new thing into the world. Americans, jolted into alertness, were given the burden of understanding it. "Everything has changed," the pundits said. But



HENNY RAY ABRAMS / AFP / GETTY

the challenge to think and act anew is daunting. When it came to interpreting and answering the attacks, most of our political and thought leaders took refuge in familiar scripts. Three were particularly influential.

One argued that the attacks were chickens coming home to roost, a punishment, maybe even cosmic justice, for American deeds abroad—in Susan Sontag’s words of that same week, “a consequence of specific American alliances and actions.” A new term, *blowback*, became popular. Stewart took it a heartless step further: All Americans were fair game in a war against imperialism. This view implied that, if the U.S. would just stop doing certain things, the attacks would also stop.

A second script saw America as the entirely innocent party. All that was evil (them) was trying to destroy all that was good (us). The conflict was indeed a war, a war over freedom; American military and moral power, both nearly boundless, would eventually vanquish freedom’s sworn enemies. This was George W. Bush’s view (who was president turned out to matter a lot). The key phrase was *moral clarity*, which in practice became a policy of belligerence that soon fractured our national unity and eventually alienated most of the world.

A third script fell between or outside the first two: America, for all its flaws, had an obligation to support democracy and human rights, even if this meant using the 82nd Airborne Division to attempt nation-building in Afghanistan and regime change in Iraq. September 11 gave rise to the idea that security at home depended on the spread of democratic values in the Muslim world. This was the view of liberal

interventionists—including me, before I began reporting from Iraq in 2003—and it suffered from the illusion that war and power politics could be fitted to humanitarian ends.

In one way or another, all three of these views continued the dream of the 1990s. They put America at the center of the story. They assumed that the U.S. could will peace or destruction—that other countries and people weren’t quite real.

There were better responses, ones that showed intellectual modesty in the face of a new kind of war and a new kind of politics. As jihadist attacks became global and quotidian, in Madrid and Mumbai and Boston and Paris and Orlando, these responses warned against both overreaction and underestimation. They tried to comprehend radical Islamism on its own terms—not as a mechanical reflex against U.S. foreign policy, nor as the reincarnation of Nazi Germany, but as a potent ideology nourished by the repressive politics of a region with its own complex relation to both imperialism and modernity. These responses counseled that a contest of ideas would achieve more in the long term than air strikes.

They never got much of a hearing. Instead, American leaders fell into the jihadists’ trap and embarked on an undefined, unwinnable War on Terror, while imagining, as Bush declared, that “it will end in a way and at an hour of our choosing.”

THE YEARS AFTER September 11 plunged us into the rough stream of history. Shock after shock followed that first one: the militarization of the homeland; the Iraq War, with its early arrogance

and prolonged agony; the use of torture, which undermined Bush’s every high-flown phrase; the financial crisis, which destroyed Americans’ wealth and trust in the system; the return of the Taliban in Afghanistan, the emergence

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of the Islamic State in Iraq and Syria, and the rise of right-wing populism in America; Donald Trump’s frantic assaults on democracy; and the coronavirus pandemic, which has killed well over 200 times as many Americans as the terrorist attacks did.

In light of this history, September 11 wasn’t a sui generis event coming out of a clear blue sky. It was the first warning that the 21st century would not bring boundless peace and prosperity. Al-Qaeda was less a primitive throwback

to the Middle Ages than an augury of the anti-liberal politics and virulent nationalism that would soon reach around the world, even to America, where the hijackers once aimed their blows.

And yet they didn’t win. After dominating geopolitics in the years following September 11, radical Islamism has, for now at least, receded as a strategic threat. It is no longer normal to hear of mass-casualty suicide bombings in Baghdad and Peshawar, or East African shopping malls turned into shooting galleries, or vans driven into European crowds. Nothing close to the scale of September 11 has occurred on American soil in the past 20 years. During that period, the U.S. spent about \$3 trillion on counterterrorism. Some of that money now seems well spent. Recognizing what truly protected us is as important as rejecting what only failed and shamed us.

Gennie Gambale is buried in Brooklyn’s Green-Wood Cemetery. The remains of 78 others murdered on the same day lie near her. Two decades after September 11, we’re no longer those Americans who believed such things would never happen to us, and who, when they did happen, went boldly overseas to rid the world of monsters. Experts now see white-nationalist terrorism as a greater domestic threat than Islamist terrorism. The new fight is for our own democracy. It will require all the restraint and purpose and wisdom that we struggled to muster when the enemy wasn’t us. *A*

George Packer is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



Today, Italian takeout. Tomorrow, Italian vacation.

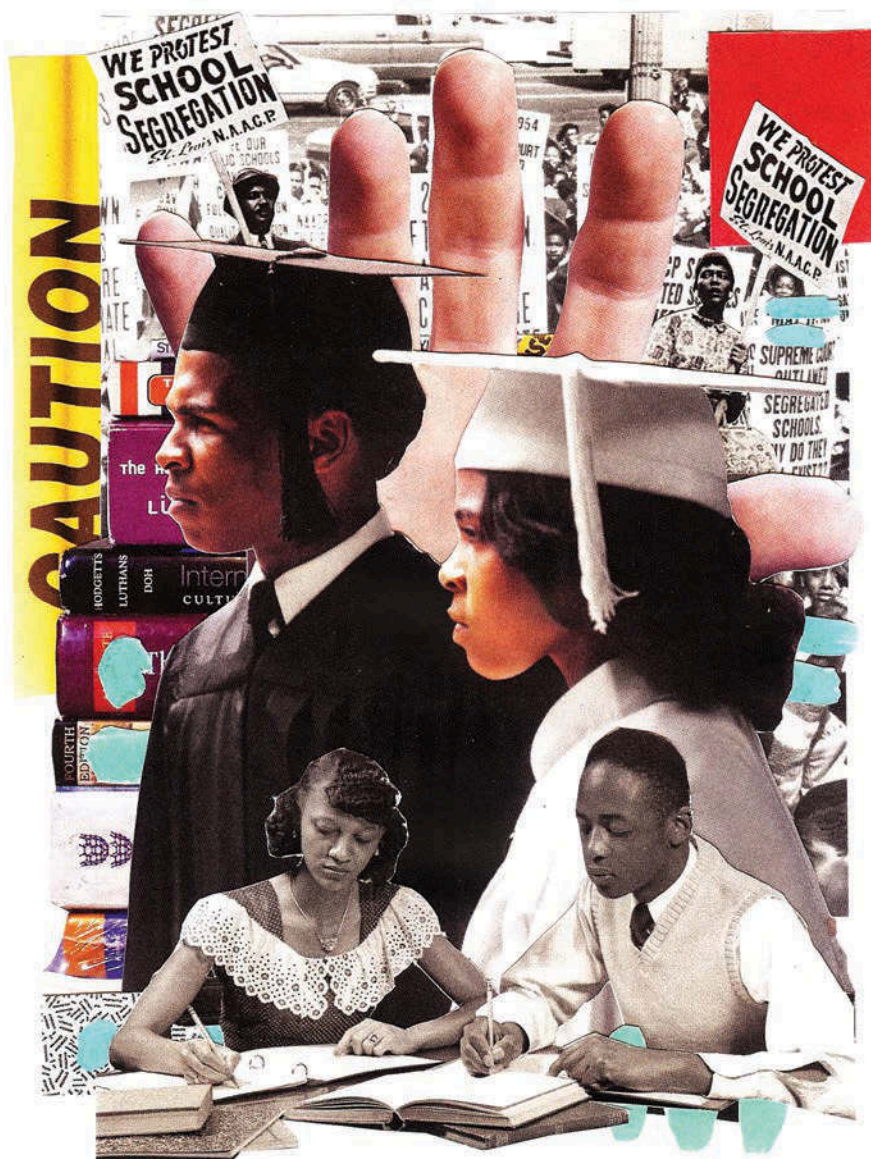
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THIS IS THE END OF AFFIRMATIVE ACTION

*We have to face the reality that our education system is,
and always has been, separate and unequal.*

BY ADAM HARRIS

O

One afternoon, during my freshman year at Alabama A&M University, my homework was piling up, and I was feeling antsy. I needed a change of scenery from Foster Hall. I'd heard that the library at the University of Alabama at Huntsville, 10 minutes away, was open three hours longer than our own. So I loaded up my backpack, ran down the stairs—the dorm's elevator was busted—and headed across town.

Founded in 1875 to educate Black students who had been shut out of American higher education, A&M was a second home for me. My mom had gone there; my uncle had been a drum major in the '80s; my sister was on the volleyball team. But when you're home long enough, you start to notice flaws: The classroom heaters were always breaking down, and the campus shuttle never seemed to run on time when it was coldest out. When I arrived at UAH, I was shocked. The buildings looked new, and fountains burst from man-made ponds. The library had books and magazines I'd never heard of—including the one for which I now write.

Something else quickly became obvious: Almost every student I saw at UAH was white. That day, a little more than a decade ago, was my introduction to the bitter reality that there are two tracks in American higher education. One has money and confers prestige, while the other—the one that Black students tend to tread—does not.

H. ARMSTRONG ROBERTS / GETTY; PICTORIAL PARADE / HULTON ARCHIVE / GETTY; MARTY CAIVANO / DIGITAL FIRST MEDIA / BOULDER DAILY CAMERA / GETTY; NATIONAL ARCHIVE / GETTY

The United States has stymied Black education since the country's founding. In Alabama in the 1830s, you could be fined \$500 for teaching a Black child. Later, bans were replaced by segregation, a system first enforced by custom, then by state law. Entrepreneurial Black educators opened their own colleges, but as a 1961 report by the U.S. Commission on Civil Rights pointed out, these schools were chronically underfunded. The report called for more federal money for institutions that did not discriminate against Black students. Nothing much came of it.

But as the civil-rights movement gained traction, white schools started reckoning with a legacy of exclusion. For the first time, they began to make a real effort to offer Black students an equal shot at higher education, through a strategy called affirmative action.

President John F. Kennedy had used the phrase in a 1961 executive order requiring government contractors to “take affirmative action to ensure that applicants are employed, and employees are treated during employment, without regard to their race, creed, color, or national origin.” The goal was to diversify the federal workforce and, crucially, to begin to correct for a legacy of discrimination against applicants of color.

Colleges that adopted affirmative action in their admissions programs quickly faced challenges. White applicants filed lawsuits, claiming that to take race into account in hiring or education in any way discriminated against them. A long process of erosion began, undermining the power of affirmative action to right historical wrongs.

Today, race-conscious admissions policies are weak, and used by only a smattering of the most highly selective programs. Meanwhile, racial stratification is, in many places, getting worse.

Nearly half of the students who graduate from high school in Mississippi are Black, but in 2019, Black students made up just 10 percent of the University of Mississippi's freshman class. The share of Black students there has shrunk steadily since 2012. In Alabama, a third of graduating high-school students are Black, but in 2019 just 5 percent of the student body at Auburn University, one of the state's premier public institutions, was Black. While total enrollment has grown by thousands, Auburn now has fewer Black undergraduates than it did in 2002.

Over the past two decades, the percentage of Black students has fallen at almost 60 percent of the “101 most selective public colleges and universities,” according to a report by the nonprofit Education Trust.

The Supreme Court may soon hear a case—*Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard*—that could mark the definitive end of affirmative action in higher education nationwide. If the Court takes the case, the plaintiffs will argue that under no circumstances should race be taken into consideration in college admissions. They will make this argument before a conservative majority that many observers believe is sympathetic to this view.

If the majority dismisses what remains of the nation's experiment with affirmative action, the United States will have to face the reality that its system of higher education is, and always has been, separate and unequal.

TO UNDERSTAND the loss of race-conscious admissions, we must first appreciate what it accomplished—and what it didn't.

In 1946, President Harry Truman commissioned a comprehensive report on the state of American higher education.

TODAY, RACE-CONSCIOUS ADMISSIONS POLICIES ARE WEAK, AND USED BY ONLY A SMATTERING OF THE MOST HIGHLY SELECTIVE PROGRAMS.

The study found that 75,000 Black students were enrolled in America's colleges, and about 85 percent of them went to poorly funded Black institutions. “The ratio of expenditures of institutions for whites to those of institutions for Negroes,” it noted, “ranged from 3 to 1 in the District of Columbia to 42 to 1 in Kentucky.”

Affirmative action jump-started Black enrollment at majority-white colleges. And the overall number of Black graduates boomed—more than doubling from the early 1970s to the mid-'90s. But the drive to reform higher education had slowed, and by the end of that period it was running on fumes.

Affirmative action was hobbled almost from the start, in large part because of a case brought against the regents of the University of California. In 1973, Allan Bakke, a white man in his early 30s,

was rejected by the UC Davis School of Medicine. He was rejected by 10 other medical schools as well, and again by UC Davis in 1974, perhaps because he was considered too old to begin training for medicine. But that's not how Bakke saw it. UC Davis had apportioned 16 out of its 100 seats for applicants from underrepresented groups, and Bakke sued, arguing that the program violated his rights guaranteed by the Fourteenth Amendment, as well as Title VI of the Civil Rights Act, which bars entities receiving federal funds from discrimination. The California Supreme Court agreed, ruling that colleges could not consider race in admissions.

When the Supreme Court heard oral arguments on October 12, 1977, the courtroom was packed. Newspapers hailed *Bakke* as the most important civil-rights case since *Brown v. Board of Education*. The Court ultimately released six different opinions, a judicial rarity. Four justices agreed, in some form, with Bakke that the university's affirmative-action strategy violated Title VI because it capped the number of white students at 84. Four other justices argued that the strategy was permissible. The decision came down to one man: Justice Lewis F. Powell Jr.

Powell's opinion was a compromise. Yes, institutions could consider race, but only for the sake of general diversity. In Powell's view, affirmative action was not a way of righting historical—and ongoing—wrongs against Black people; it was a way to achieve diversity, a compelling state interest because it benefited all students.

Time and again, courts have upheld Powell's rationale. As a result, schools have not been

able to design affirmative-action programs to redress discrimination against Black students, or to systematically increase their share of the student body. Wary of running afoul of the law, schools that have enacted affirmative-action programs have done so too timidly to make a real difference. Only in rare cases have these programs accomplished much more than keeping the Black share of the student body at pre-*Bakke* percentages.

Perhaps the best that can be said for this neutered version of affirmative action is that, in states where the practice has been banned, the picture is even bleaker. In 2006, Michigan prohibited the consideration of race in admissions at public colleges and universities. Black students made up 9 percent of the University of Michigan before the ban, and 4 percent a few years after it went into effect. The number has hovered there ever since.

AFFIRMATIVE ACTION has been a veil obscuring the truth about American higher education. It has never been that hard to see through, for those who tried, but removing it could force the nation at large to recognize the disparities in our system, and to search for better mechanisms to make college equitable.

One way to make a real difference would be to support the institutions that Black students have historically attended, and that still produce an outsize share of Black professionals.

Black colleges do more with less for those who have always had less. But their finances are precarious. A 2018 report by the Government Accountability Office found that the

median endowment at Black colleges was half the size of median endowments at comparable white colleges. In some cases, states are supposed to match federal funds to historically Black colleges and universities, but they often simply choose not to. From 2010 to 2012, one report found, Black land-grant colleges were denied more than \$56 million in state money. A bipartisan legislative committee in Tennessee showed this year that the state had shorted Tennessee State University, the Black college in Nashville, by hundreds of millions of dollars in matching funds since the 1950s.

There are 102 HBCUs—many with stories like Tennessee State’s. The scale of harm is devastating. Wealth accumulates, and Black colleges have been blocked from building it.

Philanthropists have recently stepped in to fill some of the gaps. MacKenzie Scott, Jeff Bezos’s ex-wife, donated hundreds of millions of dollars to 22 HBCUs last year. In several cases, the gift represented the largest single donation the school had ever received. But even some of those largest-ever donations were relatively small—\$5 million or \$10 million. These are sums that would not merit press releases at some predominantly white institutions.

Perhaps those institutions—the ones that, for years, barred Black students’ entry while profiting from slavery and Jim Crow; the ones that were lavished with state funding denied to Black colleges—now have a responsibility to provide that aid to HBCUs.

Some colleges are already examining their legacies of slavery and discrimination. In

2003, the president of Brown, Ruth Simmons (the first Black person to lead an Ivy League school), appointed a committee to explore the university’s relationship with the slave trade. After Brown learned that it had profited from the infernal institution, the question became:

BLACK
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What should be done? Could the school go beyond the inevitable campus memorial and conferences on slavery?

In 2019, Georgetown students voted to tax themselves—in the form of a \$27.20 fee, in honor of the 272 people the university sold in 1838 to save itself from financial ruin. The money would go to benefit those people’s descendants. But symbolic reparations that depend on student initiatives—including contributions from Black students—are not the best way to make amends. A few months later, the university said it would provide the funding itself.

These schools should make a bigger sacrifice, by redistributing some of their own endowment funds—the unrestricted bequests, at least—to Black colleges, or to support Black students. Flagship state institutions—places like the University of Mississippi, which just reported a record endowment of \$775 million—could share some of the wealth they

accumulated during the years they denied Black students enrollment.

The primary responsibility for repairing the legacy of higher education, however, lies with the government. It could set up scholarship funds and loan-forgiveness programs for Black students. States could redistribute endowments themselves, or give institutions that enroll more minority students a greater share of the education budget.

The United States has never atoned for what it has done to hamper the progress of Black people. The country has provided again and again for white students. Now it must do the same for those whom it has held back.

THIS SPRING, I traveled home—back to Alabama A&M. The campus looked sharp. I was impressed to see that the old shuttles had been replaced with three new electric buses. I asked my wife to snap a picture of me just as a landscaper pulled up to manicure some flower beds.

We drove across town to UAH, where the campus was bustling and the students were still mostly white. There was a new building I didn’t recognize. Instead of three electric buses, there were six charging stations for electric vehicles in front of the library. They can be used free of charge by all students, faculty, and staff.

For every step forward at A&M, UAH was taking two. *A*

Adam Harris is a staff writer at The Atlantic. This article has been adapted from his new book, The State Must Provide: Why America’s Colleges Have Always Been Unequal—And How to Set Them Right.



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WHY MILLENNIALS ARE SO OBSESSED WITH DOGS

The only thing getting me through my 30s is a cranky, agoraphobic chihuahua named Midge.

BY AMANDA MULL

Since the beginning of the coronavirus pandemic, I have asked one question more than any other. It's come up time and again, day and night, as frequently in my post-vaccination spring and summer as it did in the dark moments of the pandemic's first wave: Are you my boobo?

The question is never answered by Midge, my agoraphobic chihuahua, but the answer is obvious. She's been my boobo since 2018, when I brought her home from a cat shelter, where she had been stashed by a Long Island dog rescue after her foster family gave her back—she didn't like them, or anyone, and cats aren't looking for new friends. At 12 pounds, she is twice as big as the most desirable chihuahuas, and she has a moderately bad personality, which is maybe why the puppy mill where she spent the first year of her life decided it didn't want any more of her robust and extremely rude babies. Now almost 5 years old, she has grown to tolerate me. I ask her questions she doesn't answer—if she's my boobo

(yes), if she's a big girl (relatively speaking), if she has a kibble tummy (a little bit).

Since last March, Midge and I have been testing the bounds of what it means to live in my very small apartment together. In many ways, she's been a perfect pandemic pal: She hates interacting with others; she loves to sit on the couch; she long ago assessed sneezes as an existential threat. Whether she was sitting on a blanket in the kitchen while I cooked, frowning at me from a safe distance while I did yoga, or watching me do chores from beneath the leaves of her favorite enormous tropical houseplant, she bore witness to a year I spent otherwise alone. Every day, she climbed up the back of the couch to snooze atop its rear cushions, her face pointed toward mine at eye level while I worked at the kitchen table.

In a year when time felt slippery, Midge kept track of it—waking me up for breakfast, waging a nightly campaign for dinner, huffing and snorting and pacing until I got up from work to play fetch with her stuffed crocodile for a few minutes. Many days, she was the only living thing I spoke to,

and the only one I touched. She tolerated most of my hugs, and once, when I was in the depths of late-winter depression, she let me pick her up and hold her tiny, warm chest to my forehead for a few seconds. Her big brown eyes look dismayed and embarrassed after these displays of affection, which is usually enough to make me laugh. I tell her she's a good girl and try not to think about how much worse the past year would have been without her.

Or, for that matter, the past three years. The 2020 pet-adoption surge was sharp: Shelters emptied and rescue groups ran out of dogs as the work-from-home set welcomed new companions for themselves and their kids. Among adults under 40, who accounted for the majority of pet adoptions, the pandemic-era spike in demand was anomalous in its intensity, not its trajectory. Millennials recently overtook Boomers as the largest pet-owning cohort of Americans; by some estimates, more than half of them have a dog. The pet-ownership rate is even higher among those with a college education and a stable income—the same people who are most likely to delay

marriage, parenthood, and homeownership beyond the timelines set by previous generations. Dogs, long practical partners in rural life or playmates for affluent children, have become a life stage unto themselves.

That dogs' roles are changing isn't itself so surprising. Humans and canines have been molding themselves to each other's needs for tens of thousands of years, helping ensure the mutual survival of both species. The question is why the relationship is changing so quickly right now. For America's newest adopters, a dog can be many things: a dry run for parenthood, a way of putting down roots when traditional milestones feel out of reach, an enthusiastic housemate for people likely to spend stretches of their 20s and 30s living alone. An even more primary task, though, is helping soothe the psychic wounds of modern life.

MIDGE'S ADOPTION WAS both planned and impulsive. In 2017, I went apartment hunting for my first place of my own in New York, looking only at buildings that allowed dogs, even though I didn't have one. Then, I waited. How do

you know if you're ready to keep another mammal alive? I had no idea, but I found myself at a party in early 2018, in a professional rut and at the end of a relationship. A friend notorious for her flakiness showed up late, and when she arrived, she had in tow both her own happy mutt and another that she was watching for the weekend. A little bomb exploded in my head—if she could avoid killing two dogs simultaneously, surely I could manage one. I spent the next few days perusing Perfinder.com. Midge was on my lap on the B48 bus the next weekend.

I would have denied it at the time, but I got a dog because I was frustrated with everything else. The benchmarks that I was raised to believe would make me a real, respectable adult seemed foreign, even though I was 32, the same age when my mother, already a married homeowner working for the employer she'd have for the rest of her career, became pregnant with me. This particular Millennial sob story is familiar by now: Thanks to wealth inequality and wage stagnation and rising housing and child-care costs and student loans and all the rest, we're the first generation to do worse than our parents. People like me, who grew up middle-class, don't tend to suffer the most severe economic fallout. But the existential crisis provoked by these changes can still feel acute. All your life, you were told that if you worked to follow a particular path, you would be rewarded. Then the path was bulldozed to make room for luxury condos.

When I adopted Midge, I had no clear view of a future beyond my one-bedroom apartment, let alone a future involving a family of my own,

and I still don't. As I looked around for an opening through which to push my life forward, the gap that was available to me was roughly the size of a hefty chihuahua. Dogs are, for some of us, a perfect balm for purgatorial anxieties. If you have time and care to give, they love freely, they put you on a schedule, they direct your attention and affection and idle thoughts toward something outside yourself. The desire to turn outward and spend energy nurturing others is a mark of emotional maturity, but that nurturing needs a vessel.

People without kids adopt pets not only as a dry run for eventual children but for lots of other reasons, too, including, as an outlet for caring impulses that have nothing to do with parenthood. They also lavish their dogs with privileges that, in America, have historically been reserved for other people: Dogs now sleep in the same bed as their humans at night; they have birthday parties; they go see their friends at day care.

But for the particular rung of the American socioeconomic ladder that has pursued dog ownership most fervently in

recent years—young, urban professionals, especially white ones—dogs serve yet another purpose: They're a class marker and a way of coping with deep status anxiety. Dogs broadcast stability—Midge is not nearly as expensive as a child or a single-family home, but she is an indicator that I have mastered enough elements of my own life to introduce some joyful chaos into it.

Yet while dogs can be an effective therapy for the stresses of modern life, especially as it grows lonelier and more precarious, their friendship isn't always



available to those who could use it most. For people clawing to maintain basic stability (instead of signaling that they've attained a middle-class version of it), the barriers to dog ownership are larger than simply having the disposable income to feed another mouth. A lot of subsidized and low-income housing refuses pets or limits the type and number that residents can have, and homeless shelters generally require people to abandon their pets to get a place to sleep. Companionship, whether with a pet or other people, is elemental to human dignity; in America, it's easier to come by if you have money.

ACCORDING TO Pat Shipman, a paleoanthropologist and the author of the forthcoming book *Our Oldest Companions: The Story of the First Dogs*, humans and dogs have been living together for about 40,000 years, though for almost all that time, the relationship was primarily practical; we gave dogs food and heat from fire, and dogs helped us spot approaching danger and track prey.

As humans shared their hunting spoils, dogs had less need for their lupine ancestors' brutality, and more need, evolutionarily speaking, to appeal to people. As a result, long before we started breeding them, dogs shrank, their ears flopped, their tails curled—they became cute. They also acquired eyebrow muscles that gave them a much larger range of expressions than wolves, allowing them to better communicate with humans.

In *A Dog's History of the World: Canines and the Domestication of Humans*, Laura Hobgood shows how, along the way, dogs became vital players in humans' emotional lives. As smaller dogs suitable

for in-home pest control (and companionship) emerge in prehistoric fossil records, their burial sites reflect a high level of care: Dogs weren't just useful to humans; they were beloved. Still, the concept of a pet—a companion animal that plays no functional role in a household—is far more recent, dating back only about 3,000 years. The first pets tended to be tiny, manicured lapdogs, and were an extravagance of the wealthy; the ancient Pekingese breed, for example, was once legally reserved for members of the Chinese imperial court. For everybody else, the human-canine bond continued to be not only emotional but practical. (Many of the breeds now slotted into the working, sporting, hound, herding, and terrier groups at dog shows were in fact developed to perform specific tasks for agrarian families.)

Industrialization was the beginning of the end of that era for most dogs. Over time, as people left rural areas for cities, more of them began departing the home every day for work or school—and much of daily life suddenly took place where dogs weren't allowed to go. But if dogs were with humans less, that didn't mean that humans no longer needed their companionship—in some ways, we may have needed it more. "Having pets helps people physically and psychologically," Shipman told me, rattling off research findings. Mental illness, incarceration, isolation, grief, post-traumatic stress disorder, autism—virtually all modern trials can be eased, in measurable ways, by the companionship of a dog.

Seen this way, it makes perfect sense that so many isolated, stressed-out people brought dogs into their life

during the pandemic. Dogs pull us out into the world, make us get some sun on our face, give us an opening to chat with our neighbors. After a year when serendipitous social interaction was hard to come by, it returned to my life in the form of Cowboy, a then-14-week-old puppy who moved

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into an apartment on my floor in February. While waiting for his vaccinations to be complete (same, buddy), Cowboy's owners ran him up and down the empty hall a couple of times a day to work out some of his puppy energy. That's how I met him, and after a few encounters, he would scratch at my door every day to say hi.

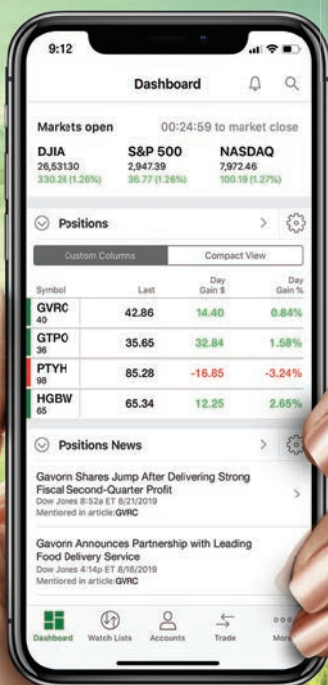
At some point soon, Cowboy's dads will go back to in-person work, and so will I. Visions have danced in my head of loading Midge into a BabyBjörn and carrying her everywhere I go, like a real asshole. Some minority of pet owners may be able to do just that, as anxious employers try to cajole people back into the office and prevent them from jumping ship with promises of pet-friendly work spaces. But many people—even many

dog lovers—will likely balk at these reverse-engineered solutions. Contemporary offices are barely hospitable to humans, let alone a new population of four-legged co-workers.

What if, instead of forcing dogs to fit our modern lives, we set about making modern life more hospitable to pets? Doing so would require us to acknowledge that our connection to other living things—and to the natural world at large—isn't a luxury, but an essential element of what makes us human. Fittingly, virtually all of the changes that would make having a pet easier would make life more humane for people too: flexible working conditions, for example, and affordable housing, and more public green space. (That the list of dog-friendly circumstances is basically identical to the things that would make it easier for more Americans to have kids isn't a coincidence. Dogs aren't children, of course, but their popularity among those of childbearing age is indicative of the deep emotional commitments that people rush toward when given the chance.)

I often look down at Midge—as she weaves between my feet while I cook, or when she's sprawled in a sunny spot, tongue hanging out—and marvel at the little animal that lives in my apartment. She knows what bedtime means, and she has somehow learned to tell whether I'm opening the fridge to get a drink or to get food, even before I touch anything. She doesn't know how she got here, or who I am, beyond the fact that I care for her, and she takes care of me. *A*

Amanda Mull is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



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BOBBY McILVAINE, WITH HIS PARENTS, HELEN AND BOB SR.,
AT HIS PRINCETON GRADUATION IN 1997. BOBBY'S BODY WAS
FOUND IN THE WRECKAGE OF THE TWIN TOWERS.

Twenty Years Gone

One family's
struggle to
make sense
of 9/11

By
Jennifer
Senior

When Bobby McIlvaine died on September 11, 2001, his desk at home was a study in plate tectonics, coated in shifting piles of leather-bound diaries and yellow legal pads. He'd kept the diaries since he was a teenager, and they were filled with the usual diary things—longings, observations, frustrations—while the legal pads were marbled with more variety: aphoristic musings, quotes that spoke to him, stabs at fiction.

The yellow pads appeared to have the earnest beginnings of two different novels. But the diaries told a different kind of story. To the outside world, Bobby, 26, was a charmer, a striver, a furnace of ambition. But inside, the guy was a sage and a sap—philosophical about disappointments, melancholy when the weather changed, moony over girlfriends.

Less than a week after his death, Bobby's father had to contend with that pitiless still life of a desk. And so he began distributing the yellow legal pads, the perfect-bound diaries: to Bobby's friends; to Bobby's girlfriend, Jen, to whom he was about to propose. Maybe, he told them, there was material in there that they could use in their eulogies.

One object in that pile glowed with more meaning than all the others: Bobby's very last diary. Jen took one look and quickly realized that her name was all over it. Could she keep it?

Bobby's father didn't think. He simply said yes. It was a reflex that he almost instantly came to regret. "This was a decision we were supposed to make together," his wife, Helen, told him. Here was an opportunity to savor Bobby's company one last time, to hear his *voice*, likely saying something new. In that sense, the diary wasn't like a recovered photograph. It raised the prospect, however brief, of literary resurrection. How, Helen fumed, could her husband not want to know Bobby's final thoughts—ones he may have scribbled as recently as the evening of September 10? And how could he not share her impulse to take every last molecule of what was Bobby's and reconstruct him?

"One missing piece," she told me recently, "was like not having an arm."

Over and over, she asked Jen to see that final diary. Helen had plenty of chances to bring it up, because Jen lived with the McIlvaines for a time after September 11,

unable to tolerate the emptiness of her own apartment. Helen was careful to explain that she didn't need the object itself. All she asked was that Jen selectively photocopy it.

Jen would say she'd consider it. Then nothing would happen. Helen began to plead. *I just want the words*, she'd say. *If Bobby's describing a tree, just give me the description of the tree.* Jen demurred.

The requests escalated, as did the rebuffs. They were having an argument now. Helen, Jen pointed out, already had Bobby's other belongings, other diaries, the legal pads.

When she finally left the McIlvaines' house for good, Jen slammed the door behind her, got into her car, and burst into tears. Shortly after, she wrote Helen a letter with her final answer: No, just no. If Helen wanted to discuss this matter any further, she'd have to do so in the presence of Jen's therapist.

Helen and her husband never saw Jen again. "She became a nonperson to me," Helen told me. Today, she can't so much as recall Jen's last name.

But for years, Helen thought about that diary. Her mind snagged on it like a nail; she needled her husband for giving it away; it became the subject of endless discussion in her "limping group," as she calls it, a circle of six mothers in suburban Philadelphia who'd also lost children, though not on September 11. They became indignant on her behalf. A number proposed, only half jokingly, that they break into Jen's apartment and liberate the diary. "You don't get any more memories," one of the women told me. "So anything written, any video, any card—you cling to that. That's all you're going to get for life."

The McIlvaines would have to make do with what they already had. Eventually, they did. Three words of Bobby's became the family motto: *Life loves on*. No one could quite figure out which diary or legal pad it came from, but no matter. Helen wears a silver bracelet engraved with this phrase, and her husband got it tattooed in curlicue script on his upper arm.

HERE I SHOULD NOTE that I know and love the McIlvaine family. On my brother's first day of college, he was assigned to a seven-person suite, and because he arrived last, Bobby became his roommate. My brother often thinks about what a small miracle that was: If he'd arrived just 30 minutes earlier, the suite would have been an isomer of itself, with the kids all shuffled in an entirely different configuration. But thanks to a happy accident of timing, my brother got to spend his nights chattering away with this singular kid, an old soul with a snappity-popping mind.

Eight years later, almost to the day, a different accident of timing would take Bobby's life. He and my brother were still roommates, but this time in a two-bedroom apartment in Manhattan, trying to navigate young adulthood.

Back when Bobby was still alive, I would occasionally see the McIlvaines. They struck me as maybe the nicest people on the planet. Helen taught reading to kids who needed extra help with it, mainly in a trailer in the parking lot of a Catholic high school. Bob Sr. was a teacher who specialized in working with troubled adolescents; for a decade, he'd also owned a bar. Jeff, Bobby's younger brother, was just a kid in those days, but he was always unreasonably good-natured when he turned up.

And Bobby: My God. The boy was incandescent. When he smiled it looked for all the world like he'd swallowed the moon.

Then, on the morning of September 11, 2001, Bobby headed off to a conference at Windows on the World, a restaurant in a building to which he seldom had reason to go, for a media-relations job at Merrill Lynch he'd had only since July. My brother waited and waited. Bobby never came home. From that point forward, I watched as everyone in the blast radius of this horrible event tried to make sense of it, tried to cope.

Early on, the McIlvaines spoke to a therapist who warned them that each member of their family would grieve differently. *Imagine that you're all at the top of a mountain*, she told them, *but you all have broken bones, so you can't help each other. You each have to find your own way down.*

It was a helpful metaphor, one that may have saved the McIlvaines' marriage. But when I mentioned it to Roxane Cohen Silver, a psychology professor at UC Irvine who's spent a lifetime studying the effects of sudden, traumatic loss, she immediately spotted a problem with it: "That suggests everyone will *make it* down," she told me. "Some people never get down the mountain at all."

This is one of the many things you learn about mourning when examining it at close range: It's idiosyncratic, anarchic, polychrome. A lot of the theories you read about grief are great, beautiful even, but they have a way of erasing individual experiences. Every mourner has a very different story to tell.

That therapist was certainly right, however, in the most crucial sense: After September 11, those who had been close to Bobby all spun off in very different directions. Helen stifled her grief, avoiding the same supermarket she'd shopped in for years so that no one would ask how she was. Jeff, Bobby's lone sibling, had to force his way through the perdition of survivor's guilt. Bob Sr. treated his son's death as if it were an unsolved murder, a cover-up to be exposed. Something was fishy about 9/11.

And then there was Jen. She's married now, has two terrific kids, but she wonders sometimes, when she's quarreling with her husband or feeling exasperated with her life, what it would have been like if she'd been with Bobby all this time. I tracked her down in April, and of course she's nothing like the heartless villainess I had come to imagine her to be. That was just the story I'd told myself, the one I'd used to make sense of the senseless, to give shape to my own rage. Like I said: We all need our stories.

One thing I knew when I finally visited her, though: I wanted to see that diary. And I wanted the McIlvaines to see it too. "I'm not a saver," she said when we first met up for cocktails. My heart froze.

But she still had it, just so you know.

TELL ME ABOUT YOUR SON.

Helen welcomed this invitation the first time she heard it, because it focused her thinking, gave her an outlet for her grief. But soon it filled her with dread, and she felt herself straining under the weight of it. How can you possibly convey who your firstborn was or what he meant to you?

Helen usually starts by telling people that Bobby went to Princeton, but that's hardly because she's status-fixated. It's because she and Bob Sr. did not expect to have a child who went



to an Ivy League school. They both went to state schools in Pennsylvania, not even particularly well-known ones. Both of their kids were sporty. But when Bobby was 8, his third-grade teacher said to them—and they both remember her exact words—“Start saving your pennies.” This one’s education might cost you.

“The amount of things that had to go right for my brother to go to Princeton were, like, astronomical,” says Jeff, a high-school biology teacher and track coach in Somerdale, New Jersey. “To us, it was like someone from our family becoming the president.”

This is how everyone in the family remembers Bobby: as a sui generis creature, exceptional and otherworldly, descended from the heavens through a basketball hoop.

“THE ONLY THING I DO IS 9/11 STUFF,”
BOB McILVAINE SR. SAYS. “MY WHOLE BASIS
OF EVERYTHING REVOLVES AROUND THE DAY.”

He was an intense student. He was an even more intense athlete, competitive to the point of insolence. Writing in *The Philadelphia Inquirer* last year, Mike Sielski, an old high-school classmate of Bobby’s, described him as “all bones and acute angles and stiletto elbows” on the basketball court. It was a goose-pimpling story, one he had occasion to write because another classmate of theirs had unearthed 36 seconds of video from 1992, in which a teenage Bobby McIlvaine throws an immaculate pass that sets up an immaculate shot that flies right over the teenage head of ...

Kobe Bryant.

Bobby scored 16 points off Kobe and his team that day, in addition to setting up that floater.

When he arrived at college, Bobby retained a bit of that alpha-dog streak. He was still competitive, even while playing mindless, made-up dorm games. He wasn’t bashful about ribbing friends. He was tall and handsome and had a high level of confidence in his sense of style, which may or may not have been justified. “There were times you wanted him to step back and not be so serious and intense,” says Andre Parris, a former suitemate and one of Bobby’s closest friends. “But it was part of who and what he was, and what he thought he had to do to get ahead.”

What “getting ahead” meant to Bobby was complicated. Financial worries are all over his journals from those years (*I don’t feel like a real person sitting here with no money*, reads one typical entry). Yet he was conflicted about what it might take to make money, flummoxed by all the kids who were beating a dutiful path to business school. (*Is youth really just a hobby?* he asked about them, with evident pique.) He wanted to be a writer. Which paid nothing, obviously.

This conflict continued into his brief adulthood. He spent two years in book publishing before realizing that it was no way to make a living, and switched instead to corporate PR. He could still write his novels on the side.

But for all Bobby’s hunger and swagger, what he mainly exuded, even during his college years, was warmth, decency, a corkscrew quirkiness. He doted on girlfriends. He gave careful advice. His senior year, he took a modern-dance class because, well, why not? It would be fun. And different. His final project involved physically spelling out his girlfriend’s name.

That was just a lark, though. Bobby’s real intellectual passion was African American culture and history. After Bobby died, the McIlvaines got not one but two condolence notes from Toni Morrison, with whom he’d taken a class. The second came with the term paper he’d written for her. “It is certainly one of the more accomplished and insightful,” she wrote, “as was he.” His senior thesis received an honorable mention for the main prize in the department of African American studies.

At his funeral, Bobby's oldest friends spoke of what a role model he was to them. I was five years older than Bobby, which meant I mainly saw him as charming and adorable, intelligent and unstoppable.

But strangely, I wanted to impress him too. When I started my job at *New York* magazine, writing short features in the theater section each week, Bobby gave me grief about ending each one of them with a quote. At first I was annoyed, defensive—the *little shit*—but in hindsight, it's amazing that I cared so much about this 22-year-old's opinion, and even more amazing that he'd read me attentively enough to discover an incipient tic. To this day, I credit Bobby with teaching me a valuable lesson: If you're going to cede the power of the last word to someone else, you'd better be damn sure that person deserves it.

BOB McILVAINE SR. cries easily and regularly when you speak to him. Everyone in the family knows this and has grown accustomed to it—his grief lives close to the surface, heaving up occasionally for air. He cried at our first lunch after the McIlvaines picked me up at the train station a few months ago; he cried again just minutes into our first chat when the two of us were alone; he cried in a recent interview with Spike Lee for a documentary series about 9/11 on HBO.

In talking with Bob Sr., something heartbreaking and rudely basic dawned on me: September 11 may be one of the

most-documented calamities in history, but for all the spools of disaster footage we've watched, we still know practically nothing about the last moments of the individual dead. It's strange, when you think about it, that an event so public could still be such a punishing mystery. Yet it is, and it is awful—the living are left to persevere, to let their imaginations run amok in their midnight corrals.

For Bob Sr., what that meant was wondering where Bobby was and what he was doing when the chaos began. For years, that was all he could think about. The idea of Bobby suffering tortured him. Was he incinerated? Was he asphyxiated? Or even worse? "I think Bobby jumped," he shouted up the stairs one day to his wife. The thought nearly drove Helen mad.

Over time, it became clear that Bobby didn't jump. Bobby's was one of fewer than 100 civilian corpses recovered from the wreckage. But it haunted Bob Sr. that he never saw the body. At the morgue on September 13, the pathologist strongly advised him against viewing it. Only years later—four? five? he can no longer remember—did he finally screw up the courage to go to the medical examiner's office in New York City and get the official report.

That's when everything changed. "My whole thesis—everything I jump into now—is based upon his injuries," he tells me. "Looking at the body, I came to the conclusion that he was walking in and bombs went off."

A controlled demolition, he means. That is how he thinks Bobby died that day, and how the towers eventually fell: from a controlled demolition. It was an inside job, planned by the U.S. government, not to justify the war in Iraq—that was a bonus—but really, ultimately, to destroy the 23rd floor, because that's where the FBI was investigating the use of gold that the United

AFTER BOBBY DIED, HELEN McILVAINE BEGGED HIS GIRLFRIEND, JEN, TO SHARE HIS FINAL DIARY WITH THE FAMILY, TO NO AVAIL.



States had unlawfully requisitioned from the Japanese during World War II, which it then leveraged to bankrupt the Soviet Union. The planes were merely for show.

DOES A MAN wake up on September 12, 2001, and believe such a thing? No. This belief takes shape over the span of years, many years.

That first year, Bob Sr. was numb. His sole objective was to get through each day. But he eventually got involved in a group called 9/11 Families for Peaceful Tomorrows, protesting the wars in Afghanistan and Iraq. “It opened up my life,” he tells me. “I became very active. That’s how I grieved. It was perfect.”

Before Bobby went to Princeton, Bob Sr. had been indifferent to politics, voting sometimes for Democrats and sometimes for Republicans—including, he thinks, Ronald Reagan. “I was not a well-read person,” he says. “I owned a bar in the city. If I even mentioned the word *progressive*, my customers probably would have shot me.”

But then Bobby started taking classes with Princeton’s glamorous tenured radicals. He started writing for the school’s *Progressive Review*. His father devoured everything he wrote. Soon, he had Bob Sr. reading Howard Zinn’s *A People’s History of the United States* and *Z Magazine*, the radical monthly. Bob Sr. has been interested in politics ever since. “That’s all because of Bobby.”

So this anti-war activity? It *was* perfect—a natural outlet for him.

But as time wore on, Bob Sr. got impatient. In 2004, he went down to Washington to hear Condoleezza Rice speak to the 9/11 Commission, and her testimony—or lack thereof, he’d say—so enraged him that he left in a huff, cursing in the halls of Congress. “I wanted answers,” he explains. Yet no answers were forthcoming. That’s when he realized: The government was hiding something. “I became militant,” he says. “To this day, I’m very militant.”

Bob Sr. is a bespectacled, soft-spoken man, slender and slightly stooped. But his affect is deceptive. We’re sitting in the upstairs den of the McIlvaines’ three-bedroom home in Oreland, Pennsylvania, the same house where Bobby and Jeff grew up. It’s sweet, modest, cluttered with family pictures. But this room has been transformed into a 9/11 research bunker, stuffed with books and carefully organized files—by event, subject, country. The largest piece of art on the wall is a world map freckled with pins marking every country that’s invited Bob Sr. to tell his story.

“I speak out so much, the word just spreads,” he tells me. “I’ll show you Italy.” Pictures and clippings from a Rome film festival, he means, because he appeared in the documentary *Zero: Inchiesta sull’11 Settembre*. He got to walk the red carpet. “The Russians came over. They spent two days here, wanted to hear what I had to say.” Meaning Russian state news agencies. They parked themselves on the McIlvaines’ back deck. “France came here, stayed a few days to talk.” Same deal, though he doesn’t remember which media outfit. (“My dad is practically a celebrity in that community,” Jeff told me.)

Crucial to Bob Sr.’s understanding of September 11—that it was the cynical skulduggery of the U.S. government, not a grisly act of terrorism by jihadists using commercial planes filled with helpless civilians—is the work of Architects & Engineers for 9/11 Truth, which popularized the idea that jet fuel couldn’t burn at a high enough temperature to melt beams into

Bobby’s daily planner
is cluttered with
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Whatever he was doing was
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merit its own entry.

molten steel. This is, it should go without saying, contrary to all observable fact.

But this theory is what Bob Sr. is eager to illustrate for me. He has visuals prepared, lots of building diagrams. I tell him we’ll get there; I just want to ask a few more questions about those early days—

He’s disappointed. “Everything I’ve done in my life is based upon those seconds.” This is something he very much wants to discuss.

And so we discuss it. Only a preplanned detonation, he argues, could bring down those towers, and only a lobby embroidered with explosives could explain the injuries to Bobby’s body. He has the full medical examiner’s report.

It is very upsetting to read. Most of Bobby’s head—that beautiful face—was missing, as was most of his right arm. The details are rendered in generic diagrams and the dispassionate language of pathology (“Absent: R upper extremity, most of head”), as well as a chilling pair of responses on a standard checklist.

Hair color: None.

Eye color: None.

But a subtle thing made Bob Sr. think something was amiss. The report describes many lacerations and fractures, but they appear almost entirely on the front of Bobby’s body. The back of his corpse is basically described as pristine, besides multiple fractures to what remained of his head.

The story we’ve told ourselves all these years is that Bobby had already left the building when the planes hit. Bobby didn’t work in the World Trade Center; from what we could piece together, he’d gone to Windows on the World simply to help a new colleague set up for a morning presentation at an all-day conference, not to attend it. So Bobby did his part, was our assumption, then said his goodbyes and was making his way back to nearby Merrill Lynch when he was suddenly killed in the street by flying debris.

Bob Sr. doesn’t buy it. If that were true—if Bobby were moving *away* from the World Trade Center—wouldn’t he have fallen forward? Wouldn’t there be injuries on his *back*? “If you’re running away, it’d be more of a crushing type of thing,” he tells me. “Probably every bone in his body would be breaking.”

I tell him I’m not a pathologist, but it seems just as plausible to me that he heard the roaring sound of a plane flying too low

and too fast, or maybe the sound of a hijacked aircraft hitting the North Tower itself, and turned around to see what had happened and never knew what hit him.

He rejects this explanation. "My theory is he was walking *into* the building at the time, because he had the conference up there."

"I thought his conference started at 8:30?" I ask. The first plane hit at 8:46 a.m. That would have meant Bobby was arriving late.

"I thought it started at 9," Bob Sr. says.

"Isn't there a way to find out?" I ask.

"You know, to tell you the truth, I never ..."

He'd never checked.

BREAKFAST AND REGISTRATION for the conference began at 8 o'clock. Opening remarks were scheduled for 8:30. Bobby's colleague was scheduled to speak at 8:40. The full brochure is available on the 9/11 Memorial & Museum's website.

When I eventually visit Jen—she of the purloined diary, the woman to whom Bobby was about to be engaged—she shows me the daily planner that was sitting on his desk at Merrill. It's cluttered with appointments. But the day of September 11 is blank. Whatever he was doing was not significant enough to merit its own entry.

My brother also tells me that he still has the note Bob Sr. left for him on his kitchen table on Thursday, September 13. It said that an investigator with the New York City Police Department, Joe Gagliardi, had just come by to drop off the wallet they'd pulled from Bobby's pocket. One line in particular stood out. *He was found on the perimeter.* Not near the lobby.

"Was he really?" Bob Sr. says when I phone him and ask him about the note. He'd completely forgotten that he'd written it. "If that's true, that's great." He thinks for a moment. "Though the perimeter—he still could have been 10 feet away. He certainly wasn't 100 feet from the building."

I then tell him about the conference schedule, which actually did leave open the possibility that he was 100 feet from the building. If he'd left before his colleague started speaking—or the opening remarks—he could have been quite close to his office at Merrill Lynch, a five-minute walk away. Bob Sr. takes it all in. He repeats that he finds Bobby's injuries too extreme, too savage, to be caused by flying debris. "But you know what?" he finally says. "That's no longer relevant to me. My whole thing is who did it and why. It's been 20 years and I *still* can't get any answers."

IT TAKES ME some time, but eventually I summon the courage to ask Bob Sr. an obvious question: What makes his claims about the destruction of the World Trade Center more credible than the claims of, for instance, Donald Trump supporters who say the 2020 election was stolen?

"I can believe it was stolen!" he tells me. "But I'm not going to go around preaching that, because *I don't know*. Because I'm doing *my* homework." Bob Sr. is always reading. His latest is a biography of Allen Dulles. "Probably 99.9 percent of the people that you will find in those radical groups—the Oath Keepers, whatever—they really haven't done any research."

But then he adds that he sympathizes with Trump voters, as much as he despises Trump himself. "This country hasn't done

anything for them in such a long time. So you can't blame them for voting for him."

BOB SR. ASKS if I would like to see Bobby's wallet. I didn't realize he had it, but he does, stuffed in a biohazard bag, itself entombed in a plastic box in the room that once belonged to Bobby. He carefully opens them for me.

"Helen and Jeff have never seen this," he tells me.

They haven't?

"No."

The wallet is covered in dust, still, and faintly redolent of that World Trade Center tang, a scent once so powerful that New Yorkers could smell it in their eyes. He starts pulling out a 26-year-old's modest possessions: a Pennsylvania driver's license, a Visa card, some kind of work or building ID, a library card. The wallet still contains \$13 in cash, but the money is disintegrating, almost completely rotted away.

"The only thing I do is 9/11 stuff," Bob Sr. says. "My whole basis of everything revolves around the day."

This is not, it should be said, anything like what Helen does with her days. A two-decade investigation into 9/11 was not part of her retirement plan. In one of our earliest conversations, she specifically told me that she'd walk across the United States to *not* discover some of the things that Bob Sr. has learned. So as he and I sit here, inspecting a wallet that she's never seen, I ask: Doesn't all this searching, this interrogating, have unhealthy consequences for his marriage?

He readily admits that it does: "We'd socialize and she'd catch me saying stuff, and she would go nuts. She'd say, 'Do not talk about 9/11.' But then someone would come up to me and say, 'Can I ask you about it?' And I'd start talking. Then she'd find out about it. She'd get so upset." They now tend to socialize separately. "I will talk 9/11 with anyone I see, if they want to talk about it," he says. "And I think that's why I don't have many friends. They're *afraid* I'm going to talk about it."

It may be hard to imagine why anyone would want to spend so much time immersed in the story, sensations, and forensics of his son's death. But for Bob Sr., that's precisely the point: to keep the grief close. "I don't want to get away from it," he tells me. He *wants* to stay at the top of the mountain. This is how he spends time in Bobby's company—by solving this crime, by exposing the truth about the abuses of American empire. "Doing what I'm doing, that's really helped me, because I think of him every day. Every time I talk, I talk about Bobby."

He's aware that there are other ways to spend time with Bobby that wouldn't be quite so excruciating. He could read his diaries, for example. To this day, he feels terrible that he handed that last one off to Jen. He felt so guilty about it for so long that he was



still mentioning it in interviews in 2011. A British newspaper referred to it as “the journal episode.”

“I’m just not that big on the journals,” he tells me. “They don’t mean that much to me.”

So what means the most to you? I ask.

“That he was murdered,” he says.

ON THE MORNING of September 11, Helen, the most stoic of the McIlvaines, was the only one who panicked. Jeff knew that his brother didn’t work in the World Trade Center. Bob Sr., who was teaching that day in the adolescent psych unit of a local hospital, treated the macabre, smoldering towers like a news event and, along with everyone else, began watching the coverage on TV.

Helen, however, took one look at the television and needed to sit down. She knew it seemed ridiculous, superstitious, but she’d spoken with Bobby the night before and forgotten to end the conversation the way she always did: “Be careful.” She’d later say those words to his casket as it was lowered into his grave.

By midday, when no one had heard from Bobby, everyone in the family felt like Helen. Yes, the cell towers were down in Lower Manhattan and the phones were working only sporadically, but surely Bobby, who could spend hours on the phone talking with his parents (*How do you guys find so much to talk about?* his friends always asked), would have found a way to call, and Jen had heard nothing, which *really* made no sense. Bobby had just asked her father for permission to marry her two days earlier.

In the late afternoon, Andre, his close friend and old suitemate, finally reached a woman at Merrill Lynch who awkwardly told him that Bobby and a colleague had been scheduled to attend a

conference at Windows on the World that morning and no one had heard from them since. Andre called the McIlvaines.

“That first night was probably worse than after we found out for sure that he’d died,” Jeff says, “because we had no idea what had happened. I couldn’t get that out of my head—that he was *in* that, you know?”

They slept in the den, the three of them. Jen stayed in her own living room that night, glued to the TV.

On Wednesday morning, Jeff and Bob Sr. were too agitated to remain in Oreland. They took a train to New York and made a fruitless tour of the city’s triage centers. Nothing. My brother stood on line at a missing-persons center; Andre ran a command center out of his apartment, working the phones and every lead he had; Jeff checked every website he could find. *Refresh, refresh, refresh.*

Jen sat and waited.

Bob Sr. spent Wednesday night in my brother and Bobby’s apartment, sleeping in his son’s bed.

The next day, Andre got a call from the NYPD, this time with grim news: Everyone needed to go immediately to the armory on Lexington Avenue.

Once again, Andre had to tell the McIlvaines. Helen calmly did as she was told. She treated these instructions as if she were an astronaut, doing whatever step came next if one of the modules of the International Space Station caught on fire.

The armory was a seething mass of the desperate. Hundreds of families were lined up outside, carrying posters with faces of their loved ones. A minister escorted my brother, Jen, Andre, and the McIlvaine family inside. Helen gave him Bobby’s name. A police officer approached her from across the room. “Are you the mother?”

Much of what followed was a blur. They were shown to a private room where grief counselors descended on them. Then something unusual happened: Rudy Giuliani walked in.

The mayor was unaccompanied. Without aides, without cameras, nothing. He looked genuinely relieved to have a family to console at that moment, with so many bereaved New Yorkers still twisting in limbo, posting flyers with pictures of the missing on lampposts, chain-link fences, hospital walls.

Giuliani embraced everyone. Then he took a seat opposite the McIlvaines. He uttered just five words: “Tell me about your son.”

IF BOB SR. chose to feed his grief, Helen chose to starve hers. She spoke about it with her limping group, because they understood. But she was determined not to be, as she puts it, “At-Least-I’m-Not-Helen.” Living with the impossible was hard enough. But to be in the position of having to console others about her misfortune, or to manage their discomfort, or, worst of all, to smile politely through their pity—that was more than she could bear. Helen can still rattle off a list of all the well-meaning things people said that stung.

No parent should bury a child.

You will never be the same.

I was with my children last night and realized you’ll never have something like that again.

Did people not realize that they were building a moat, not a bridge, when they said such things? That they were drawing attention to the pretty castles they lived in, their walls still lined with luck?

That first year was brutal. Once, while she was sitting in a diner with some friends, one of them started going on and on about the musical talents of her son. “I wanted to scream,” Helen says. “I had to get out. I couldn’t listen to somebody else talk about their child. For years. I couldn’t.”

The second year wasn’t much better. She tried going to Italy on a tour with a friend. She says she came across as cold, distant, strange. She dreaded the most innocuous question: *Have any kids?*

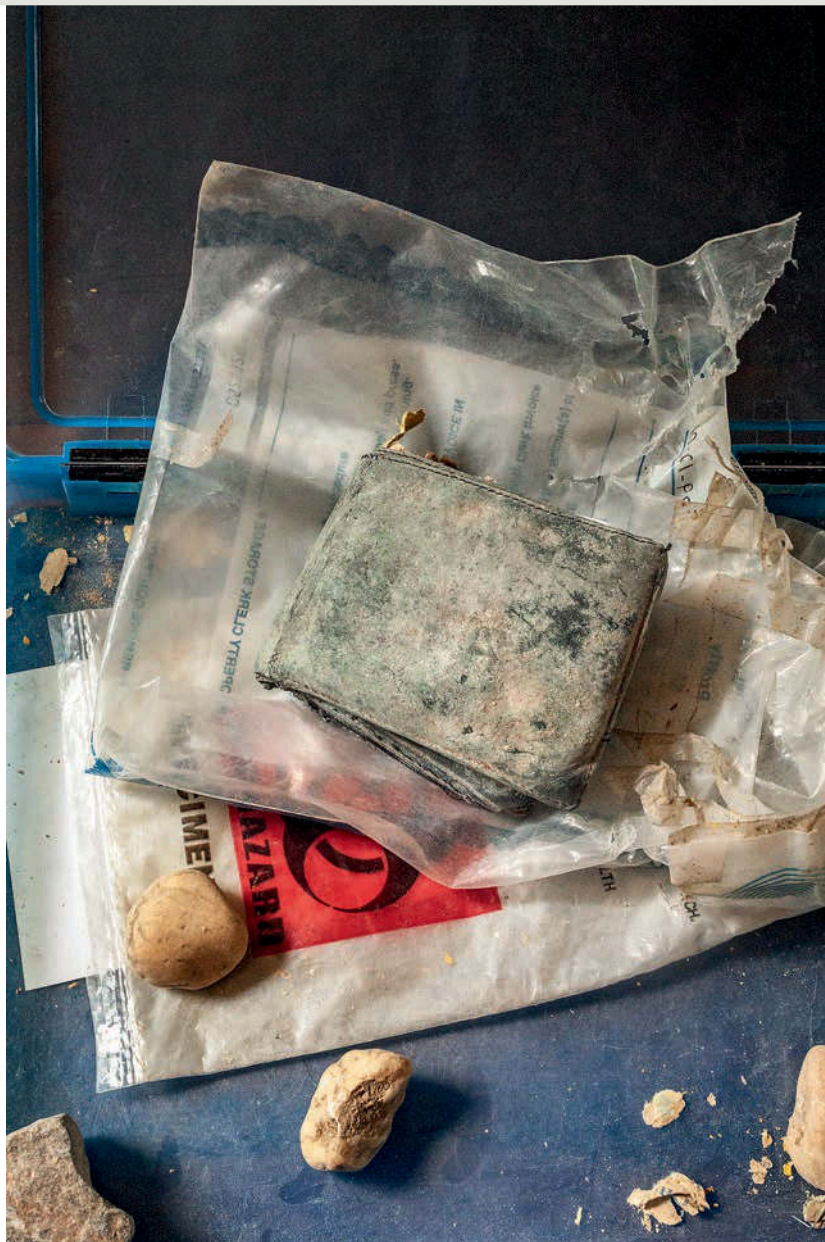
Work helped. Her students needed her, and her colleagues were great. “Except I didn’t want their help, because it was too soon,” Helen says. “So afterwards, a few years down the road, I looked like I’d healed. And it wasn’t true. I *wanted* to talk about it sometimes. But I had to find other means to do it, because I’d kind of shut that door.”

I can’t decide whether this corresponds with the Helen I’ve come to know. Maybe?

Helen: She wears little or no makeup. She is exceedingly good-humored. She is always brimming with questions about your life. She’s the kind of person who goes along with any plan and can spend 20 minutes in a drugstore trying on funny pairs of reading glasses with you.

We actually did this together in Florida a couple of years ago. We both happened to be visiting my mom.

So the reserve she’s describing is a little foreign to me. “I have a weird personality,” she tells me. “I can cry over a blouse that I ruined



in the laundry and then be stoic for something ...” She trails off, but I believe the word she’s looking for is *big*.

But with Bobby ... ! Bobby brought out her more emotional self, because he was such a sensitive kid. “Once, after about half an hour of listening to his woe-is-me girlfriend stories,” she tells me, “I said to him, ‘You do understand I’ve been married to Dad for almost 30 years and I’ve never given him this much thought, right?’” But of course she loved every minute of it.

The last time she saw Bobby was two nights before he died. Not an hour before, he had asked Jen’s father for permission to marry her; now the two families were having dinner at a restaurant in

BOBBY’S WALLET IS STILL COVERED IN DUST, AND FAINTLY REDOLENT OF THE WORLD TRADE CENTER TANG THAT HUNG OVER NEW YORK IN THE FALL OF 2001.

Lambertville, New Jersey, where Jen had an apartment. Helen took one look at her son and saw that his forehead was still shimmering with sweat. She reached under the table to find his hand. He locked his pinkie with hers. They stayed that way until the food came.

AROUND THE TENTH ANNIVERSARY of September 11, Helen realized that she was not all right. She'd lost a child, so maybe this was what her new life was destined to be: not all right. But she wasn't convinced. Somewhere along the way, her toughness, her steadfast refusal to be a victim—it had backfired. "I found myself being petty. And bickering. I found myself being too gossipy sometimes."

I've never heard Helen say a cross word about anyone. Even when I mention that I'll soon be seeing Jen, she reacts with anxiety, not bitterness. She doesn't want to open old wounds. They were both suffering terribly back then; neither was her finest self.

Okay, but what if she lends me the diary? I ask.

"Oh my God. Would you marry me?"

But this is today's Helen. The Helen of a decade ago decided she wasn't who she wanted to be. Her therapy had stalled. She had trouble managing her anger. "My life just feels so amazingly off kilter," she wrote in a reminiscence marking the tenth anniversary.

She'd kept too much in, and she was fermenting in her own brine.

Not long after, she started seeing a different therapist. This one was spiritual. That new perspective changed everything. "She really believes that we don't see all."

Even before Bobby died, Helen was a big fan of self-help books. But after September 11, she bought them by the dozen, hoovering up everything she could about loss. She found Elisabeth Kübler-Ross indispensable—not so much for her writing about the five stages of grief, though that was fine, but for her writing about life after death.

Kübler-Ross once considered a belief in the afterlife a form of denial. But starting in the mid-1970s, she had a change of heart, compiling thousands of testimonies from those who'd had near-death experiences in order to show that our souls outlast us.

"I looked at life-after-death books, but they were too faith-based," Helen says. "I *wanted* to believe what I was taught in my Catholic upbringing. But what I liked about Kübler-Ross is that she had a science background."

It was precisely because she was a scientist, of course, that Kübler-Ross's fellow physicians were so dismayed by this strange turn in her interests. They thought it kooky and unrigorous, a stain on her legacy. I tell this to Helen. She laughs. "Bet they didn't sell millions of books."

Kübler-Ross used a hokey but intuitive metaphor to describe the body and soul: Our bodies are our mortal coils, our "cocoons"; when we die, we shudder them off and our souls—our "butterflies"—are released into the wilds of the universe. Helen cherished this idea. It was a notion that could redeem a violently, capriciously abbreviated life. "One day I actually thought, *What if there's a hierarchy and Bobby's a part of that, and he just came down as a human for a bit?*"

She and Bob Sr. began watching *Supernatural* and *Buffy the Vampire Slayer*, shows they'd never have imagined watching before.

And here in this world, Helen came to understand that there was nothing to be gained by bottling up her grief. At age 60, she took up running, not only because it felt good but because it allowed her to

cry. She started expressing herself more. She noticed one day that the tempest of grievances she unloosed in her therapist's office were all so trivial, so petty, so *pointless*. What was she getting so worked up about?

Now she's doing the very thing the self-help books tell you to do: letting stuff go. She tells me about a friend whose towering self-involvement used to infuriate her. But recently, she chatted with her on the phone and decided just to enjoy the good bits.

Wow, I say. What makes you so forgiving?

"It wasn't serving me well."

YOU KNOW WHAT radical acceptance is? Living with a husband who has dedicated his life to spreading the word that the United States deliberately orchestrated the collapse of the World Trade Center and then conspired to cover it up. Forget all the chipper advice columns about how to get along with your Trump-loving uncle at Thanksgiving. How do you get on in your decades-long marriage after your son has died and your spouse wakes up each morning livid as an open wound and determined to expose the truth?

Helen would be lying if she said this didn't cause friction.

"There were many moments where I was like, *Oh, please*," she says. She was perfectly open to some of the things Bob Sr. said. "But a lot of it was emotional, and a lot of it, I couldn't trace to find out myself, and I'm not a go-on-a-website kind of person. I didn't want to burst his bubble by constantly saying, 'Well, did you check, is it a valid website?'"

Perhaps the more challenging issue, the nuts-and-bolts-of-living-in-a-marriage issue, was daily conversation. Bob Sr.'s single-minded focus meant that any conversation could segue without warning into September 11. She'd come downstairs and tell him she was thinking about buying a new sweater; he'd reply by asking if she knew that the government had lied about the actual date of Osama bin Laden's death.

"So has it gotten in the way?" she asks. "Yeah, many times. We'd be going somewhere, and I'd say to Bob, 'You *cannot* talk about 9/11.' And he'd say, 'Well, they ask me about it.' I fell for that for the first 99 times until my therapist said, 'That's not good enough.' When we're out at a social event, we're out. I don't want to be always *victim, victim, victim*."

How do you handle it now, I ask, if you feel another soliloquy coming on?

"Now I say, 'Bob, you have the I-won't-talk-about-anything-else-but-9/11 look on your face.' We've come to a point where we can actually joke about it."

Helen wants me to understand: There are some aspects of Bob Sr.'s obsessions that she doesn't merely tolerate; she actively supports them. Two years ago, she listened to a presentation by Architects & Engineers for 9/11 Truth and found it persuasive. It's the other parts of his narrative, which keep evolving, that leave her at loose ends. "If I were him, I'd just stick with the buildings," she says. I ask if she's up-to-date on his latest theory, involving Japanese gold. She shakes her head. "I don't even hear it," she says. "I'm defending the person, not the view."

Long ago, Helen realized that "9/11 truth," as Bob Sr. likes to call it, had sunk its hooks into her husband, and she's never thought it her place to pry them loose. "I'm very protective of him," she says.

"If he decided to be a male stripper in an old people's home, it's okay with me. He has to be who he has to be, because damn it, this happened, you know? And if that's going to give him comfort—"

She interrupts herself, gives an embarrassed smile. "Get that visualization out of your head."

Helen would never dream of abandoning this dear man. He was Bobby's Little League coach. The one who organized races around the house when the kids were little, using a piece of tape for the finish line. Bob Sr. was her only suitor who ever suggested they play sports together—the others thought that was strictly for the fellas.

And now he's the only other person in the world who understands what it feels like to have raised Bobby McIlvaine and lost him.

She walks me over to the wall with a giant framed poster she had custom-made for her husband five years ago. It's a periodic table of Bob Sr., basically—dozens of images of him, all tidily laid out in a grid. Bob Sr. talking to Rosie O'Donnell. Bob Sr. giving an interview on French television. Bob Sr. speaking at a forum about the 9/11 Commission report, captured on C-SPAN. "I gave him that on his 70th birthday," she says.



She went online, punched his name into Google, and voilà. A hero's gallery. "I love looking at it." He's become the superstar, strangely, that his son never had the chance to be.

Bob Sr.'s crusade may look to the outside world like madness. Helen sees it as an act of love. "He's almost going to war for his son," she tells me. "He's being a father in the best way he knows how. How can I not allow that?"

MOST THEORIES OF GRIEF, particularly the ones involving stages, are more literary than literal. People don't mourn sequentially, and they certainly don't mourn logically. But there's an aspect of one of those models I keep circling back to whenever I think of the McIlvaines. It's the "yearning and searching" stage of grief, first described by the British psychiatrists Colin Murray Parkes and John Bowlby in the 1960s. "When searching," Parkes writes, "the bereaved person feels and acts as if the lost person were recoverable, although he knows intellectually that this is not so."

How Bob Sr. searches is obvious. But it occurs to me, after speaking with Helen, that perhaps her years-long preoccupation with Bobby's final diary is her equivalent of Bob Sr.'s obsessions. "Yes!" she says when I tentatively raise the possibility. "Yes, yes. It's 'If I can't have *this*, then I'll have *that*.'"

Yet here's what's curious. Helen has two earlier diaries of Bobby's. She also has stacks of legal pads of his writing, many with diarylike entries in them. But she's barely dipped into them at all.

One reason is practical: They're hard to decipher. Bobby's handwriting is neat but small and slightly peculiar. Another is instinctive: For a long time, Helen feared that reading them would be a violation of a sacred boundary, "like going into his room without knocking." Yet another is how much pain it causes her. "I tried today again," she wrote in another reminiscence on the tenth anniversary of Bobby's death. "I thought, 'If I don't tackle these before I'm dead, who will?'" She lasted 10 minutes. Bob Sr. has never looked at them at all.

"But somewhere I did find the words *Life loves on*," Helen tells me.

I've been meaning to ask her about this, because I'm now reading Bobby's diaries and legal pads, and I can't find the phrase anywhere. Does she still not know where it came from?

She doesn't. She thought he'd written it about a close family friend who'd died, but she was wrong. I tell her I'll keep looking.

I take one of the two diaries back to my hotel that night. And I realize, as I'm reading, that there's probably

"I KNEW THAT IF THIS RUINED MY LIFE, HIS WHOLE LIFE WAS WORTHLESS," JEFF McILVAINE SAYS. "I WANTED TO WORK VERY HARD TO MAKE SURE THAT I HAD A GOOD LIFE."

another reason Helen never dug too deep into either one of them. They're from his freshman and sophomore years of college, when he was still a proto-person, still essentially a kid. He was clearly older when he scribbled in some of those legal pads, but they're chaotic and undated. Only the diaries feel manageable and chronological, and they read like the musings of a boy in his late teens—florid, soulful, a little mushy. He doesn't sound at all like the Bobby of September 11, 2001, who was almost 27 years old.

Yet I still get a kick out of them, and those chaotic legal pads, especially the parts about writing. Even at 19, Bobby was trying to find his voice, sometimes shifting from the first person to the third to see if he liked it better (and then saying so in the margins—*third-person experiment!*). They're filled with exhortations and reminders to himself: *I need to stay true to my voice, whatever it is. I write horrible stuff in other people's voices.* And my favorite: *Hope is even more important than talent.*

There's also tons of beautiful stuff about his family. This may be what astonishes me most, given that Bobby was in late adolescence, a time when most kids morph into ruthless family vivisectionists. Yet he devotes page after page to how much he loves and admires Helen, Bob Sr., and Jeff. In May 1995, for instance, he wrote about discovering that Bob Sr.'s father had been an alcoholic. Bobby had had no inkling. *He made sure that he didn't give me the bullshit,* Bobby wrote of his own father.

He made sure I had something better, and only asked that I do my best. That's all he asked. That's all my mom asked. And I want so badly to make them proud, even more proud than they already are. They deserve the pride. They deserve more than I can ever give them, and yet they will never ask for more than me. I love them so much.

You can hardly blame Helen for wanting to hear what he had to say once he'd become a young man.

JEN COBB, NOW MIDDLETON, wears her hair long, rather than in her old pixie cut, but her style and demeanor remain the same. She is still animated, still gracious, still beautiful to look at; when I walk up to her door in Washington, D.C., she greets me with a long hug. There are rescue dogs, there are sunlit rooms, there is a kitchen straight from a Nancy Meyers film. (I half-expect Meryl Streep to come gliding up with a tray of unbaked croissants.)

Jen has made for herself what is, to all outward appearances, a lovely life. But she had to assemble that life brick by brick, and she works hard to keep the joints from coming apart.

When I spoke briefly with Helen about Jen, she made an astute observation: Jen came from a family with lots of money but little love, while the McIlvaines had lots of love but little money. Jen says that yes, that's partly true, though her mother was a loving soul; she just didn't see enough of Jen's life. Susan E. Cobb died on April 20, 2001, less than five months before Bobby did, of a cancer that spread slowly, then fast.

Which is to say: On September 11, Jen was already a husk of herself.

Jen's father, her remaining parent, was highly successful but only narrowly rational, a bully and a screamer. This had predictable

“They deserve more than
I can ever give them,
and yet they will never
ask for more than me,”
Bobby wrote in his
diary, of his parents.
“I love them so much.”

consequences in her romantic life: Jen always demanded complete control. She was done being bossed around.

Then along came Bobby, asking for more vulnerability and a shared say in both of their lives. Somehow, she trusted him. They first met a couple of years earlier, at the PR firm Burson-Marsteller, and around the office, he was known as the good guy who made everyone feel important. The inveterate romantic, he made *her* feel important, asking question after question about her family, writing her love notes for no reason. For her 27th birthday, on December 6, 2000, he asked my brother to scam and rearranged the furniture in their apartment to turn it into a restaurant, where he cooked her a three-course meal.

Jen would later learn that the dinner was a dry run for a proposal. She put a hold on the Ritz-Carlton in Philadelphia for October 20, 2002.

When her mother died, Jen could barely function. Her mother was the one who'd protected her from her father's storms of rage; she was the one who'd chatted with her late at night after Jen had spent a boisterous evening out with girlfriends. Yet Bobby remained steadfastly by her side, making the intolerable seem survivable. He would be with her every step of the way. She would still be loved.

Then Bobby died. The world became a mean, untrustworthy place. “There was not one thing I could control,” she says. “Not one thing at all.”

JEN KEEPS A steamer trunk of Bobby's things in the attic above her garage. In anticipation of my arrival, she's brought his belongings down in a turquoise canvas bag. She starts sifting through it. “There's the diary,” she says, pointing. “The thing that caused all that trouble.”

Bobby's other two diaries were hundreds of pages long. This one, I will shortly discover, had only 17 pages of entries. All that fuss over what was barely a pamphlet.

Then again, they're a dense 17 pages.

Jen has no memory of getting the diary from Bob Sr. But she does remember reading it immediately, voraciously, and returning

“It felt like she was saying my grief was less important than hers,” Jen said. “I remember thinking, *How does she know I’m going to be okay?*”



to it night after night. She remembers, too, Helen asking for it back, though the tensions didn’t start immediately. At first, everything was fine. Helen even gave her the engagement ring Bobby had bought for her. It was awkward and unceremonious—“He’d have wanted you to have this”—but Jen was grateful, and she wore it everywhere for months.

At some point, though, Helen started getting more vocal about that diary. “In hindsight, I don’t know what my problem was,” Jen says. “I was probably in pain and also grasping for control and wanted something of his that no one else had. It seems kind of ridiculous now. It’s just how I felt at the time—that it was mine and I wanted it to be mine and I didn’t want anyone else to have it. It probably felt like it was all I had left.”

What I had to understand about those awful, leaden days, Jen says, is that she wasn’t just depressed. She was wretched—“double grieving,” as she puts it, for her mother and then her future husband. When her mother and Bobby died in rapid succession, she fell into a deep depression, though she did her valiant best to conceal it. She still has anxiety attacks to this day. “When something upsets me,” she says, “it goes downhill fast.”

Which all makes perfect sense, I say. The only thing I can’t understand is why she refused to transcribe the nonpersonal parts of Bobby’s diary for Helen. That’s not the act of a depressed person or a grieving person. That’s the act of someone who’s angry. She must have been upset with Helen for some reason, no?

Here Jen pauses. Then she starts measuring her words. “This isn’t a knock on Helen at all,” she says. “I’m so beyond it. But at the time I remember resenting that she said, ‘You’re going to be okay, because you’re young.’” Jen recognized that there was a difference between their two losses. “But it felt like she was saying my grief was less important than hers. I know it was coming from a place of extreme pain, but I remember thinking, *How does she know I’m going to be okay? What if I’m not okay? What if I have a different kind of not-okay?*”

One thing you don’t say to a person who’s mourning, Jen tells me, is that they’re going to be okay. She might have added: Nor do you say that to a depressed person. Depression does that—convinces you that you are never going to be okay.

“Now I get it,” she says. Because of course Helen was right. Jen did find love again. But at the time, she was convinced that she wouldn’t. She considered freezing her eggs. Once, in a moment of near-hallucinatory panic, she wondered if she could get impregnated with Bobby’s DNA from strands of hair he’d left in a comb.

“It just would’ve come out better if she’d said: ‘This is really sucky for you. And I’m sorry. Chances are, you’ll meet somebody.’ I guess there was just a nicer way to say it,” she says. “However she said it set me off. Just because of my own personal shit.”

I ask if it’s possible that Helen *did* say those things, though she may have said a few artless things too. Maybe Jen missed them—or heard insults that weren’t necessarily intended as such—because she’d grown up in a house that required an extra set of threat detectors, given her father’s volatility.

“A hundred percent,” she says. “It was probably me regressing into a little, you know, tantruming child. I was mad at the world. Of course she didn’t intend to hurt me. She’s the nicest person.”

She and Helen are more similar than either of them realizes. Like Helen, Jen believed, at the time, in hiding her grief. Like Helen, she today takes refuge in the idea that Bobby’s soul is rattling about somewhere. “I’m really showing my woo-woo side here,” she says, “but I think that he’ll be back, and I’ll be back, and we’ll finish our unfinished business.”

And like Helen, she has learned to let a lot of things go. That’s one of the most ruthless lessons trauma teaches you: You are not in charge. All you can control is your reaction to whatever grenades the demented universe rolls in your path. Beginning with

whether you get out of bed. “And that’s where I started my day, literally,” she says. For years.

Today, Jen is choosing to hand me Bobby’s diary as I’m walking out the door and heading back to New York. She has zero reservations about it. She says she’d like to have the original copy back, but there’s no rush; the McIlvaines are free to read all of it, free to make as many photocopies as they’d like.

“I would have done it years ago,” she tells me. “I think about them all the time.”

Before I leave, I ask if she remembers where the phrase *Life loves on* comes from. She looks at me blankly. “I don’t even remember him *saying* that. Is it in a book that he liked or something?” Tried that, I say. Searched Google Books. Nope. “Or was it a hymn?” Hymns aren’t my strong suit, but I don’t think so. I tell her that the McIlvaines are certain Bobby wrote it somewhere, but never mind, this is not her problem. I’ll keep looking.

MEMORIES OF TRAUMATIC EXPERIENCES are a curious thing. Some are vivid; some are pale; pretty much all of them have been emended in some way, great or small. There seems to be no rhyme or reason to our curated reels. We remember the trivial and forget the exceptional. Our minds truly have minds of their own.

Jeff, for instance, remembers that Jen stayed at his parents’ house for half a year after Bobby died, while Helen says it was one week, and Jen thinks it was probably two months.

Or here’s another: Jen remembers that Jeff gallantly slept in Bobby’s childhood bedroom while she stayed with them, so that she wouldn’t have to be traumatized by waking up to all of Bobby’s things, while Jeff remembers *her* sleeping in Bobby’s bedroom, and bravely waking up each day to all of Bobby’s things.

And strangest of all: Though no one can remember where *Life loves on* came from, everyone—and I do mean everyone (Jen, Jeff, Bob Sr., and Helen)—once knew.

It’s from Jen’s eulogy. Which she based on Bobby’s diary. The one she kept for 20 years.

“This past week I have been searching for some sort of comfort to get me through the shock of losing the love of my life,” she told the mourners at Queen of Peace Church. “I came across one of Bob’s journals and as I opened it, I said to myself, ‘Please let there be something in here that will comfort me.’” Then she described finding this passage, which Bobby had written as her mother was dying. She read it aloud.

It is OK for people to die. It hurts, and it is a deep loss, but it is OK. Life loves on. Do not fear for those who are dying. Be kind to them. And care for them.

“Life loves on,” she repeated to the crowd. “After I read this, I vowed that very instant to love on in my life, just as I had made a promise to my mom to never let her be forgotten. It was a way that I could extend a life cut short.”

The only reason I know this is because my brother found a copy of Jen’s eulogy. Jen had tossed hers out. She is not, as she says, a saver.

Somehow she’d completely forgotten those words, as well as their provenance. And the McIlvaines had forgotten where they came from, too, even though Helen wears them in an engraved bracelet and Bob Sr. enshrined them on his skin.

Then I remembered what Helen told me about Jen: *She became a nonperson to me*. She kept the words. But not Jen. She buried her future daughter-in-law too that year, just as she did her son.

HELEN RECENTLY TOLD ME a story about a long weekend she’d spent with Jen, maybe 10 days before Bobby died. The whole family was vacationing in Cape May. She, Bobby, and Jen were sitting on the beach, staring at the waves, with Bobby in the middle. It was a moment of gentle bliss. Helen turned ever so slightly toward Bobby to run her hand through his hair. But at that exact same moment, that very second, Bobby turned to do the same to Jen.

It was then that Helen realized Bobby wasn’t hers anymore. “I said to myself, *You gotta go take a walk and look at the real estate on the beach,*” she told me.

In Bobby’s early diaries, the McIlvaine family may show up everywhere. But not in this diary. This diary is primarily about two things. And one of them is Jen.

FEBRUARY 18, 2001: I love her, deeply. We communicate so well.

We resolve splits between us so well. And all of this means a lot.

APRIL 11, 2001: I miss Jen. “Big” part of my life, or descriptions of how much she means to me do not suffice.

APRIL 22, 2001 (TWO DAYS AFTER JEN’S MOTHER DIED): I am so sorry, Jen. So sorry for your hurt. I know it is hard. I’ll be here by your side—here to love you, to listen to you, to hold you when you need to cry.

It’s no wonder Jen didn’t want to part with this diary. Or that she read it every night.

Helen recognized this immediately. I sent her a couple of xeroxed copies after I returned to New York.

“The Jen piece was huge to me,” she says, when we have a chance to talk. “I thought of this in the middle of the night: She loses this guy that she loves—and most importantly, who loves her. Now, where is the *proof* that he loves her? I mean, okay, the mother gives her the ring. That’s good. But there are these wonderful words: *I love her deeply.*” She marvels. “I never thought about that. Never. That she needed that, that validation.”

She also recognizes what the diary is missing. “He didn’t say, *I love my parents too.* He said, *I love her deeply.*” Bobby was all grown up.

Helen now wonders about her own behavior in those awful months. She tried to show Jen affection. But she’d only had sons. She didn’t *speak* daughter. And that reserve she was describing to me earlier, the reserve I didn’t believe she had—it was very real. “What happens is, I have intentions sometimes and forget to say the words,” she says. “She had to guess what was in my head.”

At any rate, Helen is now clear on one very important point. “It would have been beyond Jen’s ability, even if she was in a good mood, to say, ‘Okay, here, I’m giving it back.’ I really

would have had to give her at least pieces of that, somehow. That wasn't for me to own. I really mean that."

For years, Jen had been painted as a villain for holding on to this diary. Yet there never would have been a dispute if she had already been Bobby's wife, or perhaps even his official fiancée. But Jen was suspended between worlds, without influence or status. "It must have felt horrible," Helen says.

The final entry in Bobby's diary is dated September 6, 2001. It fills the whole page. When I first read it, I was disoriented. Then I realized what it was. "I feel completely unprepared. Should I rehearse?" it begins.

It should go something like this: Do you have a few minutes to talk? First, I'd like to say that it has been a pleasure—or maybe a great experience—or do I mention Jen first? Or, I have developed a very strong relationship with Jen, and along the way it has been great to spend time in Michigan ... OR ... yes—I've had the chance to grow close to Jen, and after a lot of very serious thought, and after talking to her too, I felt that it is time to make a commitment to her. OR—after a good deal of serious thought ... AND ... out of respect for you as head of the family ...

What I was reading was a script. Filled with fits and starts, but eventually he got there. Bobby was struggling to find the words to say to Jen's father, whom he'd see on September 9, to ask for her hand.

AT SOME POINT, not long after Jen gave me Bobby's diary, I sent a note to my editor, telling him that I had found, at long last, the elusive *Life loves on*. I took a photo of the passage and sent it to him.

Amazing, he texted.

But then, three pulsing dots in a bubble. He was still typing.

*Except ... I think it is (sort of) a misapprehension. Look how he writes his I's in other words. I think it says "Life **lives** on." But hard to say for sure ...*

It wasn't hard to say. He was right. I went through the whole diary again. On just the page before, Bobby had written, *I lived too long without thinking of "the markets" to suddenly care*. But it looks like "I loved too long ..." His *I*'s look like backwards *J*'s, which can be mistaken for *O*'s, while his real *O*'s stand alone, like baby moons.

I texted Jen the same photograph I sent my editor. At first, she didn't see it. Then she did. Her initial reaction was the same as mine: anxiety, despair in the form of an expletive. Then:

Still makes me smile

ME: *What does?*

JEN: *That the people close to him saw and felt what they needed to. And that's ok. You know?*

I did. The phrase certainly sounded like something Bobby *could* have said. It was very Yoda, and Bobby was definitely very Yoda, spouting his little aphorisms about the drives of the human heart. To me, it was the difference between the spirit of the law and the letter of the law, or maybe what we do when we intensify the color of an image on our iPhone. We're not trying to create a fake; we're trying to align the image with the one that already lives in our memory.

We are always inventing and reinventing the dead.

You could make a case, weirdly, that Jen's withholding of the diary for all these years turned out to be a blessing. If she'd given it to Helen, it's possible Helen would have tucked it away in her safe for 10 years and barely read it, just as she did the other two diaries. Or maybe she'd have read it, but she wouldn't have *misread* it.

Instead, Jen misread it, formed a eulogy around it, and handed the McIlvaine family an organizing motto for their grief for 20 years.

I still debated not telling the McIlvaines. I mean, the bracelet, the tattoo. But in a phone conversation with Helen soon after, I sensed an opening. I mentioned that I wasn't sure I was going to write about *Life loves on*. She quickly intuited that something was amiss. "Because it was from somebody else?" she asked.

Kind of, I said. And I explained.

Helen was fine with it. She sees the unlikely beauty of this misunderstanding, even how it was a gift. But she holds out the possibility that the phrase still lurks somewhere. She remembers it as *Life truly loves on*, for one thing. And it's possible that I could have missed it in the hundreds of pages of Bobby's first two diaries. There are probably some missing diaries, too—why did he stop keeping them in 1995, only to resume in 2001?

So really, who's to say?

LIFE LIVES ON, LIFE LOVES ON—to me, it's irrelevant. There are far more beautiful observations in the recovered diary than that one, and they're prescient, eerie—much more germane to the McIlvaines' story once Bobby was gone.

Because the other thing his diary is about, the second thing, is grief.

In this way, the diary isn't just a time capsule. It's a crystal ball. Through an extraordinary twist of fate, Bobby spent his final few months thinking about what it meant to live with loss. He saw, through Jen, that it could render you angry, irritable, skinless. He saw that grief could utterly consume. He wondered what the utility of all this sadness was, all this suffering. *Why do we have to hurt so badly?* he wrote. *Is that the way the person we lost would have wanted it to be?*

At one point, he guiltily wished that Jen would just make a choice to seize control of the things she could.

Yet somewhere amid all the passages of exasperation and dread—and many of them are quite detailed—Bobby comes to a much larger realization. It's an epiphany, I'm guessing, that made it possible for him to stick with his plan to ask Jen's father for permission to marry her, though he seriously questioned during those months whether she was ready. The date was August 20, 2001.

There are people that need me. And that, in itself, is life. There are people I do not know yet that need me. That is life.

To me, *that* is the most profound quote from the recovered diary. *That* is Bobby as Yoda. *That* is Bobby at his very finest, his most humane, his most mature. He understood that our commitments to one another are what we're here for—and *that, in itself, is life*. Even when those commitments are hard. Even when they cause us pain.

ONE HESITATES TO SAY THIS. But if there was any path forward for the McIlvaine family, it was probably going to be through Jeff. Helen was careful never to burden him with expectations about marriage or kids—"You cannot put *anything* on the

September 6, 2001

I feel completely unprepared. Should I rehearse?
Or am I not taking this seriously enough?

It should go something like this:

Do you have a few minutes to talk?
First, I'd like to say that it has been
a pleasure — or maybe a great experience —
or do I mention Ter first? Or, I have
developed a very strong relationship with
Ter, and along the way it has been
great to spend time in Michigan, to
get to know you and Jason, and it
is very meaningful for me to have had
the chance, even for a short time, to get
to know Mrs. Cobb. I've had the chance
to grow close to Ter — or, ... yes —

I've had the chance to grow close to
Ter, and after a lot of very serious
thought, and after talking to her too,
I feel that it is time to make a
commitment to her. Or — after a good
deal of serious thought... AND...

Out of respect for you as head of the
family, and also out of respect for
the way in which marriage will bring our
two families together, I'd like to ask
your permission to propose to her.

It has been a tremendous experience —
to get to know Ter, and what a great person
she is — what a dedicated and caring
person she is.

other child,” she tells me—and he appreciated that. But it was thanks to Jeff, I think, that Bob Sr. and Helen started to muddle their way out of the dark. There were people they did not know yet who needed them. Among those people were their four grandbabies. The oldest one is named Bobby.

At 22, Jeff had a profound insight. “I remember thinking on that first day: *I can’t let this ruin me.*” Cause then what would Bobby think? Imagine if he knew that my parents and his brother were never able to recover. Imagine how bad that would make him feel.”

He was reflexively answering the very question Bobby had asked as he watched Jen struggle with her grief: *Why do we have to hurt so badly? Is that the way the person we lost would have wanted it to be?* Jeff had a very clear answer: No. He had too much of his own life left to go. “I knew that if this ruined *my* life, *his* whole life was worthless,” he says. “I wanted to work very hard to make sure that I had a good life.”

It was so hard at first. “I remember I felt a responsibility to not die, which is a weird thing,” he tells me. At the same time, he felt guilty for being the child who didn’t die, thinking often of the dream sequence in *Stand by Me* when the father snarls “It should have been you” to his surviving son. He told no one at his first real job that his brother had died on September 11, because too many people were eager to share their own stupid stories about that day, always with happy endings. This delayed his ability to grieve for years.

But eventually, he built a rich, fulfilling life. He married a woman who could not only subdue his pain but enter an entire grieving ecosystem. He had four kids—four! two boys, two girls—and oh, the relief of not having to focus on himself!

I ask if he would have had that many kids if Bobby hadn’t—“No. I don’t think I would have.” Jeff lost his only sibling. He never wants any child of his to be in that position, should lightning ever restrike. “When you go through something like this,” he says, “you realize that family—it’s the *only* thing.”

Those kids are now at the center of the McIlvaines’ lives—even Bob Sr., who has chosen a path of daily suffering. As our conversation was winding down, he said something that stunned me: This 20th-anniversary year—a big one for the people in his world, filled with TV interviews and conferences—may be his last of 9/11 activism.

I wasn’t sure I believed it. I remain unsure. This has been his life for 20 years. Still: Maybe it’s time for a change. “I’m sick of being angry,” he told me. “That’s the beauty of my life now. I can really separate. I truly can. To be out to lunch with Penelope . . .”

Penelope is his youngest granddaughter. He and Helen had lunch with her every Wednesday after preschool before the pandemic. Jeff and his wife and children rely so heavily on Bob and Helen that they recently rented an apartment five minutes from Jeff’s house, though they live less than an hour away.

Helen can’t get over having little girls in her life. They have so many opinions! She still gets depressed sometimes. She’ll have a beautiful moment, then realize that Bobby isn’t here to share it. “But then it’ll go away,” she says. “I mean, being needed—not everybody gets four grandkids.”

Yes. Being needed. That is everything.

It’s the damndest thing: The dead abandon you; then, with the passage of time, you abandon the dead.

BOBBY WOULD HAVE BEEN 46 this September. Jeff used to have vivid dreams about him, and man, how he loved them. They were brothers again, just talking, resuming their old rhythms and habits. But he seldom has those dreams anymore. “I haven’t seen him in 20 years, you know?”

He says he almost wishes sometimes that he could trade his current well-being for the suffering he felt 20 years ago, because Bobby was so much easier to conjure back then, the sense-memories of him still within reach. “No matter how painful September 11 was,” he explains, “I had just seen him on September 6.”

It’s the damndest thing: The dead abandon you; then, with the passage of time, you abandon the dead.

It’s really not surprising that Jeff should have this fantasy from time to time, to trade his happiness for just one chance to see Bobby again in a warmer hue. As Bobby wrote in that last diary, suffering, or the prospect of it, is the price we’re willing to pay for the bonds we make.

Helen has found herself in the grip of a similar reverie. Recently, she was out with her limping group, and as she was looking around the table, staring in gratitude at these women who have held her up these past 20 years, a thought occurred to her. “I wondered, *What if God said, ‘Okay, look, we gotta rewind here.’ Would we go through all of this again?*”

Would they be willing to relive their same lives, give birth to those same children, fall in love with them and then lose them a second time? “And I know that every single one of them would have said, emphatically, yes.”

For Helen, nothing in this world has rivaled the experience of raising her two boys. One of them, Robert George McIlvaine, died before his life truly began. But what would she have done without him, or he without her? For 26 years, she got to know this boy, to care for him, to love him. It was a privilege. It was a gift. It was a bittersweet sacrifice. *And that, in itself, is life.* A

Jennifer Senior is an Atlantic staff writer.



WHY THE FUTURE OF MEDICINE DEPENDS ON COLLABORATION

Successful scientific breakthroughs, such as the Pfizer-BioNTech COVID-19 vaccine, are often a team effort, made possible through collaborations—both public and private—across the health-care ecosystem.

Illustrations by Ryan Peltier



The unprecedented development and delivery of the Pfizer-BioNTech COVID-19 vaccine was born out of a collaboration. In 2018, the two companies began working together to develop an mRNA-based vaccine to prevent influenza. They quickly expanded their collaboration to focus on COVID-19 when the world desperately needed it.

That's just one example of Pfizer's many commitments to collaboration—with academic institutions that are advancing research, with start-ups developing awe-inspiring technologies, with regulatory bodies, and with patients' needs at the center.

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Before the Smoke Cleared



Photographs by
Eugene Richards

*Eugene Richards lives in Brooklyn, but was out of the country on September 11, 2001. When he returned to New York City four days later, he has written, he “metamorphosed into a bruise.” He stayed home, convinced that no one needed another photographer surveying the wreckage. But Richards’s wife and collaborator, Janine Altongy, insisted that they go see it. “You can’t avoid history, not when you’re so close to it,” he remembers her saying. Over the course of several months, Richards and Altongy traversed the city, recording scenes of loss from the long aftermath of the attacks. Their 2002 book, *Stepping Through the Ashes*, is a collection of Richards’s photographs and Altongy’s interviews with survivors, bereaved family members, first responders, and others.*

These days, Richards and Altongy almost never go back to Ground Zero. The memorial pools that now mark where the two towers stood, Richards says, are “so far, far away from the experience” of walking the smoke-filled streets that fall. If it were up to him, the site would be simpler, less polished—perhaps just the portions of the buildings’ facades that remained after the attacks. Two decades on, his photos are a stark reminder of a time when those ruins were all that was visible, a time that already feels long past.

—Amy Weiss-Meyer







Previous spread:
*A bird flies by a
building a block
away from the
World Trade Cen-
ter. On Septem-
ber 25, the area
was still shrouded
in thick yellow air.*

This spread:
*For months after
the attacks, New
York City fire-
fighters and
police officers and
volunteers from
around the country
searched what they
called “the pile” for
human remains.*

Top: A snow globe covered in dust and debris, for sale near the site of the World Trade Center on September 24. Bottom: A group from Massachusetts prays on the east side of Broadway—as close as the public could get to the site of the attacks in late September.



Top: Lieutenant William Ryan, a firefighter from Staten Island, holds his granddaughter. He recalled “how desperately he had wanted to believe there would be people found alive.” Bottom: The fires at Ground Zero burned for months after the attacks.





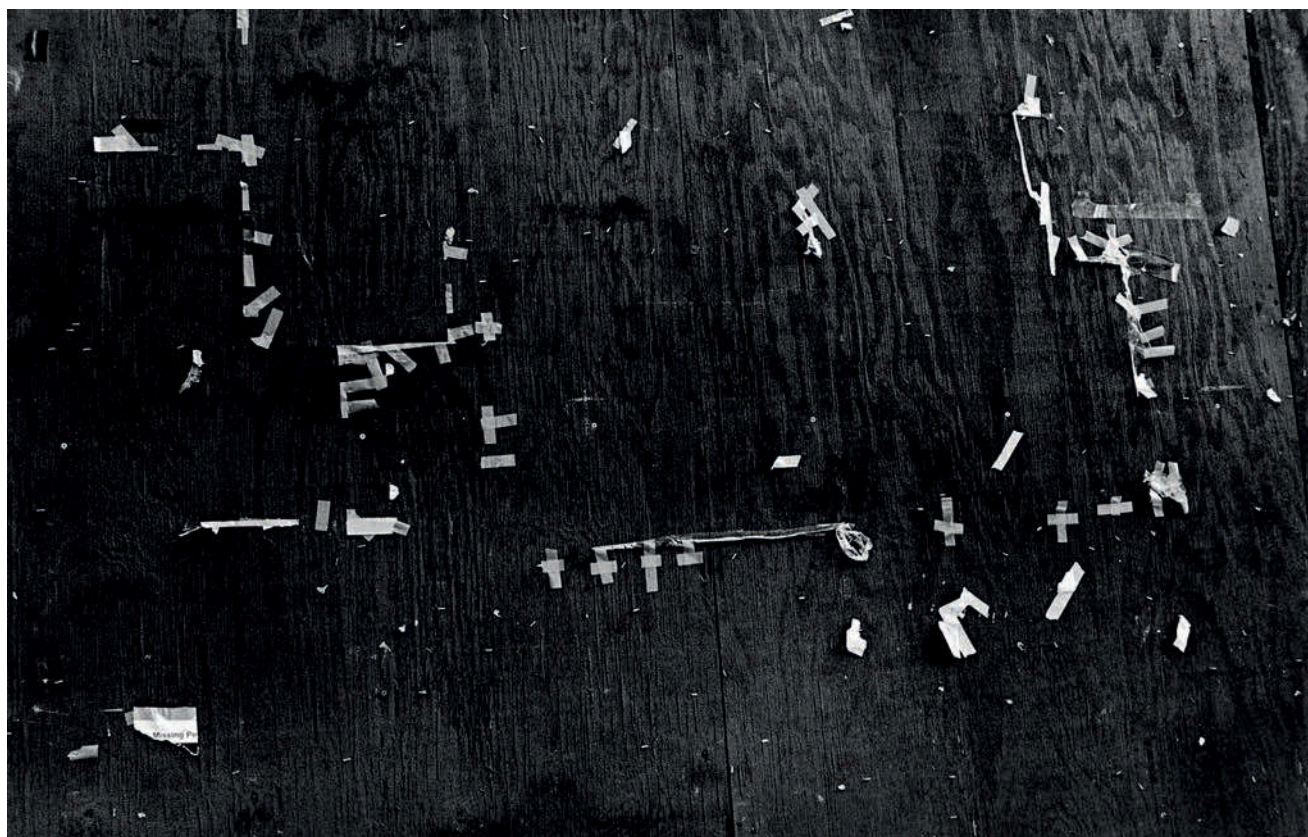
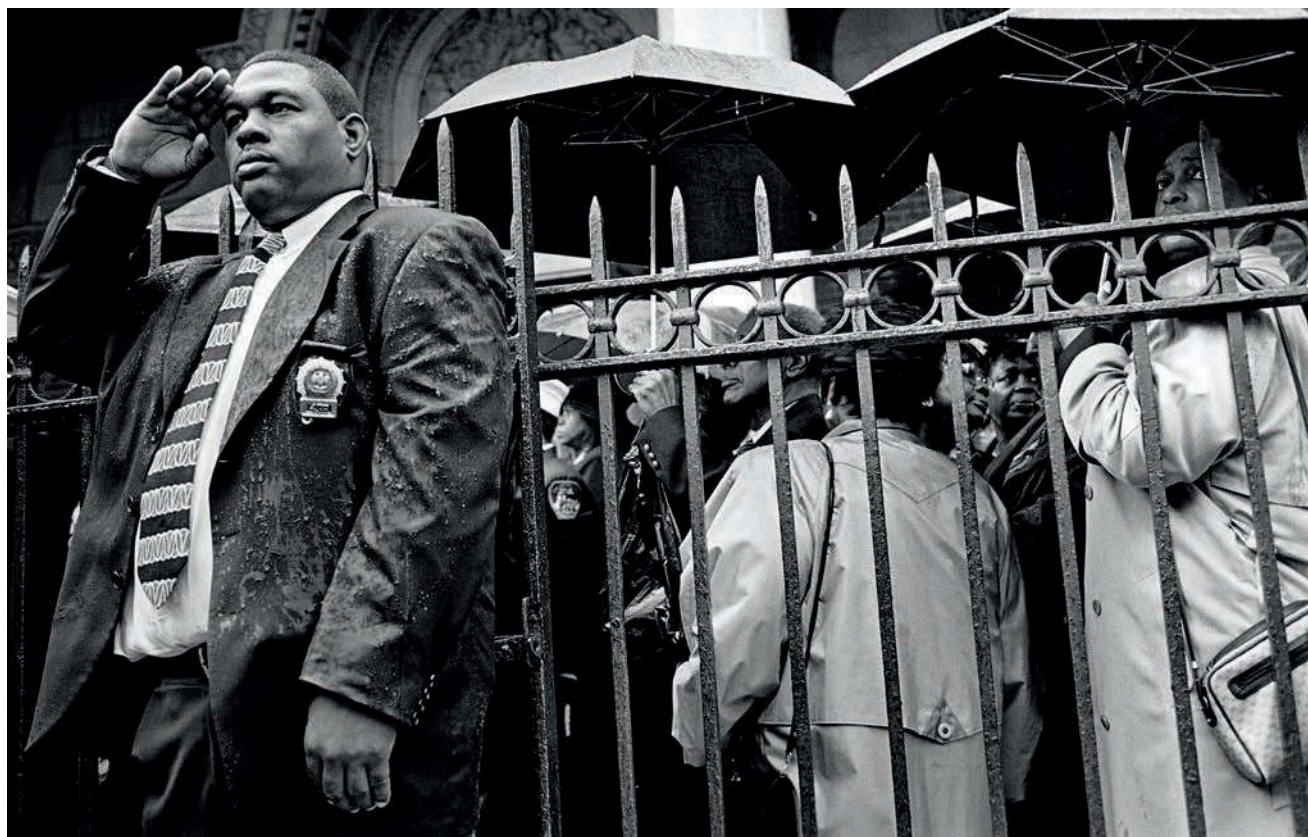


Outside the memorial service for the Brooklyn firefighter David Fontana, in October. His body had not yet been found, so mourners carried an empty casket into the church. "I chose to have a coffin because I knew that my son would be able to understand it a little more," Fontana's wife, Marian, told Altongy. Later, Fontana's remains were found and the family held a second funeral.

Top: Missing-person posters, like these at the VA Medical Center in Manhattan, covered the city. Bottom: Norma Margiotta, the widow of Lieutenant Charles Margiotta, a firefighter from Ladder Company 85, wears mementos of her husband.



Top: Outside the memorial service for Leon Smith Jr., a firefighter from Ladder Company 118, in Brooklyn. Bottom: Eventually the missing-person posters came down. “The cleanup went on forever, but the hope for any kind of human restitution was gone,” Richards says.



Lower Manhattan, reflected in a window of the Staten Island Ferry in January 2002. "Everybody was trying to come to terms with the empty skyline," Richards says.





— BY —
DAVID
BROOKS

BLAME



the BOBOS



The creative class was supposed to foster progressive values and economic growth. Instead we got resentment, alienation, and endless political dysfunction.

*Illustrations by
Kimberly Elliott*

The dispossessed set out early in the mornings. They were the outsiders, the scorned, the voiceless. But weekend after weekend—unbowed and undeterred—they rallied together. They didn't have much going for them in their great battle against the privileged elite, but they did have one thing—their yachts.



During the summer and fall of 2020, a series of boat parades—Trumpittas—cruised American waters in support of Donald Trump. The participants gathered rowdily in great clusters. They festooned their boats with flags—American flags, but also message flags: DON'T TREAD ON ME, NO MORE BULLSHIT, images of Trump as Rambo.

The women stood on the foredecks in their red, white, and blue bikinis, raising their Pabst Blue Ribbon tallboys to salute the patriots in nearby boats. The men stood on the control decks projecting the sort of manly toughness you associate with steelworkers, even though these men were more likely to be real-estate agents. They represent a new social phenomenon: the populist regatta. They are doing pretty well but see themselves as the common people, the regular Joes, the overlooked. They didn't go to fancy colleges, and they detest the mainstream media. "It's so encouraging to see so many people just coming together in a spontaneous parade of patriotism," Bobi Kreumberg, who attended a Trumpittilla in Palm Beach, Florida, told a reporter from WPTV.

You can see this phenomenon outside the United States too. In France, the anthropologist Nicolas Chemla calls this social type the "boubours," the boorish bourgeoisie. If the elite bourgeois bohemians—the bobos—tend to have progressive values and metropolitan tastes, the boubours go out of their way to shock them with nativism, nationalism, and a willful lack of tact. Boubour leaders span the Western world: Trump in the U.S., Boris Johnson in the United Kingdom, Marine Le Pen in France, Viktor Orbán in Hungary, Matteo Salvini in Italy.

How could people with high-end powerboats possibly think of themselves as the downtrodden? The truth is, they are not totally crazy. The class structure of Western society has gotten scrambled

over the past few decades. It used to be straightforward: You had the rich, who joined country clubs and voted Republican; the working class, who toiled in the factories and voted Democratic; and, in between, the mass suburban middle class. We had a clear idea of what class conflict, when it came, would look like—members of the working classes would align with progressive intellectuals to take on the capitalist elite.

But somehow when the class conflict came, in 2015 and 2016, it didn't look anything like that. Suddenly, conservative parties across the West—the former champions of the landed aristocracy—portrayed themselves as the warriors for the working class. And left-wing parties—once vehicles for proletarian revolt—were attacked as captives of the super-educated urban elite. These days, your education level and political values are as important in defining your class status as your income is. Because of this, the U.S. has polarized into two separate class hierarchies—one red and one blue. Classes struggle not only up and down, against the richer and poorer groups on their own ladder, but against their partisan opposite across the ideological divide.

In June of last year, a Trump regatta was held in Ferrysburg, Michigan. A reporter from WOOD spoke with one of the boaters, a guy in a white T-shirt, a MAGA hat, and a modest fishing boat. "We are always labeled as racists and bigots," he said. "There's a lot of Americans that love Donald Trump, but we don't have the platforms that the Democrats do, including Big Tech. So we have to do this."

On a bridge overlooking the parade stood an anti-Trump protester, a young man in a black T-shirt carrying an ABOLISH ICE sign. "They use inductive reasoning rather than deduction," he told the reporter, looking out at the pro-Trump boaters. "They only seek information that gives evidence to their pre-suppositions." So who's of a higher social class? The guy in the boat, or the kid with the fancy words?

The Rise of a Countercultural Elite

In 1983, a literary historian named Paul Fussell wrote a book called *Class: A Guide Through the American Status System*. Most of the book is a caustic and extravagantly snobby tour through the class markers prevalent at the time. After ridiculing every other class, Fussell describes what he called "X people." These were people just like Fussell: highly educated, curious, ironic, wittily countercultural. X people tend to underdress for social occasions, Fussell wrote. They know the best wine stores and delis. They have risen above the muck of mainstream culture to a higher, hipper sensibility. The chapter about X people was insufferably self-regarding, but Fussell was onto something. Every once in a while, in times of transformation, a revolutionary class comes along and disrupts old structures, introduces new values, opens up economic and cultural chasms. In the 19th century, it was the bourgeoisie, the capitalist merchant class. In the latter part of the 20th century, as the information economy revved up and the industrial middle class hollowed out, it was X people.

Seventeen years later, I wrote a book about that same class, *Bobos in Paradise*. The bobos didn't necessarily come from money, and they were proud of that; they'd secured their places in selective universities and in the job market through drive and intelligence exhibited from an early age, they believed. X types defined themselves as rebels against the staid elite. They were—as the classic Apple commercial had it—“the crazy ones, the misfits, the rebels, the troublemakers.” But by 2000, the information economy and the tech boom were showering the highly educated with cash. They had to find ways of spending their gobs of money while showing they didn't care for material things. So they developed an elaborate code of financial correctness to display their superior sensibility. Spending lots of money on any room formerly used by the servants was socially defensible: A \$7,000 crystal chandelier in the living room was vulgar, but a \$10,000, 59-inch AGA stove in the kitchen was acceptable, a sign of your foodie expertise. When it came to aesthetics, smoothness was artificial, but texture was authentic. The new elite distressed their furniture, used refurbished factory floorboards in their great rooms, and wore nubby sweaters made by formerly oppressed peoples from Peru.

Two years later, Richard Florida published *The Rise of the Creative Class*, which lauded the economic and social benefits that the creative class—by which he meant, more or less, the same scientists, engineers, architects, financiers, lawyers, professors, doctors, executives, and other professionals who make up the bobos—produced. Enormous wealth was being generated by these highly educated people, who could turn new ideas into software, entertainment, retail concepts, and more. If you wanted your city to flourish, he argued, you had to attract these people by stocking the streets with art galleries, restaurant rows, and cultural amenities. Florida used a “Gay Index,” based on the supposition that neighborhoods with a lot of gay men are the sort of tolerant, diverse places to which members of the creative class flock.

Florida was a champion of this class. I looked on them pretty benignly myself. “The educated class is in no danger of becoming a self-contained caste,” I wrote in 2000. “Anybody with the right degree, job, and cultural competencies can join.” That turned out to be one of the most naive sentences I have ever written.

The New Elite Consolidates

Over the past two decades, the rapidly growing economic, cultural, and social power of the bobos has generated a global backlash that is growing more and more vicious, deranged, and apocalyptic. And yet this backlash is not without basis. The bobos—or X people, or the creative class, or whatever you want to call them—have coalesced into an insular, intermarrying Brahmin elite that dominates culture, media, education, and tech. Worse, those of us in this class have had a hard time admitting our power, much less using it responsibly.

First, we've come to hoard spots in the competitive meritocracy that produced us. As Elizabeth Currid-Halkett reported in her 2017 book, *The Sum of Small Things*, affluent parents have increased

their share of educational spending by nearly 300 percent since 1996. Partly as a result, the test-score gap between high- and low-income students has grown by 40 to 50 percent. The children of well-off, well-educated meritocrats are thus perfectly situated to predominate at the elite colleges that produced their parents' social standing in the first place. Roughly 72 percent of students at these colleges come from the richest quarter of families, whereas only 3 percent come from the poorest quarter. A 2017 study found that 38 schools—including Princeton, Yale, Penn, Dartmouth, Colgate, and Middlebury—draw more students from the top 1 percent than from the bottom 60 percent.

Second, we've migrated to just a few great wealth-generating metropolises. Fifteen years after *The Rise of the Creative Class*, Florida published a reconsideration, *The New Urban Crisis*. Young creative types were indeed clustering in a few zip codes, which produced enormous innovation and wealth along with soaring home values. As Florida noted in that book, from 2007 to 2017, “the population of college-educated young people between the ages of twenty-five and thirty-four grew three times faster in downtown areas than in the suburbs of America's fifty largest metro areas.”

But this concentration of talent, Florida now argued, meant that a few superstar cities have economically blossomed while everywhere else has languished. The 50 largest metro areas around the world house 7 percent of the world's population but generate 40 percent of global wealth. Just six metro areas—the San Francisco Bay Area; New York; Boston; Washington, D.C.; San Diego; and London—attract nearly half the high-tech venture capital in the world.

This has also created gaping inequalities within cities, as high housing prices push middle- and lower-class people out. “Over the past decade and a half,” Florida wrote, “nine in ten US metropolitan areas have seen their middle classes shrink. As the middle has been hollowed out, neighborhoods across America are dividing into large areas of concentrated disadvantage and much smaller areas



of concentrated affluence.” The large American metro areas most segregated by occupation, he found, are San Jose, San Francisco, Washington, Austin, L.A., and New York.

Third, we’ve come to dominate left-wing parties around the world that were formerly vehicles for the working class. We’ve pulled these parties further left on cultural issues (prizing cosmopolitanism and questions of identity) while watering down or reversing traditional Democratic positions on trade and unions. As creative-class people enter left-leaning parties, working-class people tend to leave. Around 1990, nearly a third of Labour members of the British Parliament were from working-class backgrounds; from 2010 to 2015, the proportion wasn’t even one in 10. In 2016, Hillary Clinton won the 50 most-educated counties in America by an average of 26 points—while losing the 50 least-educated counties by an average of 31 points.

These partisan differences overlay economic differences. In 2020, Joe Biden won just 500 or so counties—but together they account for 71 percent of American economic activity, according to the Brookings Institution. Donald Trump won more than 2,500 counties that together generate only 29 percent of that activity. An analysis by Brookings and *The Wall Street Journal* found that just 13 years ago, Democratic and Republican areas were at near parity on prosperity and income measures. Now they are divergent and getting more so. If Republicans and Democrats talk as though they are living in different realities, it’s because they are.

The creative class has converted cultural attainment into economic privilege and vice versa. It controls what Jonathan Rauch describes in his new book, *The Constitution of Knowledge*, as the epistemic regime—the massive network of academics and analysts who determine what is true. Most of all, it possesses the power of consecration; it determines what gets recognized and esteemed, and what gets disdained and dismissed. The web, of course, has democratized tastemaking, giving more people access to megaphones. But the setters of elite taste still tend to be graduates of selective universities living in creative-class enclaves. If you feel seen in society, that’s because the creative class sees you; if you feel unseen, that’s because this class does not.

Like any class, the bobos are a collection of varied individuals who tend to share certain taken-for-granted assumptions, schema, and cultural rules. Members of our class find it natural to leave their hometown to go to college and get a job, whereas people in other classes do not. In study after study, members of our class display more individualistic values, and a more autonomous sense of self, than other classes. Members of the creative class see their career as the defining feature of their identity, and place a high value on intelligence. Usage of the word *smart* increased fourfold in *The New York Times* from 1980 to 2000, according to Michael Sandel’s recent book, *The Tyranny of Merit*—and by 2018 usage had nearly doubled again.

Without even thinking about it, we in the creative class consolidate our class standing through an ingenious code of “openness.” We tend to like open floor plans, casual dress, and eclectic “localist” tastes that are willfully unpretentious. This seems radically egalitarian, because there are no formal hierarchies of taste or social position. But only the most culturally privileged

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EDUCATION, AND TECH.**

person knows how to navigate a space in which the social rules are mysterious and hidden.

Shamus Rahman Khan is a sociologist who attended and then taught at St. Paul, an elite New England prep school. As the meritocratic creative class displaces the old WASPs, he observes, what the school primarily teaches is no longer upper-crust polish or social etiquette, but “ease”—the knowledge of how to act in open environments where the rules are disguised.

A student who possesses ease can walk into any room and be confident that she can handle whatever situation she finds. She knows how to structure relationships with teachers and other professional superiors so that they are treated both as authority figures and as confidants. A student in possession of ease can comfortably engage the cafeteria workers with a distant friendliness that at once respects social hierarchy and pretends it doesn’t exist. A student with ease knows when irony is appropriate, what historical quotations are overused, how to be unselfconscious in a crowd. These practices, as Khan writes in *Privilege*, his book about St. Paul, can be absorbed only through long experience within elite social circles and institutions.

Openness in manners is matched by openness in cultural tastes. Once upon a time, high culture—the opera, the ballet—had more social status than popular culture. Now social prestige goes to the no-brow—the person with so much cultural capital that he moves between genres and styles, highbrow and lowbrow, with ease.

“Culture is a resource used by elites to recognize one another and distribute opportunities on the basis of the display of appropriate attributes,” Kahn argues. Today’s elite culture, he concludes, “is even more insidious than it had been in the past because today, unlike years ago, the standards are argued not to advantage anyone. The winners don’t have the odds stacked in their favor. They simply have what it takes.”

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I wrote *Bobos in Paradise* in the late Clinton era. The end of history had allegedly arrived; the American model had been vindicated by the resolution of the Cold War. Somehow, we imagined, our class would be different from all the other elites in world history. In fact, we have many of the same vices as those who came before us.

I got a lot wrong about the bobos. I didn't anticipate how aggressively we would move to assert our cultural dominance, the way we would seek to impose elite values through speech and thought codes. I underestimated the way the creative class would successfully raise barriers around itself to protect its economic privilege—not just through schooling, but through zoning regulations that keep home values high, professional-certification structures that keep doctors' and lawyers' incomes high while blocking competition from nurses and paralegals, and more. And I underestimated our intolerance of ideological diversity. Over the past five decades, the number of working-class and conservative voices in universities, the mainstream media, and other institutions of elite culture has shrunk to a sprinkling.

When you tell a large chunk of the country that their voices are not worth hearing, they are going to react badly—and they have.

The Reaction

If our old class structure was like a layer cake—rich, middle, and poor—the creative class is like a bowling ball that was dropped from a great height onto that cake. Chunks splattered everywhere. In *The Great Class Shift*, Thibault Muzergues argues that the creative class has disrupted politics across the Western world. In nation after nation, the rise of the educated metro elite has led the working class to rebel against them. Trump voters listed the media—the epitome of creative-class production—as the biggest threat to America. “The more than 150-year-old alliance between the industrial working class and what one might call the intellectual-cultural Left is over,” observes the Swedish political scientist Bo Rothstein. The working class today vehemently rejects not just the creative class but the epistemic regime that it controls. In revolt, populist Trump voters sometimes create their own reality, inventing absurd conspiracy theories and alternative facts about pedophile rings among the elites who they believe disdain them.

The dominance of the bobos has also engendered a rebellion among its own offspring. The members of the creative class have labored to get their children into good colleges. But they've also jacked up college costs and urban housing prices so high that their children struggle under crushing financial burdens. This revolt has boosted Bernie Sanders in the U.S., Jeremy Corbyn in Britain, Jean-Luc Mélenchon in France, and so on. Part of the youth revolt is driven by economics, but part is driven by moral contempt. Younger people look at the generations above them and see people who talk about equality but drive inequality. Members of the younger generation see the Clinton-to-Obama era—the formative years for the creative class's sensibility—as the peak of neoliberal bankruptcy.

A third rebellion is led by people who are doing well financially but who feel culturally humiliated—the boubour

rebellion. These are Mark and Patricia McCloskey, the rich St. Louis couple who waved their guns at passing Black protesters last year. These are the people who elected as mayor of Toronto the crude, brash-talking Rob Ford, who attempted to put a very non-bobo shopping mall, a suburban Disneyland, right in the center of the city. These are people who rebel against codes of political correctness.

As these rebellions arose, pundits from the creative class settled upon certain narratives to explain why there was suddenly so much conflict across society. Our first was the open/closed narrative. Society, we argued, is dividing between those who like open trade, open immigration, and open mores, on the one hand, and those who would like to close these things down, on the other. Second, and related, was the diversity narrative. Western nations are transitioning from being white-dominated to being diverse, multiracial societies. Some people welcome these changes whereas others would like to go back to the past.

Both these narratives have a lot of truth to them—racism still divides and stains America—but they ignore the role that the creative class has played in increasing inequality and social conflict.

For all its talk of openness, the creative class is remarkably insular. In *Social Class in the 21st Century*, the sociologist Mike Savage found that the educated elite tended to be the most socially parochial group, as measured by contact with people in occupational clusters different from their own. In a study for *The Atlantic*, Amanda Ripley found that the most politically intolerant Americans “tend to be whiter, more highly educated, older, more urban, and more partisan themselves.” The most politically intolerant county in the country, Ripley found, is liberal Suffolk County, Massachusetts, which includes Boston.



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If creative-class types just worked hard and made more money than other people, that might not cause such acute political conflict. What causes psychic crisis are the whiffs of “smarter than” and “more enlightened than” and “more tolerant than” that the creative class gives off. People who feel that they have been rendered invisible will do anything to make themselves visible; people who feel humiliated will avenge their humiliation. Donald Trump didn’t win in 2016 because he had a fantastic health-care plan. He won because he made the white working class feel heard.

The New Class Hierarchies

The reaction to the bobos has turned politics into a struggle for status and respect—over whose sensibility is dominant, over which groups are favored and which are denigrated. Political attitudes have displaced consumption patterns as the principal way that people signal class sensibility.

The new map of status competition is worth pausing over, because it helps explain the state of our politics today. Let’s look first at the blue hierarchy.

Atop the Democratic-leaning class ladder sits the blue oligarchy: tech and media executives, university presidents, foundation heads, banking CEOs, highly successful doctors and lawyers. The blue oligarchy leads the key Information Age institutions, and its members live in the biggest cities. They work hard; as Daniel Markovits reported in *The Meritocracy Trap*, the share of high-income workers who averaged more than 50 hours of work a week almost doubled from 1979 to 2006, while the share of the lowest earners working long hours dropped by almost a third. They are, in many respects, solid progressives; for instance, a 2017 Stanford survey found that Big Tech executives are in favor of higher taxes, redistributive welfare policies, universal health care, green environmental programs. Yet they tend to oppose anything that would make their perch less secure: unionization, government regulation that might affect their own businesses, antitrust or anti-credentialist policies.

With their amazing financial and convening power, blue oligarchs move to absorb any group that threatens their interests, co-opting their symbols, recruiting key leaders, hollowing out their messages. “Woke capitalism” may seem like corporations gravitating to the left, but it’s also corporations watering down the left. Members of the blue oligarchy sit atop systems that produce inequality—and on balance their actions suggest a commitment to sustaining them.

One step down from the blue oligarchy is the creative class itself, a broader leadership class of tenured faculty, established members of the mainstream media, urban and suburban lawyers, senior nonprofit and cultural-institution employees, and corporate managers, whose attitudes largely mirror the blue oligarchs above them, notwithstanding the petty resentments of the former toward the latter.

The bobos believe in human dignity and classical liberalism—free speech, open inquiry, tolerance of different viewpoints, personal autonomy, and pluralism—but our class has not delivered

for the people outside it. On our watch, government and other public institutions have deteriorated. Part of the problem is that, steeped in an outsider, pseudo-rebel ethos, we never accepted the fact that we were a leadership class, never took on the institutional responsibilities that go with that acceptance, never got to know or work with people not in our class, and so never earned the legitimacy and trust that is required if any group is going to effectively lead. According to the Institute for Advanced Studies in Culture, 65 percent of Americans believe that “the most educated and successful people in America are more interested in serving themselves than in serving the common good.”

One economic rung below are the younger versions of the educated elite, many of whom live in the newly gentrifying areas of urban America, such as Bedford-Stuyvesant in New York or Shaw in Washington, D.C. More diverse than the elites of earlier generations, they work in the lower rungs of media, education, technology, and the nonprofit sector. Disgusted with how their elders have screwed up the world, they are leading a revolution in moral sentiments. From 1965 to 2000, for instance, about 10 percent of



white liberals favored increased immigration. By 2018, according to Zach Goldberg, a researcher at the Center for the Study of Partisanship and Ideology, it was more than 50 percent, thanks to the influence of a rising generation on the multicultural left.

Yet wokeness is not just a social philosophy, but an elite status marker, a strategy for personal advancement. You have to possess copious amounts of cultural capital to feel comfortable using words like *intersectionality*, *heteronormativity*, *cisgender*, *problematicize*, *triggering*, and *Latinx*. By navigating a fluid progressive cultural frontier more skillfully than their hapless Boomer bosses and by calling out the privilege and moral failings of those above them, young, educated elites seek power within elite institutions.

Wokeness becomes a way to intimidate Boomer administrators and wrest power from them.

On the lowest rung of the blue ladder is the caring class, the largest in America (nearly half of all workers, by some measures), and one that in most respects sits quite far from the three above it. It consists of low-paid members of the service sector: manicurists, home health-care workers, restaurant servers, sales clerks, hotel employees. Members of this class are disadvantaged in every way. The gap in life expectancy between those in the top 40 percent and those in the bottom 40 percent widened from 1980 to 2010—from five to 12 years for men and from four to 13 years for women. Only one in 100 of the children raised in the poorest fifth of households will become rich enough to join the top 5 percent.

This hardship requires a different set of traits and values than are found in more upscale classes. Researchers report that people who feel a weaker sense of personal control are quick to form mutual-support networks; their sense of community clashes with the creative class's valorization of individualism. Other research has found that members of this class are less likely to behave unethically than the creative class when put in tempting situations.

Surveys suggest that members of this class stay at some remove from the culture wars—they are much less likely to share political content on social media than other groups, and more likely to say they “avoid arguments.” Many are centrists or detached from politics altogether, but as a whole they sit to the right of the bobos on abortion and LGBTQ issues and to the left of the bobos on issues like union power and workers' rights.

ATOP THE RED HIERARCHY is the GOP's slice of the one-percenters. Most rich places are blue, but a lot of the richest people are red. A 2012 study of the richest 4 percent of earners found that 44 percent voted Democrat that year while 41 percent voted Republican. Some are corporate executives or entrepreneurs, but many are top-tier doctors, lawyers, and other professionals who aspire to low taxes and other libertarian ideals. This is the core of the GOP donor class, men and women who feel that they worked hard for their money, that the American dream is real, and that those who built wealth in this country shouldn't have to apologize for it.

Members of this class are in many ways similar to the conservative elite of the Reagan years. Yet they too have been reshaped by the creative class's cultural dominance. When I interview members of the GOP donor class, they tell me they often feel they cannot share their true opinions without being scorned. Few of them supported Donald Trump in the 2016 GOP primaries, but by 2020 most of the red one-percenters I know had swung enthusiastically pro-Trump, because at least he's scorned by those who scorn them. It turns out that having a large investment account is no protection against self-pity.

One step down are the large property-owning families, scattered among small cities and towns like Wichita, Kansas, and Grand Rapids, Michigan—what we might call the GOP gentry. (I've adapted the coinage from what the historian Patrick Wyman has written about the local elite in his hometown of Yakima, Washington.) This gentry class derives its wealth not from salary but from the ownership of assets—furniture companies, ranches,

a bunch of McDonald's franchises. This wealth is held in families and passed down through the generations. Members of this elite stay rooted where their properties are and form the leadership class in their regions, chairing a community foundation or the local chamber of commerce.

Below them is the proletarian aristocracy, the people of the populist regatta: contractors, plumbers, electricians, middle managers, and small-business owners. People in this class have succeeded in America, but not through the channels of the university-based meritocracy, from which they feel alienated.

In other circumstances, the GOP gentry would be the natural enemies of the proletarian aristocracy, but now they are aligned. Both embrace the symbolic class markers of the sociologically low—pickup trucks, guns, country music, Christian nationalism. Both fear that their children may not be able to compete in the creative-class-controlled meritocracy. Both dislike sending their kids to schools that disdain their values, yet understand that their children will have to adopt creative-class values if they are going to be accepted in the new elite. As Thibault Muzergues writes, “The boubours and the provincial bourgeois thus have a common agenda: to unmake the Creative Class's societal transformation of the late 2000s and early 2010s.”

A level below the people of the populist regatta, you find the rural working class. Members of this class have highly supervised jobs in manufacturing, transportation, construction. Their jobs tend to be repetitive and may involve some physical danger. As the Princeton sociologist Robert Wuthnow notes, many people in this class have an identity rooted in loyalty to their small town. They are supported by networks of extended family and friends, who have grown up with one another. Like the poorer members of the blue hierarchy, they value interdependence and are less individualistic.

Many members of the red-hierarchy working class feel totally forgotten. In her book *White Working Class*, Joan C. Williams shares the account of a woman who says she raised three children on \$40,000 a year but “didn't get any assistance because we did not qualify.” Their towns are not diverse. As Wuthnow notes, two of the most common statements you hear in these towns are “Everybody knows everybody else” and “We're all pretty much the same.” If educated urbanites go out of their way to enjoy diversity and display their superior cultural taste, one-upmanship is despised in this class. Christmas Tree Shop sincerity is prized over academic, art-house pretentiousness.

By and large, members of the rural working class admire rich people who earned their wealth. Their real hatred is for “Washington”—a concept that encompasses the entire ruling class. “Those people up there in Washington, they think they know more than we do,” one of them told Wuthnow. “They treat us like second-class citizens, like we're dumb hicks.”

How the Class War Ends

As the bobos achieved a sort of stranglehold on the economy, the culture, and even our understanding of what a good life is, no wonder society has begun to array itself against them, with

the old three-part class structure breaking apart into a confusing welter of micro-groups competing for status and standing in any way they can. So, for instance, the bobos have abundant cultural, political, and economic power; the red one-percenters have economic power, but scant cultural power; the young, educated elites have tons of cultural power and growing political power, but still not much economic power; and the caring class and rural working class, unheard and unseen, have almost no power of any kind at all. Our politics, meanwhile, has become sharper-edged, more identity-based, and more reactionary, in part because politics is the one arena in which the bobos cannot dominate—there aren't enough of us.

Into this fraught, every-which-way class conflict walks Joe Biden. Weirdly, he stands outside it.

Biden is the first president since Ronald Reagan without a degree from an Ivy League university. His sensibility was formed not in the meritocracy but in the working-class neighborhoods of his youth. Condescension is alien to his nature. He has little interest in the culture-war issues that drive those at the top of the hierarchies, and spent his 2020 campaign studiously avoiding them. Biden gets prickly when he is surrounded by intellectual preening; he's most comfortable hanging around with union guys who don't pull that crap.

Biden's working-class version of progressivism is a relic from the pre-bobo era. His programs—his COVID-relief law, his infrastructure bill, his family-support proposal—represent efforts to funnel resources to those who have not graduated from college and who have been left behind by the creative-class economy. As Biden boasted in an April speech to a Joint Session of Congress, “Nearly 90 percent of the infrastructure jobs created in the American Jobs Plan do not require a college degree; 75 percent don't require an associate's degree.” Those are his people.

If there is an economic solution to the class chasms that have opened up in America, the Biden legislative package is surely it. It would narrow the income gaps that breed much of today's class animosity.

But economic redistribution only gets you so far. The real problem is the sorting mechanism itself. It determines who gets included in the upper echelons of society and who gets excluded; who gets an escalator ride to premier status and worldly success and who faces a wall.

The modern meritocracy is a resentment-generating machine. But even leaving that aside, as a sorting device, it is batshit crazy. The ability to perform academic tasks during adolescence is nice to have, but organizing your society around it is absurd. That ability is not as important as the ability to work in teams; to sacrifice for the common good; to be honest, kind, and trustworthy; to be creative and self-motivated. A sensible society would reward such traits by conferring status on them. A sensible society would not celebrate the skills of a corporate consultant while slighting the skills of a home nurse.

Some 60 years after its birth, the meritocracy seems more and more morally vacuous. Does the ability to take tests when you're young make you a better person than others? Does a society built on that ability become more just and caring?

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This situation produces a world in which the populist right can afford to be intellectually bankrupt. Right-leaning parties don't need to have a policy agenda. They just need to stoke and harvest the resentment toward the creative class.

The only way to remedy this system is through institutional reform that widens the criteria by which people get sorted. For instance, we need more pathways to success, so those who are not academically inclined have routes to social leadership; programs like national service, so that people with and without college degrees have more direct contact with one another; and an end to policies like residential zoning rules that keep the affluent segregated on top. More broadly, changing this sorting mechanism requires transforming our whole moral ecology, such that possession of a Stanford degree is no longer seen as signifying a higher level of being.

The bobos didn't set out to be an elite, dominating class. We just fit ourselves into a system that rewarded a certain type of achievement, and then gave our children the resources that would allow them to prosper in that system too. But, blind to our own power, we have created enormous inequalities—financial inequalities and more painful inequalities of respect. The task before us is to dismantle the system that raised us. *A*

David Brooks is a contributing writer at The Atlantic and a columnist for The New York Times. He is the author of The Road to Character and The Second Mountain: The Quest for a Moral Life.

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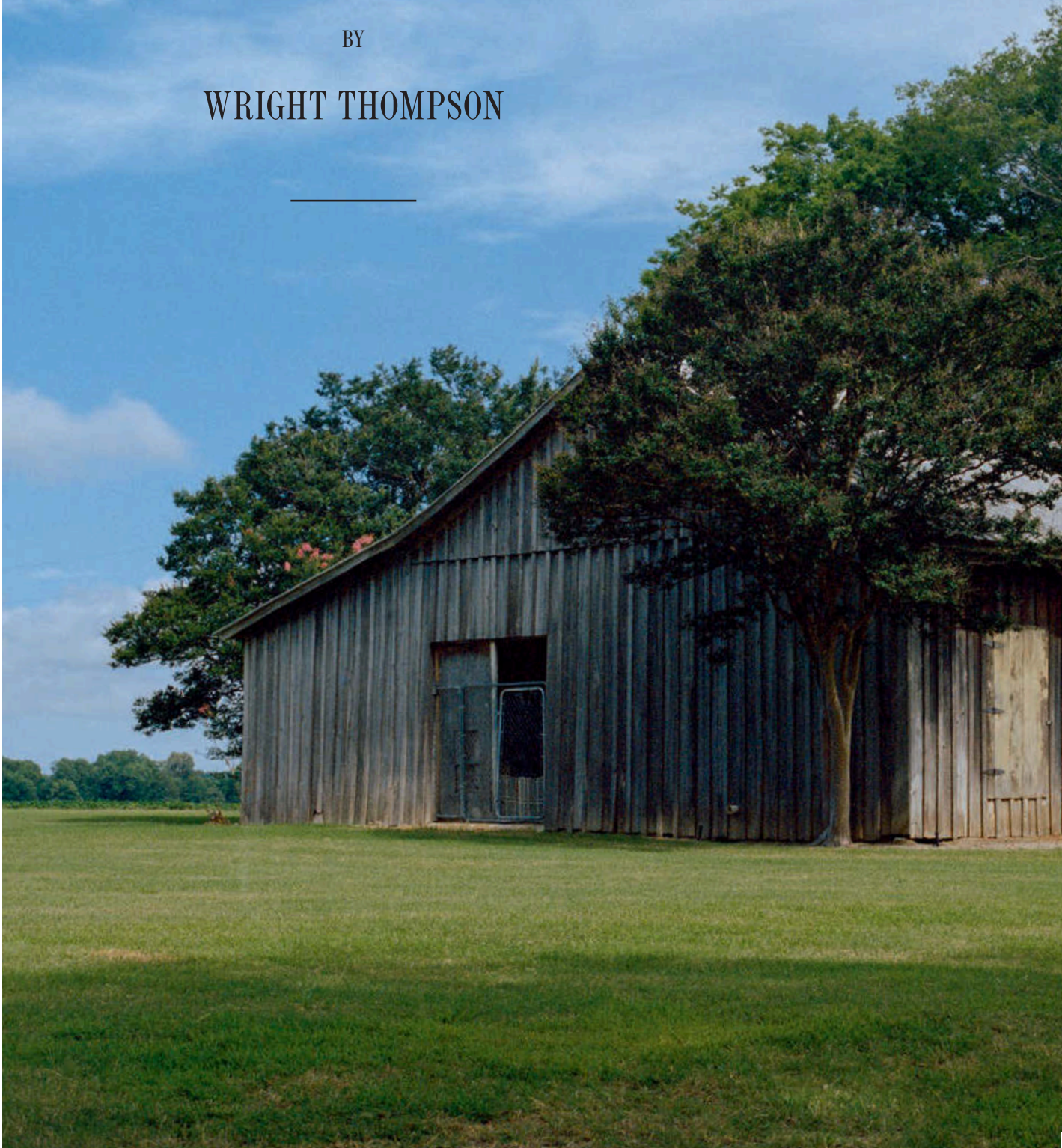


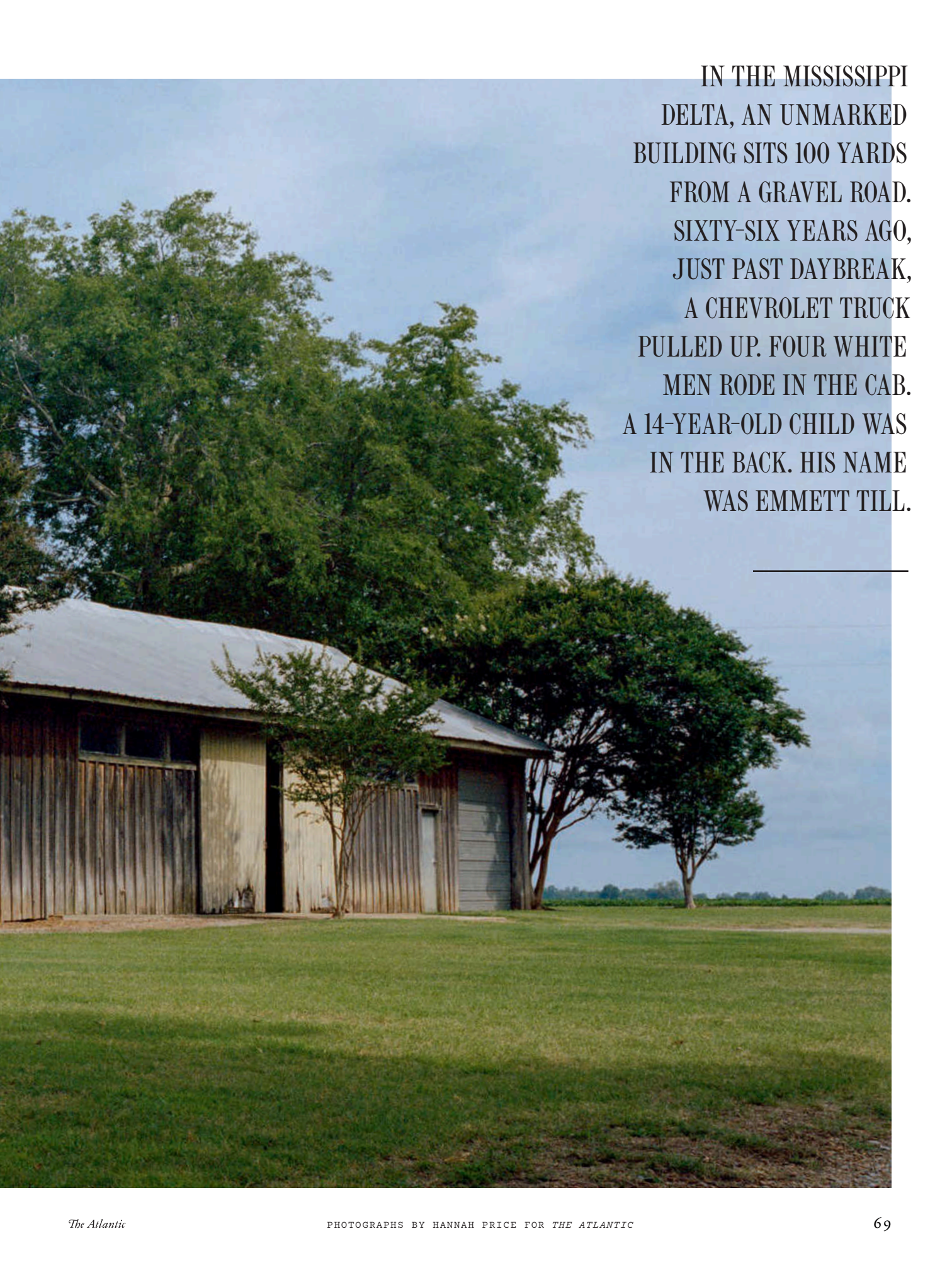
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THE BARN

BY

WRIGHT THOMPSON





IN THE MISSISSIPPI
DELTA, AN UNMARKED
BUILDING SITS 100 YARDS
FROM A GRAVEL ROAD.
SIXTY-SIX YEARS AGO,
JUST PAST DAYBREAK,
A CHEVROLET TRUCK
PULLED UP. FOUR WHITE
MEN RODE IN THE CAB.
A 14-YEAR-OLD CHILD WAS
IN THE BACK. HIS NAME
WAS EMMETT TILL.

T

The dentist was a few minutes late, so I waited by the barn, listening to a northern mockingbird in the cypress trees. His tires kicked up dust when he turned off Drew Ruleville Road and headed across the bayou toward his house. He got out of his truck still wearing his scrubs and, with a smile, extended his hand: “Jeff Andrews.”

The gravel crunched under his feet as he walked to the barn, which is long and narrow with sliding doors in the middle. Its walls are made of cypress boards, weathered gray, and it overlooks a swimming pool behind a white columned house. Jeff Andrews rolled up the garage door he’d installed.

Our eyes adjusted to the darkness of the barn where Emmett Till was tortured by a group of grown men. Christmas decorations leaned against one wall. Within reach sat a lawn mower and a Johnson 9.9-horsepower outboard motor. Dirt covered the spot where Till was beaten, and where investigators believe he was killed. Andrews thinks he was strung from the ceiling, to make the beating easier. The truth is, nobody knows exactly what happened in the barn, and any evidence is long gone. Andrews pointed to the central rafter.

“That right there is where he was hung at.”

EMMETT TILL WAS KILLED early on the morning of August 28, 1955, one month and three days after his 14th birthday. His mother’s decision to show his body in an open casket, to allow *Jet* magazine to publish photos—“Let the world see what I’ve seen,” she said—became a call to action. Three months after his murder, Rosa Parks kept her seat on a Montgomery, Alabama, bus, and she later told Mamie Till that she’d been thinking of Emmett when she refused to move. Almost 60 years later, after Trayvon Martin was killed, Oprah Winfrey channeled the thoughts of many Americans in evoking the memory and the warning of Emmett Till.

But the way Till’s name exists in the firmament of American history stands in opposition to the gaps in what we know about his killing. No one knows, for instance, how many people were involved. Most historians think at least seven were present. Only two were tried: half brothers J. W. Milam and Roy Bryant. Another half brother, Leslie Milam, was there that night too. He lived in an old white farmhouse a few dozen steps from the barn, next to where Jeff Andrews’s house now stands.

In 1955 an all-white, all-male jury, encouraged by the defense to do their duty as “Anglo-Saxons,” acquitted J. W. Milam and Roy Bryant. Because the defendants couldn’t be tried again, they got paid to make a confession to a national magazine—a heavily fictionalized account stage-managed by their lawyers—and Leslie Milam and his barn were written out of the story. Ask most people where Till died and they’ll say Money, Mississippi, the town where Till whistled at Bryant’s wife outside the family’s store. An Equal Justice Initiative monument in Montgomery says Money. Wikipedia does too. The Library of Congress website skips over the barn, which is just outside the town of Drew, about 45 minutes from the store.

I learned about the barn last year and have since made repeated visits, alone and with groups, once with members of Till’s family. Over and over, I drove from my home in the Mississippi hill country back into the gothic flatland where I was born. The barn’s existence conjures a complex set of reactions: It is a mourning bench for Black Americans, an unwelcome mirror for white Americans. It both repels and demands attention.

During one of my visits, Patrick Weems sat next to me as I navigated the backroads near Drew. A young, white Mississippian, Weems co-founded the Emmett Till Interpretive Center in nearby Sumner, to commemorate the places where Till spent the last days of his life. Weems is now working with Wheeler Parker, Till’s cousin and the last living eyewitness to the kidnapping, to create a series of monuments in Chicago, where Till grew up, and in Mississippi, where he died, with the hope that they might one day form a new national park. That’s why the barn matters now. There’s money, energy, urgency bearing down on the dentist and the long cypress building overlooking his pool, which is made somehow more menacing by the way it just sits there, unmemorialized.

One afternoon Weems and I were a little lost, surrounded by an endless landscape of soybeans and corn. I made a wide right turn around a cornfield and there it was, ordinary and freighted, hunkered in the flat, hot sun.

“Here we are,” Weems said. “Ground zero.”

WHEELER PARKER MADE that same ride not long ago. He looked out the window of a bus at overflowing rivers and submerged farmland. It would not stop raining. The flood, perhaps



The inside of the barn near Drew, Mississippi, where Emmett Till was tortured in 1955

mercifully, prevented the bus from reaching the barn. Parker sat quietly while Weems and a group of architects and planners—part of a team charged with imagining the memorials—got out and stared across the unruly bayou at the barn.

When everyone climbed back on the bus, the air felt somber. Parker didn't say much. He thinks about Till every single day, and not as a symbol or a part of American history. Parker was Till's cousin, yes, but also his best friend. They rode bikes together. Parker is 82 years old now and wants to see a memorial to Till built before he dies. Over and over, he told the people on the bus how much things had changed in Mississippi, so many times that it sounded like the person he was trying most to convince was himself. Maybe

that's why he keeps coming back here to tell this story, because he knows that all the changes he's seen remain fragile.

For white Mississippians like Jeff Andrews and me, it's possible to grow up rarely, if ever, hearing Emmett Till's name. Slipping free of the generational guilt and shame of this particular murder—a proxy for so many acts of violence and cruelty, large and small—remains a central part of a white child's education in the Delta, where a system of private schools arose in response to integration. "Seg academies," they're called. A Mississippi-history textbook taught at one in the early 1990s didn't mention Till at all. A newer textbook contains 70 words on Till, calling him a "man" and telling the story of his killing through the lens of the damage that two evil

men, J. W. Milam and Roy Bryant, did to all the good white folks. Half the passage is about how the segregationist governor was a “moderating force” in a time when media coverage of Till’s murder “painted a poor picture of Mississippi and its white citizens.” This textbook is still in use.

Jeff Andrews says he doesn’t feel personally connected to Till’s death. He didn’t know the history of his barn when he bought the property back in 1992, but now he understands its importance, and the emotional power it holds for the Till family members he welcomes on his land. Most everyone, from his patients to national civil-rights scholars, likes and respects Andrews. He winces a little when he sees people noticing his Christmas decorations. “I hate to have to show people this,” he says, “because I got so much shit in here.”

After he showed it to me, we found a place to sit in the shade by his pool. I kept looking back at the barn. He knew what I was doing.

“We don’t think about it,” Andrews said. “It’s in the past.”

Out by the barn, his yellow lab, Dixie, rolled in the hot grass near the corn.

EMMETT TILL had looked forward to his trip south from the moment his mother gave him permission to go. He was too young to understand that he was arriving in a place with a violent history just as that place was dying. For two centuries cotton had been as central to the global marketplace as oil is today, fueling commerce and war and suffering. But by 1955 the cotton economy, and the caste system sustained by it, was in a downward spiral.

A year before Till traveled to Mississippi, the Supreme Court outlawed “separate but equal” in *Brown v. Board of Education*. Mississippi and other southern states refused to comply, so the Court issued another ruling saying that they had to desegregate the public schools. Cotton prices were stagnant. Banks were calling in loans. A drought set in. Small-time operators like Leslie Milam couldn’t afford to irrigate, so already thin crops just burned in the fields. Several years without a lynching in the state ended in May 1955 when a civil-rights activist and preacher named George Lee was murdered. On August 13, a voting-rights activist named Lamar Smith was killed in Brookhaven. Seven days later, Emmett Till and his older cousin Wheeler Parker left Chicago on a southbound train.



Above: Wheeler Parker at the Roberts Temple Church of God in Christ in Chicago, where Emmett Till’s funeral was held. Opposite page: The remnants of Bryant’s Grocery in Money, Mississippi, where Till whistled at Carolyn Bryant.

Parker told me he remembers how much Till bounced around the train, bothering people with his nervous energy. His mother, whose family had fled the Delta three decades earlier, had tried to prepare him for the unwritten but ironclad rules that would govern his time in Mississippi. Say “Yes, sir” and “No, ma’am.” Don’t look white women in the eye. Be silent. Be invisible.

Mose Wright, who was in Chicago for a funeral, accompanied Parker, his grandson, and Till, his great-nephew, on the train. When they arrived in Mississippi, they drove back to



Wright's home on Dark Fear Road, east of Money. His own youngest child, Simeon, was two years younger than Till. A few days later, the boys went to Bryant's Grocery. That's where Till whistled at Carolyn Bryant, a 21-year-old white woman the press described as beautiful.

Simeon and Parker were standing right there when he whistled. They both knew immediately that there would be trouble. Parker later told me that Till saw the fear in his cousins' eyes and he got scared too. Till begged them not to tell Mose what he'd done. For the rest of his life, Simeon regretted not saying anything.

Till and Simeon shared a small bed while Parker slept in another room. A few nights later Simeon woke up to Mose standing over them with Roy Bryant and J. W. Milam, who held his pistol in one hand and a flashlight in the other. Simeon's mother begged the men not to take the boy, and offered what little money they had. The kidnappers became aggravated when Till, groggy and disoriented in the dark, insisted on putting his socks on. Simeon would never forget the look of fear on his cousin's face.

Mose followed them outside. He heard what sounded like a woman's voice saying they'd gotten the right kid, just before the men took Till and drove away. Mose stood outside staring down Dark Fear Road long after the dusty trail disappeared.

Simeon's mother swore she wouldn't sleep in that house another night, and she didn't. She moved to her brother's house that same day and from there went to Chicago, where she spent the rest of her life. A few days later, Simeon saw a sheriff's deputy come to the field to find Mose. There was a whispered conversation he couldn't hear and then he saw his father leave quietly. When Mose got home from identifying the body, he could only sit on the porch swing and grunt.

The old man agreed to testify, and when asked to identify J. W. Milam in court he pointed a finger and said in a booming voice, "There he is." Some writers made him seem simple and country, quoting him as using the word *thar*, but Simeon said his father carefully enunciated the words: *There. He. Is.* After the trial, Mose joined his wife in Chicago and never returned to Dark Fear Road. Simeon came home to Mississippi for reunions but never lived in the Delta again. He wrote a book titled *Simeon's Story*, in which he recounted that night and said he could never again hear the sound of an approaching car without thinking of 1955.

Not long before Simeon died, four years ago, he stood outside the abandoned and collapsing Bryant's Grocery in Money with a group of Till scholars and activists. They headed to their cars. Next stop: the barn. One of them turned to Simeon, an old man by then, and asked if he wanted to come. He'd never been to the barn, not once in the 60 years that had passed since that night. Simeon shook his head.

"I'm not ready yet," he said.

THE BARN'S HISTORY would have remained secret except for a single Mississippian. Early on the last morning of Emmett Till's life, a Black 18-year-old named Willie Reed awoke and walked toward the town of Drew on the dirt road that still runs past the Andrews place.

Reed was heading to a nearby country store to get breakfast. He saw a green-and-white Chevrolet pickup truck turn onto the path that led up to the barn. Four white men sat shoulder to shoulder in the cab; in the back three Black men sat with a terrified Black child. The child was Emmett Till.

Reed heard Till screaming in the barn. At one point, he saw J. W. Milam take a break and walk with a gun on his hip to a nearby well. Milam drank some cool water, then went back inside and the beating continued. The screams turned to moans.

The men talked about taking Till to a hospital, but they'd beaten him too badly to be saved. So much about this murder remains unknown, but FBI investigators believe a single gunshot to the head ended Till's life in the barn. The men threw

Simeon and Parker were
standing right there when
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cotton seeds on the floor to soak up the blood and took the body to the Tallahatchie River. They threw Till off a bridge; a cotton-gin fan tied to his neck pulled him down.

Willie Reed went to work the next day. By then word had spread, and people were starting to talk. His grandfather begged him to stay quiet and not create trouble for the family. Reed thought over and over about whether he should tell the truth about what he'd seen and heard.

A RETIRED FBI AGENT named Dale Killinger knows more about the murder of Emmett Till than anyone else alive. Killinger was the lead agent when the FBI opened a federal investigation in 2004, with the potential to finally bring charges against Carolyn Bryant for her presumed role in the murder.

Leslie Milam's wife called a preacher named Macklyn Hubbell and asked him to come to their home. Milam "said he was involved in the killing of Emmett Till," Hubbell says. "He was releasing himself of guilt. He was belching out guilt."

I talked to Killinger on the phone one afternoon about the violence in the barn. The next time we spoke he told me that his wife had been sitting next to him during that graphic conversation, and when he'd hung up, she'd turned to him with a hollow look in her eyes and asked him why they'd done it. Even when people know generally what happened to Till, the specifics still leave them gasping.

"Rhea, don't you understand?" he told her. "They were entertained by this."

"What do you mean?" she said.

"They could've killed and tortured him anywhere they wanted to," he told her. "They chose to take him to a barn where they could control the environment and do what they wanted. In my mind, they were entertaining themselves."

He told me he's imagined the sounds of that night over and over. He interviewed Leslie Milam's widow before she died and found her evasive.

"Frances Milam was home," he said. "She was in the house. You think she heard what was going on?"

Killinger laughed bitterly and answered his own question. "Hell yeah, she did," he said. "It's 1955 and you don't have air-conditioning. So she admitted that they brought him to the farm in the middle of the night. That's in the FBI report. So she was there and they were beating him and eventually somebody shot him in that barn in the head. You hear everything in Mississippi! You know? The windows are open. You have window screening—that's all you have. You hear a car coming a mile away. You hear somebody getting beat in your barn! You hear a gunshot! Think about why they chose to go to that barn. They chose it because Leslie Milam controlled that space. And they could go in there and do what they wanted, how they wanted. And why would you do that? You could have taken him off in the woods and killed him if you wanted to, right? Dump the body anywhere. They went out of their way."

THE WHITE MISSISSIPPIS who lived around the barn responded to the killing like an organism fighting an infection. A new narrative took hold, about how the community of good white people was unfairly tarnished by the actions of a few monsters. In 1955, the editorial page of the *Chicago Defender*, the preeminent Black newspaper in the country, chronicled this self-absolution as it happened. "Most of the educated upper class white Mississippians are desperately trying to disassociate themselves from the lynchers," the paper said, "trying to show that they are civilized and do not approve of such racial violence."

Three months after Till's death, according to records in the Sunflower County courthouse, Leslie Milam's landlord, Ben Sturdivant, sold the property and threw him off the land. Last summer, his grandson Walker Sturdivant showed me into his office on the family's sprawling farm. All around were the telltale signs of old Delta money: a chair from a fancy boarding school, a Union Planters Bank espresso cup, photographs from ski vacations. Walker's dad was a respected, progressive politician, and the family had recently helped the Emmett Till Interpretive Center acquire land for a memorial site on the Tallahatchie River.

Before we talked, Walker had gone down to the courthouse to pull up the old rental agreements and land records so he'd have his facts straight. It's all there, in red leather-bound books. "Immediately after it happened," he said, "that's when he exited from his relationship. Dad always said J. W. Milam and Roy Bryant both had been ostracized in the white community after what they had done. The people just decided: At least the code said you don't do that to children."

During the trial, people put up jars in stores around the Delta to raise money for Bryant and Milam, but once the pair got paid for the magazine confession, they were essentially exiled. Bryant lost his store because almost all his customers had been Black and nobody would shop there anymore. He moved around a lot, broke and shunned. J. W. Milam lived out his final years in a Black neighborhood, the only place he could afford. He kept getting in trouble—for writing bad checks, for assault, for using a stolen credit card.

Leslie Milam lived better than his brothers but only marginally so. Nineteen years after the murder, his wife called their minister, a Baptist preacher from Cleveland, Mississippi, named Macklyn Hubbell. She asked him to come to their home, on the outskirts of town. Milam wanted a moment of his time, a meeting first reported in Devery S. Anderson's book *Emmett Till*. Hubbell drove over to the house, and Frances led him into a room where Milam was stretched out on the couch. "I remember exactly," Hubbell, 90 years old and sharp, told me. "I remember approaching the couch where he was lying."

The preacher pulled up a straight-backed chair.

Milam looked him right in the eye and began to speak.

"It was a confession between Leslie and me," Hubbell said. "And I didn't share it with anybody until Leslie was gone and Frances was gone. Because they are gone, I can tell you what Leslie said. I remember that he said he was involved in the killing of Emmett Till. He wanted to tell me, because he perceived me to be a man of God. He was releasing himself of guilt. He was belching out guilt."

Hubbell listened and prayed, and then he left the small ranch house on a street surrounded by farmland. Milam died before sunrise. He's buried in Drew, a few miles from the barn where he helped torture and kill a child.

ONE OF THE THINGS Dale Killinger did when the FBI opened its case was go looking for Willie Reed, the man who as an 18-year-old had heard Till screaming in the barn. Reed had ignored the warnings of his grandfather and agreed to testify. He said later he couldn't have lived with himself if he'd stayed quiet.

After the trial, mobs searched the Delta for the witnesses. Reed knew he needed to escape. He walked and ran six miles from his home outside Drew. A car waited at a rendezvous spot and carried him to Memphis, where for the first time in his life he boarded an airplane. U.S. Congressman Charles Diggs of Detroit flew with him as an escort. When they landed in Chicago, all Reed had were the clothes on his back plus a coat and an extra pair of pants.

He tried to start a new life in Chicago but suffered a breakdown. Eventually, he changed his name to Willie Louis and got a job at Jackson Park Hospital, where he met a woman named Juliet. They married and bought a home in the Englewood neighborhood, on the South Side. They both worked at the hospital for decades, she as a nurse and he as an orderly.

Juliet didn't know about her husband's old name until they'd been together for at least a decade. Then, in the 1980s, a journalist tracked him down. An aunt had given the reporter his address. Quickly realizing that she shouldn't have done that, the aunt called Juliet to let her know what was about to happen.

"Do you know who Willie is?" she asked.

"He's Willie!" Juliet said.

"He's the boy that testified in the Emmett Till trial."

That's how Juliet learned about her husband's previous life. Willie was angry at his aunt but told the reporter everything. Juliet listened. After that, he'd talk about Till occasionally, but only if someone asked. "He was trying to forget," she says.

Sometimes Juliet would catch Willie lost in silence.

"What's wrong?" she'd ask.

"I was just thinking about Emmett," he'd reply, then fall silent once more. He told her that he was reliving Till's screams.

Two more decades passed, and then Killinger called. He said that the United States needed Willie Louis to go back to Mississippi. Back to the barn, so he could walk agents through his old testimony and be ready to give it again. Louis invited Killinger to the house in Englewood, and Killinger promised to be by his side every moment. Only then did he agree.

The FBI bought Willie and Juliet plane tickets and flew them down South, into the Memphis airport. The next morning, Willie looked out on newly planted cotton fields as the men from the FBI drove him deeper into the Delta. Killinger wondered what he must have been thinking. Until the day his grandfather died, the old man had told anyone who'd listen that Willie should have kept his mouth shut. Willie had built a new life in Chicago, a respected quiet life, but the feeling of exile had never quite gone away.

They drove mostly in silence. After two hours, they turned onto Drew Ruleville Road and parked. Willie Louis became Willie Reed again. He stood on the empty grass where he'd once lived. His house was long gone, and so was the country store where he'd been headed when he saw the truck.

Louis moved slowly up the road, across the bayou and the dentist's manicured lawn.

"I could hear screaming," he said.

"Which part of the barn?" Killinger asked.

"On the right side," he said.

Then Willie Louis got to the barn itself. Killinger watched him closely as he walked into a past reaching out to grab him, back into a life he'd left behind. Everything felt new and strange. The old man stood with his arms out, like someone who'd lost his balance, and he tried to make sense of then and now on this terrible piece of dirt.

WILLIE LOUIS DIED in 2013, and Simeon Wright died in 2017, leaving Wheeler Parker as the last surviving witness to the kidnapping. He's working on a memoir. He wrote it in longhand and his wife, Marvel, typed it for him, at times weeping as she read things she hadn't known, even after five decades of marriage.

Now a pastor, Parker met me this past spring in a Chicago suburb at a community center named for Till. It sits on a piece of land where he and Till used to play.

"Cowboys and Indians," he said with a smile.

The community center is just feet from where his grandfather Mose Wright used to keep a vegetable garden after he testified in the trial. A painting of the store in Money hangs on the wall near portraits of Martin Luther King Jr. and Barack Obama.

That week in 1955 was the defining moment in Parker's life. He remembers riding the train south from Chicago with Till. He remembers hearing Till whistle at Carolyn Bryant, and he remembers the night when J. W. Milam shined a flashlight in his face.

"They came to me," he said. "I was shaking like a leaf. Whole bed was shaking. I closed my eyes and said, 'This is it.' And I was praying. I said, 'God if you just let me live, I will be doing right,' because I thought of every evil little thing I've done wrong, you know? Oh, man, I was begging."



The Tallahatchie River, near where Till's body was discovered

He looked at me, and there was silence. It was 1955 again for just a moment.

I asked him how many people are alive who grew up with him and Till.

He started counting.

"Well, around here," he said, and the names started coming: first his own brothers, then a local shoeshine man who used to play war games with them right where we were sitting. He kept rattling them off: Joanne, Mary Ellen, Louise, Lee. Nine or 10, he finally told me. He paused.

"Ms. Bryant's gonna be 87 this year," Parker said. "She's five years older than I am. I'm 82 last week."

IN THE DECADES after the murder, the old Bryant's Grocery in Money became a strange underground tourist attraction, a place that offered truths about America, or maybe just satisfied some morbid curiosity. The family of one of the jurors bought the store and then let it collapse. Now the building is falling in on itself, overgrown with vines, ivy, and trees. In the owners' desire for the store not to become a monument to a killing, it's become something else: a monument to the desire, and ultimate failure, of white Mississippi to erase the stain of Till's death.

Meanwhile, the barn vanished from the popular account of the murder, and then it faded from all but a few local memories,

too. The land around it just kept on being plowed and planted and harvested. A local farmer named Reg Shurden and his family moved into the farmhouse next to the barn in the late 1950s. They didn't stay long. Shurden's wife didn't like it and never really explained why.

"When my grandmother was still living, I didn't realize that's where Emmett Till had been killed," Stafford Shurden says. "Now I wonder, did she hate it because she knew that happened?"

In the early 1960s, a couple from Missouri, the Buchanans, moved onto the farm with their two children. Their son, Bob, was a junior in high school then. He says his father didn't know the history of the land when he bought it. The barn was just where they stored seed and farm equipment. But one day he was in there helping out when someone pointed.

"That's where they tied up Emmett Till," the man told him.

Buchanan says he didn't think about it much after that. His family never discussed it, even among themselves. They just went on with their lives.

In the early 1980s, Bob's mother rented the land near the barn to Reg Shurden's nephew Steve. "Miss Buchanan was a sassy old little lady when I knew her," Steve says. "The house was getting run-down then. She kept talking about how she was going to fix it up."

He knew about the barn.

"We didn't think about it," he says. "I mean, it wasn't anything to talk about."

His cousin Stafford sat with us at a Drew lunch spot as we talked.

"As a kid, I didn't know who Emmett Till was," he said.

Mrs. Buchanan refused to leave even as the house deteriorated around her. Finally, sometime before 1985, she moved out and the place sat abandoned. High-school kids started going out there to drink. They would sit in the dark front room, with the big bay windows looking out on the cypress trees and the bayou, and either they didn't know Emmett Till had died there or they didn't care. I bet they didn't know. That innocence was what their parents and grandparents had wanted. Sometimes the kids would go through Mrs. Buchanan's drawers and find old farm bills and letters and paperwork. It was like she'd up and vanished one day.

Jeff Andrews loved the view across the bayou, and after Mrs. Buchanan died he begged Bob and his sister to sell him the property. He pestered them for close to a year until they relented. He'd lived in Drew for most of his life. He didn't know he'd bought the barn where Emmett Till was killed. Nobody told him.

Around the time of the sale, on a spring Saturday night, the house caught fire. Instead of paying to have the debris removed, Andrews got a bulldozer and a crew to dig a big hole and push the ruins of Leslie Milam's old home into the hole and cover it up with Mississippi dirt. He built a new house, and finally his father told him about the barn. Andrews never asked his dad why he hadn't mentioned it sooner.

A GROUP OF FBI AGENTS once asked Wheeler Parker what justice looked like to him. That's a hard question. His cousin Simeon always wanted to see Carolyn Bryant behind bars. Parker told the agents he just wanted people to know the truth.

Over the decades, evidence and facts had slowly vanished. The only copy of the trial transcript disappeared, and FBI agents had to track down a copy of a copy of a copy, which a source led them to at a private residence on the Mississippi Gulf Coast. The ring Till had been wearing, which had belonged to his father, vanished. In the 1970s, the Sumner courthouse was renovated and old evidence was discarded. A lawyer in Sumner looked on the curb of the courthouse and saw the gin fan that had been used to sink Till's body sitting with all sorts of meaningless trash bound for the dump. He took it as a trophy but soon threw it away.

A recording of Roy Bryant's account of that night in 1955 exists. The tapes are either in Mississippi or in Los Angeles, where the United American Costume Company is based. That's the company founded by John Wayne's personal costumer, a native of Ruleville, Mississippi, named Luster Bayless. Decades ago, Bayless decided he wanted to make a movie about the Till murder and so he arranged an interview with Bryant. A microcassette recorder captured every word as Bryant drove around the Delta, re-creating the night of the murder; it is likely the only existing description of what happened inside the barn in the final hour of Till's life. Bryant even posed for a Polaroid in front of the store. Other than FBI agents and a few random people, nobody has heard the recording.

These tapes contain something other than facts, although they contain lots of those, too. They contain the sound of Bryant's voice, the way his laugh sounds when he recounts torturing a child, the way he draws his vowels, the little details that let you know a human being did this terrible thing. Locals remember Bryant as an old man, blinded by a lifetime of welding, working at a store on Highway 49 in Ruleville, eight miles from the barn.

The researcher Bayless hired, a woman named Cecelia Lusk, told me she went to the libraries at Delta State and Ole Miss and was stunned. Stories about Till had been torn out of magazines in the archives. In both of the courthouses in Tallahatchie County, she said, she found the legal file folders for the case. They were empty. "Not one sheet of paper," she said. "Someone had removed everything. There was absolutely not one piece of paper in those folders."

This is the world of silence Killinger entered when he started asking questions around the Delta, trying to find Wheeler Parker's idea of justice and maybe Simeon's too. He went to Carolyn



Jeff Andrews grew up in the area but didn't know the history of the barn when he bought the property in 1992.

Bryant's home to question her; when she dies, that interview will become public. He tracked down missing transcripts and uncovered new evidence. A forensic team searched Andrews's barn but came up empty.

A central pillar in the 1955 defense of Milam and Bryant had been that the body Mamie Till buried was not, in fact, her son's—that it was instead a body planted by the NAACP. One juror later told a reporter that he'd voted to acquit because the body had chest hair and everyone knew that Black men couldn't grow chest hair until they were about 30. Killinger knew prosecutors would have to deal with that accusation if they were to bring charges against Carolyn Bryant, and so he had to ask the Till family for permission to bring up the body and conduct a DNA test.

The family held a small service, and then the diggers went to work. They removed the concrete vault and then the casket. After the casket came out, the vault crumbled. Emmett Till had been buried in a glass-top coffin, and the glass hadn't broken. The assembled people gasped, according to Killinger, who was there. The embalmer, Woodrow "Champ" Jackson, a Black man from Tutwiler, Mississippi, had clearly done his work with care. Emmett Till looked just as he did when they put him in the grave. The FBI photos taken in 2005 looked almost exactly like the famous *Jet* pictures that helped spark the civil-rights movement.

Killinger presented his report and waited; he thought there was enough evidence for an indictment. But nothing happened. A local prosecutor tried—not hard enough, in Killinger's opinion—to indict Carolyn Bryant for manslaughter, but a grand jury declined. That was 14 years ago. A reporter heard the news and found Simeon Wright at his local church. He said he knew he didn't have many years left and now he knew he'd die without seeing Carolyn Bryant spend a minute behind bars. The members of the grand jury looked in the mirror, he said, and didn't like what they saw.

I CALLED JEFF ANDREWS a month or two after my first visit to the barn and asked if I could come back and talk. I explained that I felt compelled to do this story because one of the central conflicts for white Mississippians is whether to shine a bright light on the past or—

“—move on?” he said, finishing my thought.

That remains a fraught and divisive question for white Mississippians. Should you dig deep enough that you might come to hate a place you also love? When Andrews graduated from dental school, he and his wife visited a town in Alabama where a practice was for sale. They both liked the area and thought they could make a great living—and a great new life—there. But they both felt out of place. “It's a long way from home,” Jeff's wife said.

They moved back to Drew and have never left. Last year, Andrews went duck hunting 40 of 65 possible days. He drives a tractor in the early morning and late afternoon, working his soybean fields and listening to sports talk radio. He never got rich, but he's built the kind of life he dreamed about. Andrews talks about the love he feels for the land around his home—not just the piece he owns, but all of it, a kind of spiritual homeland. His family arrived here by way of a New Deal program two generations ago. He still farms the original 40 acres that his grandfather farmed, about a mile from the barn.

Andrews and I talked on and off in the months that followed our first meeting. He seemed genuinely at ease. He told me it didn't bother him to own the barn, or sleep near it, or grill while kids splashed in the pool in its shadow. I couldn't understand how the knowledge of what had happened there wasn't grinding away somewhere deep inside him. How a place that was the literal site of the torture and execution of a 14-year-old boy could be a place of such peace for him.

Finally, at his suggestion, I got in touch with a woman who'd written a book about her experiences communicating with the spirit of Emmett Till. She asked whether I'd talked to the Andrews family about the noises and lights. I said I had not. They've seen and felt



One of the signs commemorating Till's death. A sign at another site collected more than 100 bullet holes before it was taken down and given to the Smithsonian.

things, she told me. A flash. A rush of movement. They've heard noises. The woman said Andrews's wife talks to Till sometimes.

I asked Andrews about this, and he hemmed and hawed but eventually told me that his daughter believes Till's spirit is on their land, that their home is haunted by the memory of the boy who died there. Let that idea sit for a moment: If ghosts aren't real, which they're not, and if these apparitions are the only way for deeply buried feelings to find the light of day, then the gap between what the Andrewses allow themselves to know and what they keep buried inside is the exact gap that memorials are designed to bridge. And so Jeff Andrews has a choice.

Money is being raised to buy the barn and turn it into a memorial, with the idea that it might one day become part of the national park Wheeler and Marvel Parker hope to create. The Parkers want the centerpiece of that project to be the Chicago church where Till's funeral was held and where the world saw his open casket. That is the story of Mamie Till's courage and strength, whereas the barn is a symbol of white violence and fear. The barn remains a mirror.

Andrews knows an offer is likely coming for his land and home, and he isn't sure what he's going to do.

FOURTEEN YEARS AGO, Tallahatchie County issued a formal apology for the acquittal of Roy Bryant and J. W. Milam. The state installed a green historical marker outside the courthouse. Patrick Weems's office is across the street from that sign, so he can literally point out his window at progress. But he can also point to the repeated vandalism of signs his organization has worked to erect. There was a marker at the Delta Inn, the hotel where jurors were sequestered and where, during the trial, a cross was burned just in case any of the jurors didn't understand what their neighbors expected of them. That marker was taken down one night by vandals and has not been replaced. A sign was placed along the Tallahatchie River, where Till's body was found, but someone threw it in the water. A replacement collected more than 100 bullet holes until, made illegible by the violence, it came down and was given to the Smithsonian. A third sign got shot a month after it went up. Three Ole Miss students posed before the sign with guns, and one posted the photo to Instagram. The current sign is bulletproof.

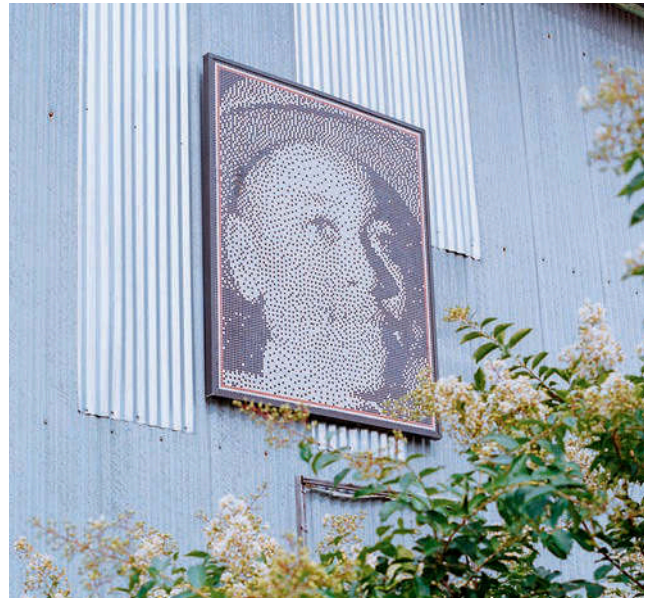
Little about this murder feels safely in the past. Wheeler Parker is alive. So is Carolyn Bryant. Many of the children and grandchildren of the killers and the jurors and the defense attorneys still live in the area. The barn is still just a barn. One man claims that the truck used to kidnap Till is rusting right now on a Glendora plantation. Two of the four men suspected of being in the cab of that truck back in 1955 went unnamed in public until Killinger's FBI report was released. Till's ring remains missing, and the legal files remain missing.

But J. W. Milam's gun, which Willie Reed saw strapped to his hip and Wheeler Parker saw when the flashlight hit his face, isn't one of the many pieces of this story that vanished without a trace. The FBI suspects that it didn't vanish at all. When I first heard that the gun might still be in the Delta, I didn't believe it. Then I got a local crop-duster pilot on the phone. Yes, he confirmed, he and his sister believe they own J. W. Milam's military-issue pistol, as well as the holster. The siblings don't really know what to do with the gun. Maybe, the pilot said, they could get local celebrity Morgan Freeman to buy it from them and donate it to a museum. The pilot explained that their father had gotten the gun from one of Milam's attorneys, and upon their father's death it passed down to them. Right now, he said, that gun is locked away in a safety-deposit box in a bank in Greenwood, Mississippi. It's a model 1911-A1 .45-caliber semiautomatic, made by Ithaca, serial number 2102279. The gun still fires.

THIS SPRING, Wheeler Parker drove me around Argo, Illinois, southwest of Chicago, showing me the places where he grew up. He told me more about the group of old men who went to elementary school with Till all those decades ago. They were planning to gather on what would have been Till's 80th birthday for a weekend celebration. Parker said the old guys sit around and tell stories about the place where they were born.

"Oh," he said, "Mississippi is talked about all the time."

He laughed.



Till's image is displayed on the building in Glendora, Mississippi, where the killers are believed to have gotten the cotton-gin fan to weigh down his body.

"Behind the iron curtain," he said.

He pulled over in front of an empty lot with houses on both sides. This little industrial suburb is where Emmett Till lived before he and Mamie moved to the South Side. The kids used to play across all these yards. An old fire hydrant is out front, and Parker looked at it closely. It's the original. The fire hydrant remains but the home is long gone.

"Emmett Till's house is right here," he said, pointing to the empty grass. "And 7524, our house, was right next door here."

They rode bikes together on this street. They told jokes and made plans. Till wanted to do whatever his older cousin Parker was doing. That's why he asked his mom to let him go to Mississippi. Because Parker was going down to visit his grandparents. Till begged. Mamie said no at first but finally relented. Parker had to face Mamie when he got back to Chicago from the Delta. He still remembers how guilty he felt in her presence for surviving, and he will forever carry that guilt, and also the resolve it put in him.

He and Marvel are raising money for the memorials, to make sure that when they die, and the others who knew Emmett Till die, Till's story will be remembered. They will continue telling his story for as long as they're able. Because Till rode his bike on this street. Because the gun still fires, because the barn is still just a barn, because time is thin and fragile, because the dirt Jeff Andrews and I were taught to love is the exact same dirt Wheeler Parker was taught to fear. *A*

Wright Thompson is a senior writer for ESPN.

Culture & Critics



OMNIVORE

The Heroine's Journey

In Joseph Campbell's classic study of world myths, women were in the background. A new book puts them at the center of the story.

By James Parker

It's one of the darkest and bloodiest episodes in Ovid's *Metamorphoses*. King Tereus of Thrace, having lusted after his sister-in-law, Philomela, inveigles her away from her father's protection, takes her to a forest dungeon, and rapes her. Philomela, towering in eloquence, vows to tell the world what Tereus has done; her raised voice, she promises him in Arthur Golding's 1567 translation, will "make the stones to understand." So Tereus cuts her tongue out. Ovid, characteristically, zooms in: The wound pours; the severed tongue bounces and mutely spasms—"as an adder's tail cut off doth skip a while," in Golding's version. More modern retellers of *The Metamorphoses* have been similarly transfixed. From Ted Hughes's *Tales From Ovid* (1997): "The tongue squirmed in the dust, babbling on—Shaping words that were now soundless." From Nina MacLaughlin's *Wake, Siren* (2019): "Please imagine how it continues to wriggle, how it twitches and moves on the dirt floor."

It barely qualifies as mythic, the story of Philomela. A sexual assault, a silencing, a mutilated testimony—there is nothing supernatural about any of this. The germ of hope in the tale is that Philomela is not silenced; still trapped by her abductor, the speechless princess secretly weaves her denunciation of Tereus into the imagery of a tapestry, which she then sends to her sister.

For the distinguished folklorist Maria Tatar, Philomela's resourcefulness—literally, her craftiness—places her in a secret lineage of truth-telling women. "Silenced women are not without tools," Tatar writes in her new book, *The Heroine With 1001 Faces*, "and Philomela reminds us that so-called women's work—weaving, sewing, and working with coverings—provides an opportunity not just to create but also to communicate." Female *telling*, however hopeless or subterranean, is a

fairy-tale motif, as Tatar shows us: There's the Goose Girl in the Brothers Grimm, who opens her heart to an iron stove, and the Armenian tale of Nourie Hadig, mistreated and betrayed, who confides in the sympathetic Stone of Patience. (This stone really does understand; hearing Nourie's story, it swells with pity.) Dimensions converge in Tatar's book: deep, shimmering, archetypal time and the urgency of the present moment. "From Myth to #MeToo" is the subtitle of one of her chapters. "Telling your story," she writes—"revealing injuries inflicted and harm done—has come to be invested with unprecedented weight."

The Heroine With 1001 Faces is not exactly a rebuttal to Joseph Campbell's 1949 classic, *The Hero With a Thousand Faces*—but it is a counter-book. Campbell famously and rather rapturously identified the "monomyth": the single great life-giving story that expresses itself in endless variations through the legendarium of every tribe and culture. The Call to Adventure, the Ordeal/Initiation, the Trouble in the Third Act, the Return—this is the Hero's Journey, schematized by Campbell and unblinkingly cloned in a zillion Hollywood screenplays. We all use it, to a degree, writers and nonwriters. The voyage, the pilgrimage, the vision quest are part of our mental circuitry. "It's difficult to avoid the sensation," wrote Christopher Vogler in his best-selling *The Writer's Journey: Mythic Structure for Writers*, "that the Hero's Journey exists somewhere, somehow, as an eternal reality, a Platonic ideal form, a divine model." But what if the divine model excludes women? Tatar is decisive: "Driven by conflict and conquest, this narrative arc utterly fails as a model of women's experience."

It's not like there are *no* women in *The Hero With a Thousand Faces*. Look, there she is in the index: *woman*, right between *wolf image* and *womb-image*. The problem is, of the hero's 1,000 faces, 999 are male. Aeneas, the Buddha, Taliesin, Cuchulainn ... Campbell's prose, often wonderful, never less than sonorous, actually goes a bit demented when he writes about "woman": "Woman is the guide to the sublime acme of sensuous adventure." She may be the muse, the grail, or the goddess. She may be the source of being, or she may be bottomless death. But the adventure itself, with its conquering of monsters and quelling of demons—that's for the blokes. It's linear, phallic, acquisitive. "The woman is life, the hero its knower and master."

Tatar has had enough of this. "Suddenly," she writes in the introduction to her book, "I understood the rage of one of my undergraduate students, who described her journey into the world of folklore and mythology as a crusade against Campbell." The genial Campbell might have been surprised to discover himself, in this particular heroic journey, playing the role of dragon/ogre. Then again, he was all for transfiguration. Things change; it's a precondition for the great quest. "The familiar life horizon," as he wrote in *The Hero With a*

Thousand Faces, "has been outgrown; the old concepts, ideals, and emotional patterns no longer fit; the time for the passing of a threshold is at hand."

I had hoped that Tatar would do for the Hero's Journey and its tropes what Hannah Gadsby did for stand-up comedy in her special *Nanette*—lay bare its essentially male mechanism and then, with great precision, blow it up. What gorgeous organic form might the Heroine's Journey take? A wave, a spiral, a magnetic field?

But *The Heroine With 1001 Faces* is not that kind of book. Not a guide to gynocentric plot-building—more of a roaming miscellany of heroines across the ages. Tatar sent me on a superb binge of reading and rereading: Angela Carter's daredevil retellings and renewals of Little Red Riding Hood and Puss in Boots in *The Bloody Chamber*, her language running wild over the material; Anne Sexton's *Transformations*, whose jolting, funny/horrific poems are a kind of biological absorption and mutation of the cruel old tales. "It's not the prince at all, / but my father / drunkenly bent over my bed, / circling the abyss like a shark ..." As Marina Warner observes in her indispensable *Fairy Tale: A Very Short Introduction*, in these poems, "you can glimpse the broken trust in families, as well as the suffocating limits on women's horizons. You can hear the desperation that drove women mad."

And when, primed by Tatar and her heroines, I picked up Sinéad O'Connor's new memoir, *Rememberings*, my head—in a manner of speaking—exploded. O'Connor has left a unique imprint on pop-cultural memory: the unnervingly transparent gaze, the hyperborean wail, the songs. And of course, the trouble. In October 1992, as a protest against the Catholic Church's culture of child abuse, O'Connor went on *Saturday Night Live*, performed—in a voice as keen as the stroke of an ax—an a cappella version of Bob Marley's "War," and then ripped into pieces a photograph of Pope John Paul II. The vilification was instantaneous; her sanity was questioned; her career was generally assumed to be over. Thirteen days later, she took the stage at Madison Square Garden to perform in a Bob Dylan tribute concert. She was met by a noise she had never heard before, deafening, undifferentiated crowd-roar—half love, half hate, with hate in the ascendant. "Like a sonic riot," she writes in *Rememberings*, "as if the sky is ripping apart." We pass here into the mythic. The Church, classic rock, American manhood—all arrayed howling against her, like terraces of burning angels. Was this the Ordeal/Initiation, or the battle with the dragon itself? Looking back, we know she was right. In the moment, she faced the storm alone. Transformations and metamorphoses have been undergone since then; reckonings and vindications have occurred. But the wages of heroism, real heroism—they don't change. *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

What gorgeous form might the Heroine's Journey take? A wave, a spiral, a magnetic field?

THE HEROINE
WITH
1001 FACES

Maria Tatar

LIVERIGHT

BOOKS

The Would-Be Savior of Patagonia

Are environmental crusaders like Douglas Tompkins good for the planet?

By Michael O'Donnell



Patagonia as many of us imagine it was born in 1968. That year, the vast region of South America became an exotic destination for outdoor adventure. Of course, residents of Chile and Argentina did not need their backyard discovered any more than Native Americans needed Christopher Columbus. But to a group of young men in California, the landscape held a mystical appeal. That summer they set out by van to drive 16,000 miles southward, drawn by the peak of Fitz Roy, a forbidding mountain that no American had ever summited. Despite weeks of storms, they succeeded. The five men returned home with film footage of breathtaking terrain at the ends of the Earth. Their 1968 expedition has enjoyed a romantic legacy, inspiring countless adventurers—and, in a way, outfitting them as well. One member of the party, Yvon Chouinard, later founded the apparel company Patagonia. The instigator of the trip, Douglas Tompkins, had already launched The North Face.

Tompkins, the group's alpha male, traveled in search of achievement and discovery, but his journey was also an abandonment. The six-month trip stranded his wife, Susie Tompkins, with two very young children as she attempted to start her own clothing business, Plain Jane. Tompkins tossed her some cash and wished her luck (returning for a brief stint of troubleshooting, and then leaving again). She found herself in fearful limbo when the group was months overdue in returning from the dangerous ascent. A film of the expedition, called *Mountain of Storms*, elides these tensions. It shows Tompkins having his fortune read in a Central American city and being told that his family is thinking of him. The film then cuts to gauzy scenes of domestic life accompanied by guitars and flutes. Two children play happily with their father as his wife cradles his head and feeds him crackers. In a voice-over, Tompkins marvels at his own freedom of movement: "You never really thought about the motives."

One adventurer's selfish act more than 50 years ago might not bear emphasizing—except that Tompkins later became a famous altruist who renounced the business world and moved to a cabin in Patagonia. There he used his wealth to become what his biographer, Jonathan Franklin, calls "among the greatest conservationists of his generation." From the early 1990s until his death in 2015, Tompkins led a campaign to preserve more than 10 million acres of wilderness in Patagonia, helping build or expand more than a dozen national parks throughout Chile and Argentina. In *A Wild Idea*, Franklin compares him, in his mercurial zeal and undaunted ambition on multiple fronts, to Bill Gates and Steve Jobs.

By now, we're accustomed to the spectacle of visionary entrepreneurs who don't excel in empathy, and literature reminds us of the long lineage of philanthropic myopia. Think of Mrs. Jellyby in Dickens's *Bleak House*, fervently dedicated to a mission in Africa while her own brood goes neglected. Tompkins's story reveals a new incarnation of the type, the imperious progressive as global savior. In the era of climate change, he is a figure who should prompt questions along with admiration. "It doesn't matter," he said of the bad publicity he accrued. "In fifty years they will be building statues of me." In the half decade since his death, he has indeed been lionized as a giant of the environmental movement. But is relying on crusaders like Tompkins what's best for the planet?

RAISED IN the Hudson Valley in a Mayflower-pedigreed family, Tompkins grew up watching his father acquire museum-grade pieces of antique furniture. In this way the young Tompkins cultivated his own eye for perfection. He was a star athlete in prep school, bound for the Ivy League until he crossed paths with Chouinard on a rock-climbing trip. Thus began a lifelong friendship between entrepreneurial rebels; one of the pleasures of *A Wild Idea* is Franklin's patient chronicling of the connection, and the contrasts, between the two men over the years. Tompkins fell in with the dirt-bag crowd and got himself expelled from high school in 1960, weeks before his graduation. He adopted an itinerant life of well-paid gigs logging and baling hay in Montana, then skiing and climbing in Colorado, South America, and Europe. (His parents refused to support him.) Within a few years, he was trying his hand at business, dabbling in mountain-guiding and selling camping equipment. Chouinard, who was forging climbing hardware in his own shop, offered inspiration and advice.

In the mid-'60s, Tompkins moved to the San Francisco Bay Area and founded The North Face, a company that produced and sold outdoor gear and apparel. The hallmark of his genius, visible even in his early 20s, was fanatical attention to detail, evident in his remarkable skill at marketing and presentation. The brand stood out for the ambience of its retail stores, which became places for hip outdoor types to hang out, and for its beautifully printed catalogs dotted with feel-good aphorisms ("Pack less and enjoy more"). Stunts and gags drew attention to the hot new company just as the counterculture took off. A North Face employee rappelled down a San Francisco skyscraper for a cup of coffee. The Grateful Dead headlined a party launching the 1966 winter season.

Yet in 1967, just a few years after starting the company, Tompkins grew tired of being an equipment expert and cashed out, soon leaving on his Patagonia expedition. After that trip, he continued to disappear for

*Paternalism
informed
Tompkins's
dealings with
the people of
Patagonia:
I'm going to
take this land
and show you
how it ought
to be used.*

Opposite page:
*Douglas Tompkins
reached the summit of
Mount Fitz Roy on
December 20, 1968.*

months at a time on almost comically dangerous adventures, ignoring his children. But the entrepreneur was busy as ever on his return. The most fruitful of Tompkins's subsequent business enterprises was the clothing company that became Esprit, founded with Susie and another partner in 1968; he went on to serve as "image director," a title he preferred to CEO. The company's bold colors and patterns made it the label for cool teens and young 20-somethings of the 1970s and '80s.

Tompkins overflowed with ideas; obsessed over details as small as tags, buttons, and hangers; and created a progressive corporate campus with trampolines, green policies, and organic food. His thoughts on design influenced Jobs, who directed his own team to buy copies of Tompkins's book *Esprit: The Comprehensive Design Principle*. But if Tompkins's energy and vision drove the enterprise, Susie's sharp decision making boosted sales. She pushed Esprit's striking use of color and promoted marketing all their apparel properties under one brand name (an idea Tompkins initially opposed).

Their marriage and business partnership lasted 25 years but ended in acrimony. The interpersonal tension infected the company, which by the late '80s was struggling financially. Tompkins had also begun to grow disillusioned with the fashion industry and the effects of consumerism on the planet. "I found myself caught up in the marketing. I lost track of the larger picture. I was creating desires that weren't there. I was making products that nobody needed." Tompkins recognized his own talents but felt he had put them in service of waste. He spent more and more of his time on environmental concerns, particularly deforestation, and found his eye wandering back to South America. He immersed himself in books about deep ecology, which called for a broader understanding of ecosystems and a less human-centric view of nature. Inspired by the youthful energy of activists in radical organizations such as Earth First and Greenpeace, he dedicated his life to conservation.

Here Tompkins's path diverged from his friend Chouinard's. You might call them the extremist and the pragmatist of green activism. Patagonia integrated sustainability into the ethos of the company by making clothing out of recycled and low-impact materials, discouraging customers from buying new products when old ones could be repaired, and donating 1 percent of sales to environmental causes. Its example led other firms to reduce their own carbon footprint while still prospering. Yet Tompkins seemed to see things in binary terms: He was either a businessman or an environmentalist. He left Esprit, selling his 50 percent stake for approximately \$150 million and turning to philanthropy. He never looked back. His efforts, as they unfolded, revealed both the opportunities and the limitations of private conservation. When saving the planet relies not on law or policy but on the whims

of idiosyncratic multimillionaires, we all have to live with their flaws.

Tompkins's high-handedness at Esprit carried over into his reincarnation as a conservationist. Chouinard's company has made fair working practices a hallmark of its identity, but Tompkins had fought bitterly with labor. When workers at Esprit's San Francisco factory tried to unionize, he harassed and threatened them. After they went on strike, Tompkins locked them out and had strikers arrested. Promises made to end the strike turned out to be false.

In South America, Tompkins was as assertive as ever. He picked fights in a bold display of wealth and power. His ventures included 54 lawsuits against his neighbors and local governments in Argentina, fierce turf battles with the fishing industry, and controversial campaigns to protect endangered species. He used his marketing skills to help prevent a series of dams from being built, spearheading a national ad blitz that mocked the dams' corporate backers. The project was abandoned in 2014. These moves made him influential enemies in the energy industry and the Argentinian and Chilean governments. But the heart of Tompkins's decades-long Patagonia project, jointly led with his second wife, Kris Tompkins, was to buy as much land as possible, protect it from development, and donate it to South American governments to be used as national parks.

Although Franklin portrays Tompkins as humbler after remarrying, he made little effort to acquaint himself with the expectations and traditions of the area he had staked out to preserve. Locals could not believe that a gringo furiously buying up acreage would simply give it all away. Their skepticism was understandable in a region that had experienced colonialist abuses, property disputes, and military dictatorships. Ignorant of this history, Tompkins pressed ahead with plans for low-tech "pioneer villages" abutting and supporting his parks, their economy based on manual labor and sustainable agriculture. In one proposal, he suggested teaching beekeeping to local residents. The notion that Patagonia's residents might aspire to a more modern existence—or that they simply preferred to choose their fates for themselves—did not slow him down.

A Wild Idea outlines the controversies surrounding Tompkins's crusade. Still, Franklin could have offered a more nuanced (and better sourced) consideration of the white man's burden that Tompkins carried in South America. Doug and Kris Tompkins ultimately did give their land away; they were not amassing it for some nefarious purpose as many had feared. But that end result shouldn't eclipse the means employed or the response they elicited. In the September 2014 issue of *The Atlantic*, Diana Saverin reported in depth on the mistrust, anger, and resentment that local residents felt toward the strident American who swooped

in and out on a plane and bought up the land. Some of it belonged to absentee landowners and had been leased to or claimed by campesinos and indigenous communities, who were abruptly evicted. One café owner pointed out that the large stone visitors' centers the Tompkinses had built in the parks looked like they belonged in London rather than Patagonia. Critics said that turning grazing land into parkland eliminated the animal-husbandry jobs that the locals preferred, and that the pumas and other predators he'd reintroduced killed their livestock. Kris Tompkins batted away these critiques, arguing that the soil was overfarmed and that in 100 years, no one would be able to imagine the land as anything other than national parks.

The point is not that the locals were right and Tompkins was wrong. History may well thank him for preserving as much wilderness as he could before it was too late. Yet history isn't complete without taking account of the way that his single-mindedness and confidence in his own righteousness blinded him to the needs of others, whether Patagonians, business subordinates, climbing buddies, or family members. His merciless altruism comes through with particular poignancy in a story his elder daughter recounted about Christmas when she was 4 years old. Thrilled to be greeted by a big pile of presents bought by her father, she and her sister opened them up—only to be told by him that they would each keep one and donate the rest to an orphanage. Generosity and anti-consumerism are noble values, but the encounter left the searing message that Tompkins cared more about his own dogma than his children's joy. The same harsh paternalism informed his dealings with the people of Patagonia: *I'm going to take this land of yours and show you how it ought to be used.* Imagine how much more effective he might have been had he arrived with an open hand rather than a pointed finger. He might even have set a template for durable conservation, replicable elsewhere.

Chouinard wrote a well-received memoir about "the education of a reluctant businessman" in 2005 and gave it a fitting title: *Let My People Go Surfing*. The book captured the community-minded spirit of its author and his largely successful attempt to balance leadership, freedom, and conscientious stewardship. Tompkins, who died while kayaking in Patagonia with Chouinard and others nearly 50 years after the 1968 journey that changed both their lives, did not have a chance to publish a memoir of his own. It's a shame, because he was a unique figure of wide-ranging cultural influence, and a bit more self-reflection might have done him—and us all—good. *A*

Michael O'Donnell is an attorney in the Chicago area. His writing also appears in The New York Times, The Wall Street Journal, and The Economist.

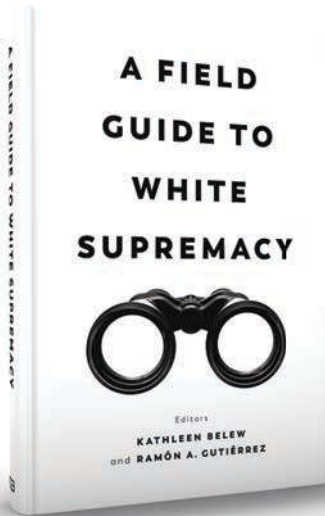
A WILD IDEA

Jonathan
Franklin

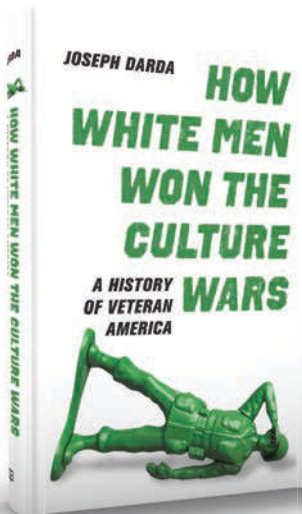
HARPERONE

AMERICA IN CONFLICT

MILITARISM AS A WAY OF LIFE AT HOME AND ABROAD

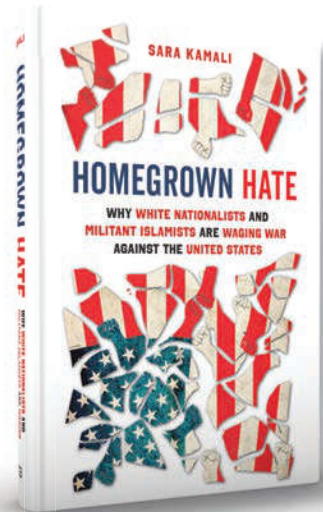


Drawing explicit lines, across time and a broad spectrum of violent acts, to provide the definitive field guide for understanding and opposing white supremacy in America.



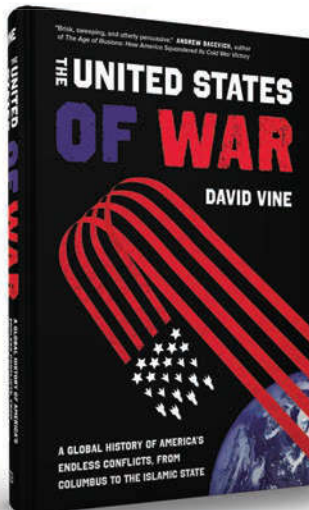
"A book of incandescent insight—a clear and persuasive account of how the misuse of wartime service has been coopted into a mythos of whiteness."

—Kathleen Belew, author of *Bring the War Home: The White Power Movement and Paramilitary America*



"Rebuts the idea that 'lone wolves' drive terrorism and focuses on a comparative analysis of the White nationalist and militant Islamist groups that can drive it."

—Kirkus Reviews



NEW IN PAPERBACK

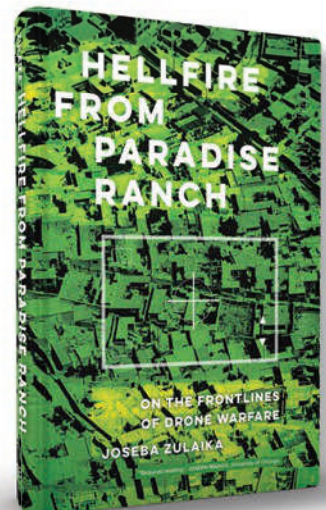
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—Los Angeles Review of Books



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Sally Rooney Addresses Her Critics

The Irish writer has been accused of being overly sentimental and insufficiently political. In her new novel, she makes the case for her approach to fiction.

By Caleb Crain

In her first two novels, *Conversations With Friends* (2017) and *Normal People* (2018), the young Irish writer Sally Rooney resurrected the depressive, evacuated style that Ernest Hemingway made his signature. “The hills across the valley of the Ebro were long and white,” he famously wrote in his short story “Hills Like White Elephants,” and in much the same deadpan way, Rooney has Frances, the narrator of her debut, look around a college library and think, “Inside, everything was very brown.” Ridiculous in isolation, Rooney’s line makes sense in context: Frances has just received an email from her lover’s wife, and while she waits for the courage to read it, she tries, unsuccessfully, to distract herself by focusing on her surroundings. At least, that’s what I imagine is going on in Frances’s head. With a writer so chary of detail, the reader rushes to fill in.

Rooney also resembled Hemingway—and Raymond Carver, a renovator of Hemingway’s minimalism whom Rooney has cited as an influence—in her ability to write dialogue that sounds unpremeditated but has a neutron-star density of drama and emotion. Here are Connell and Marianne, the teenage lovers of *Normal People*, after their first kiss:

All right, he said. What are you laughing for?
Nothing.
You’re acting like you’ve never kissed anyone before.
Well, I haven’t, she said.

Rooney showed mastery of point of view as well. Her control was so fine that she was able to convey Connell’s arousal during a reunion with Marianne by slowing down his perception and amping up its sensuousness: “She’s wearing a white dress with a halter-neck and her skin looks tanned. She’s been hanging washing on the line. The air outside is very still and the laundry hangs there in damp colors, not moving.” Rooney’s respect for the limits and biases of her characters’ minds was strict. Frances, young and unsophisticated, has never tasted a fresh avocado before, fantasizes about seeing her name printed in a magazine “in a serif font with thick stems,” and describes the torso of her first male lover with an almost generic simile: “like a piece of statuary.”

The rigor with which Rooney conformed narrative voice to the shape of her characters’ consciousness won her praise as a portraitist of her Millennial generation—and also left her vulnerable to political critique. Many of her characters are college-age leftists of an idealistic sort and, like tyro intellectuals since the dawn of time, are deadly earnest without altogether knowing what they’re talking about. They are besotted with theory but literally haven’t done the homework. At a performance of *Cat on a Hot Tin Roof*, Frances catches sight of the washing-instruction label on the lead actor’s slip, and the spell of the performance is broken: “I concluded that some kinds of reality have an unrealistic effect, which made me think of the theorist Jean Baudrillard, though I had never read his books and these were probably not the issues his writing addressed.” A whole essay could be written about this sentence’s simultaneous knowingness and not-knowingness, but as a snapshot of a young person who knows which names to invoke but not (lucky for her) their actual work, it can’t be bettered. And in fact, Frances’s insight is a good one—whoever thought it up first.

Rooney told interviewers that she, like some of her characters, was a Marxist, and American critics—many of them her Millennial contemporaries—drafted her into the war over tone of voice, ideological purity, and evidentiary standards that has been raging in progressive political circles since at least the run-up to the 2016 presidential election. In *The New York Review of Books*, Madeleine Schwartz complained that “the politics are mostly gestural” in Rooney’s books, pointing out that her protagonists, far from being rebels, “are all good students.” Becca Rothfeld, writing in *The Point*, also saw the leftism as fashionable posturing and seemed sorry that Rooney hadn’t more explicitly punctured it. In a follow-up essay in *Liber-ties*, Rothfeld went so far as to dismiss Rooney’s fiction as “sanctimony literature”: “full of self-promotion and the airing of performatively righteous opinions.”

I agree that the leftism of Rooney's characters is shallow, and that their worldview is to a great extent undermined by the novels' plots. "The whole idea of 'meritocracy' or whatever, it's evil, you know I think that," Marianne tells Connell, a working-class boy from a single-parent home who, thanks to hard work and native talent, gets into an elite university, where he becomes "rich-adjacent"—the epitome of a meritocrat, in other words (though never, as befits a romantic lead, an entitled one). Frances, meanwhile, is described as a Communist by her sometime girlfriend, Bobbi, but once Frances's writerly ambition awakens, she expropriates Bobbi's life story as literary grist, which Bobbi only discovers from a third party, just as the revealing story is about to appear in print. I don't find that the inconsistency compromises the novels, maybe because I'm what the internet calls an old, who thinks of politics and literature as different endeavors. Plenty of young people do think and talk like Rooney's characters, and I like reading novels that look at their world from a sympathetic but significant distance.

At least as salient as the nod to radical politics in Rooney's first two novels was a troubled longing for traditional relationships, which struck many of the same critics as unexamined, if not ill-advised. The union of a strong man and a submissive woman seemed to fascinate Rooney, the way faith in God once fascinated Matthew Arnold: She could no longer bring herself to believe, but she also couldn't stop mourning the shape and meaning that such a union once gave to life. In the lives of her heroines, the mourning sometimes took the form of masochism. Frances tears open the skin in the crook of an elbow after she learns she hasn't been made pregnant by her married lover, whom she later asks to hit her. Marianne lets a boyfriend beat her up and lets another lover tie her wrists and tell her she's worthless, and she, too, ends up asking the love of her life to hit her.

I find I don't need Rooney to condemn or fully explain here either; a novelist's role is to notice and explore. It would be unnatural if characters as young as Rooney's had already worked out what to do with such impulses. Frances tries to soften her urge to punish herself—tries to tame and socialize it—by submitting herself to a partly homemade Christianity, a wider communion that she seems to hope will dilute the guilt she has incurred in romantic couples and triangles. She starts reading the Gospels and, while sitting in church, has a vision of the world, including herself, as created by the work of many different human beings. "Now I see that nothing consists of two people, or even three," she writes to Bobbi. Toward the end of *Normal People*, Marianne tries to transcend her masochism by making her

choice to surrender to Connell, who has refused to hurt her in bed, a conscious one, and her rationale echoes Frances's communal vision: "No one can be independent of other people completely, so why not give up the attempt, she thought, go running in the other direction, depend on people for everything, allow them to depend on you, why not." Unfortunately, an impulse to abase oneself isn't resolved by a recognition that human life is a collaboration. Rooney's characters never quite work through the conflicts they've been acting out.

ROONEY SEEMS to have been aware that she left the puzzle uncompleted: Submissive impulses, homemade Christianity, and an ethos of mutual care return in her new novel, *Beautiful World, Where Are You*. The book takes its title from a poem of Friedrich Schiller's praising a mythic past when contact with the divine was part of daily life. Like *Conversations With Friends*, the new book tells the story of two Irish couples. The first consists of Alice Kelleher, a young Dublin novelist who has moved to the west of Ireland after a nervous breakdown in New York, and Felix Brady, a taciturn, hard-drinking warehouse picker she meets through an app. Rooney loans Alice the shape of her own career: Only 29, Alice has become rich and famous for writing two novels that won a lot of attention from the press—"mostly positive at first," Rooney writes, "and then some negative pieces reacting to the fawning positivity."

The loan gives Rooney an opportunity to reply to her critics, with whom, it turns out, she agrees that while a novelist may be Marxist, novels rarely are. "The novel works by suppressing the truth of the world," Alice writes in one of the meditative emails that she and her best friend, whom she's known since college, exchange over the course of the book; fiction soothes readers into feeling at liberty to care about such trivial matters as "whether people break up or stay together." The problem is more general than novels, the friend responds, noting that most people, on their deathbeds, keenly aware that time is precious, talk about close personal relationships rather than human justice in the abstract.

The novel's second couple consists of Eileen Lydon, Alice's email correspondent, and Eileen's childhood friend Simon Costigan. Eileen works at a literary magazine and thinks of herself as socially awkward. Simon—five years older and strikingly beautiful—works as a political consultant for high-minded left-wing politicians, is a communicant in the Roman Catholic Church, and has considered joining the priesthood. His father accuses him of having a messiah complex, and no one in the novel much dissents from the diagnosis. The morning

BEAUTIFUL
WORLD, WHERE
ARE YOU

Sally Rooney

FARRAR, STRAUS
AND GIROUX

after Simon and Eileen renew a romance that started almost a decade earlier, Eileen accompanies him to Mass, where they hold hands, and ideas about religion and morality soon become integrated into the gentle dominance-and-submission games they play in bed. “I think I enjoy being bossed around by you,” she tells him, and he tells her, when she obeys, with a couple of his fingers inside her, that she’s being “good.” Sexual worldliness, a whiff of incense—it’s all very Muriel Spark, except in pastel.

Alice and Felix, meanwhile, seem charged with menace on their first date—she appears capable of mockery and condescension, and he of scorn or even violence. Indeed, he goes on to ghost her, stand her up, ask her for sex while drunk and high, and tell her no one cares about her. Rooney stage-manages the scenes so that Alice retains much of her dignity—at the cost, I think, of Felix’s coherence as a character. The same man, the reader is told, asks which terms for sex acts she prefers in bed. Rooney claims Felix is bisexual, a claim that goes largely unsubstantiated, and makes his outlines even blurrier. I came to think of his bisexuality as a bay leaf that was said to have been added to the soup but hadn’t been.

Chasing her ideas about love, Rooney hasn’t sufficiently incarnated them. Unlike the wayward human beings of her earlier novels, the foursome in *Beautiful World* seems carefully planned and a little static, like figures in an allegory. Rooney’s efforts to introduce romantic suspense feel added on. I couldn’t manage to believe that Alice and Felix would ever make a couple except briefly and painfully, and I couldn’t see why Eileen and Simon weren’t settled lovers from Chapter 3 onward.

I SUSPECT that many readers will miss the ruthless speed and economy that Rooney displayed in her first two books, but she remains a great talent. Among the considerable pleasures here are her bold variations in perspective. Interspersing the long emails between Alice and Eileen is narration from a third-person omniscient point of view, the first time Rooney has tried this in a novel, and I felt the excitement of watching a serious artist try out a new tool. One of her chapters, for example, begins with a description of Simon’s living room before anyone has entered it and ends with a description of the same room after he and Eileen have gone into his bedroom and closed the door. Elsewhere, Rooney describes Felix’s warehouse-picking in tandem with Alice’s performance of publicity duties, even though the two actions are taking place at a distance from each other. I loved this playfulness.

And then there are the ideas themselves. As the riff about realism and clothing labels in Rooney’s first novel demonstrated, a powerful intellect beats

beneath her underdressed prose. Like every thinking person, she has felt driven to come up with new theories about the world during the crises of the past few years, and in the emails between Alice and Eileen, she ruminates on capitalism, the fall of communism, beauty, plastic, minority identities (Eileen seems to be a class-first socialist), the role of art in the Trump era, and the abrupt degradation and collapse of several Mediterranean civilizations during the Late Bronze Age.

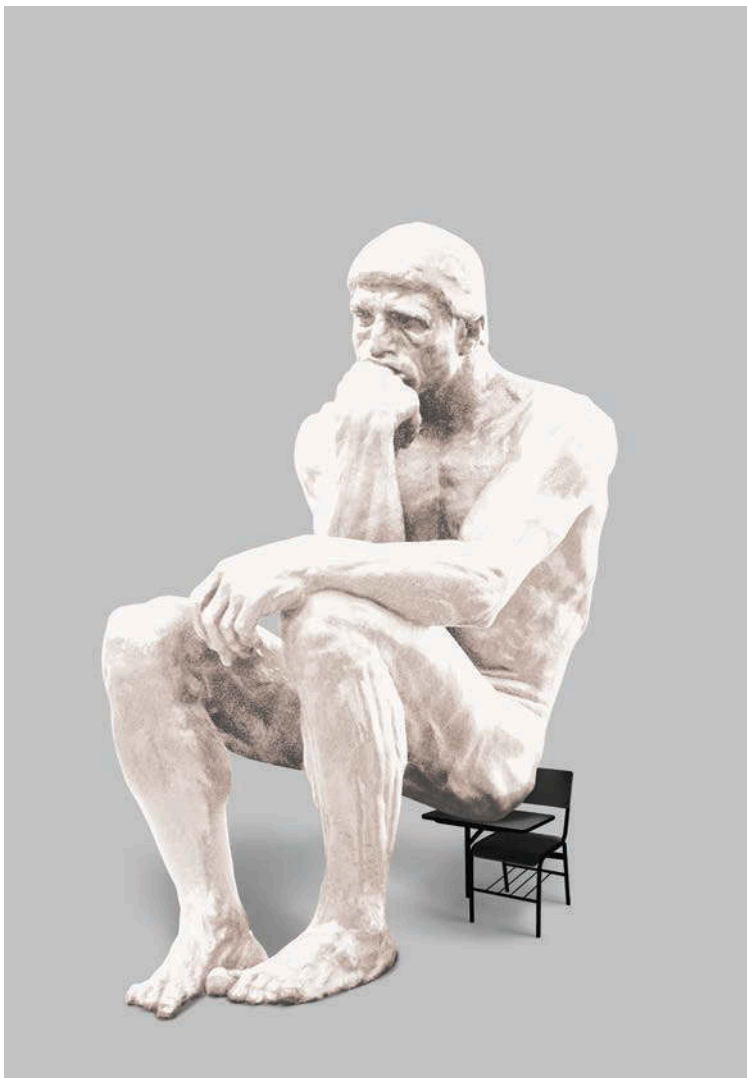
The emails come to seem less like chapters in a novel than like installments of a discursive essay. The central question that Eileen and Alice keep returning to is how to make a community out of loving interdependence. Selflessness, in the name of some higher unity, seems necessary. Eileen admires the way congregants at Mass earnestly lift their hearts to the Lord. Alice quotes a sentence of Proust’s suggesting the existence of a single intelligence in the world, which everyone looks at from their own body, the way members of an audience look at a single stage from many different seats.

But structure seems necessary too. The substance that makes up relationships is “soft like sand or water,” Alice writes, and without a vessel to contain it, people can only “pour the water out and let it fall,” leading not to utopia but to waste. Although Alice, like Rooney characters before her, is disenchanted with traditional marriage, “it was at least a way of doing things,” she writes, sounding less Marxist than Burkean. Rooney hints that friendship might be the shapeless vessel needed for a shapeless substance. When Alice and Eileen reunite in person after a separation, Rooney wonders if they glimpse “something concealed beneath the surface of life, not unreality but a hidden reality: the presence at all times, in all places, of a beautiful world.”

There’s something a little 18th-century about *Beautiful World*, with its philosophical tone and its abstractly conceived characters who can’t stop talking about how to reconcile romantic liberty with love’s responsibilities. It reminds me of Goethe’s *Elective Affinities*, and like that book, it has held my attention more strongly than is easy to explain. In her new novel, Rooney hasn’t quite found the right vessel for her vision, any more than her characters have found the ideal sociopolitical structure for channeling human connectedness. Rooney could have taken the safer route of repeating herself, but she seems to have an Enlightenment idea of the artist’s calling: She experiments. *A*

Caleb Crain is the author of Necessary Errors and Overthrow.

Rooney loans Alice, a young Dublin novelist, the shape of her own career.



BOOKS

White Progressives in Pursuit of Racial Virtue

What two new books reveal about the moral limits of anti-racist self-help

By Danzy Senna

Last March, just before we knew the pandemic had arrived, my husband and I enrolled our son in a progressive private school in Pasadena, California. He was 14 and, except for a year abroad, had been attending public schools his whole life. Private was my idea, the gentle kind of hippie school I'd sometimes wished I could attend during my ragtag childhood in Boston-area public schools amid the desegregation turmoil of the 1970s and '80s. I wanted smaller class sizes, a more nurturing environment for my artsy, bookish child. I did notice that—despite having diversity in its mission statement—the school was extremely white. My son noticed too. As he gushed about the school after his visit, he mentioned that he hadn't seen a single other kid of African descent. He brushed it off. It didn't matter.

I did worry that we might be making a mistake. But I figured we could make up for the lack; after all, not a day went by in our household that we didn't discuss race, joke about race, fume about race. My child knew he was Black and he knew his history and ... he'd be fine.

Weeks after we sent in our tuition deposit, the pandemic hit, followed by the summer of George Floyd. The school where my son was headed was no exception to the grand awakening of white America that followed, the confrontation with the absurd lie of post-racial America. The head of school scrambled to address an anonymous forum on Instagram recounting "experiences with the racism dominating our school," as what one administrator called its racial reckoning began. Over the summer, my son was assigned Ibram X. Kendi and Jason Reynolds's *Stamped: Racism, Antiracism, and You* and Angie Thomas's *The Hate U Give*. When the fall semester began, no ordinary clubs like chess and debate awaited; my son's sole opportunity to get to know other students was in affinity groups. That meant Zooming with the catchall category of BIPOC students on Fridays to talk about their racial trauma in the majority-white school he hadn't yet set foot inside. (*BIPOC*, or "Black, Indigenous, and people of color," was unfamiliar to my son; in his public school, he had described his peers by specific ethnic backgrounds—Korean, Iranian, Jewish, Mexican, Black.)

He made us laugh with stories about the school at the dinner table. His irony and awareness were intact. But his isolation in the new school, under quarantine, was acute; he missed his friends, who were all going to the local public high school, albeit on Zoom. How could he meet kids who shared his interests in graphic novels, film, debate, comedy, politics? I expressed my concern and was told that our son would surely soon make some friends through that weekly BIPOC affinity group. This year of racial reckoning, one school official said, was about healing. At every meeting I attended, I kept bringing up the

importance of recruiting more Black families. Administrators, almost all of them white, kept emphasizing the need for more outside DEI (diversity, equity, and inclusion) specialists to heal the school's racial trauma.

I THOUGHT of our experience at the school recently as I read Courtney E. Martin's memoir about trying to live a "White moral life." In *Learning in Public: Lessons for a Racially Divided America From My Daughter's School*, she shares her experience of deciding to send her kindergarten to the majority-Black and academically "failing" neighborhood public school she's zoned for in Oakland, California. Martin is a writer on social-justice issues who is in demand on the college-lecture circuit. In spirit, her book is an extension of her popular Substack newsletter, called The Examined Family, written "for people who get all twisted up inside about the brokenness of the world, and wonder how to actually live in it, loving and humble, but brave as hell." In other words, her memoir is aimed at fellow upper-middle-class white progressives eager to confront their "white fragility," the phrase coined a decade ago by the white educator Robin DiAngelo, whose 2018 book by that title (subtitled *Why It's So Hard for White People to Talk About Racism*) is the bible of many of those DEI specialists I kept hearing about.

DiAngelo diagnosed what has never not been obvious to Black people (to be Black in America is to hold a Ph.D. in whiteness, whether you want to or not): that white people, when their "expectations for racial comfort" get violated, go into a defensive crouch, and vent some blend of guilt, anger, and denial. White privilege turns out to be a kind of addiction, and when you take it away from people, even a little bit, they respond just like any other addict coming off a drug. The upper-middle-class thin-skinned liberals among them are also very willing to pay for treatment, of which DiAngelo offers a booster dose in a new book, *Nice Racism: How Progressive White People Perpetuate Racial Harm*, aware that the moment is ripe.

The word *brave* gets used a lot in Martin's book, and the idea of bravery gets performed a lot in DiAngelo's book, as she time and again steps in as savior to her Black friends, who apparently need a bold white person to take over the wearisome task of educating unselfaware, well-meaning white people. In a curated space and for an ample fee, she heroically takes on a job that Black people have been doing for free in workplaces and at schools and in relationships over the centuries. As she acknowledges, she also "could not articulate the dynamics of white fragility without ... reading the work of Black writers who came before my time." Indeed, everything she notices about whiteness has been noticed by Black writers before her. DiAngelo's whiteness is her not-so-secret sauce, giving her crucial entrée to audiences who, as she puts

*Black people
in these books
are oppressed.
White people
are clueless
and privileged.
And never
the twain
shall meet.*

it, "are more likely to be open to initial challenges to [their] racial positions ... from a fellow white person."

How we have wished that white people would leave us out of their self-preoccupied, ham-fisted, kindergarten-level discussions of race. But be careful what you wish for. To anyone who has been conscious of race for a lifetime, these books can't help feeling less brave than curiously backward.

MARTIN, ENSCONCED in a hotbed of just the sort of racial self-delusion that DiAngelo feels is crying out to be challenged, wants very badly to be good. "We, White progressives, *love* Black Oakland," she writes, self-mockingly. "We just don't actually know anyone who is Black who is from Oakland." Setting out to change that, she is more than ready to break the "ubiquitous, maddening, and problematic pattern" of "white silence"—one of 18 "moves of white progressives" to maintain the status quo that DiAngelo enumerates. Right in step with *Nice Racism's* edicts, she is also eager to "take risks and make mistakes in the service of learning and growth" by speaking up—not just in a workshop, but between the covers of a book.

The project Martin proudly chronicles is learning by actually doing. Rather than finagling to snag a spot in either of the two highly rated, whiter public schools nearby, as her quasi-enlightened Oakland friends do—or considering the progressive private school in the area—she agonizes about her choices, then bucks the trend. Her account is cringey in its many blind spots. She's also hyperaware that it has blind spots. Does that mean we are not allowed to cringe?

Martin is most at ease in moments when she is describing her own white tribe and the "inequity and hypocrisy" rife in a hip enclave like hers. She's acerbically self-deprecating, sharp in her observations. "I love this little experiment with White parents. If you say your kid isn't gifted, it's like you've shit on the avocado toast in the middle of the table." When she meets another white mother, she captures the texture of social advantage with a vividness you won't find in DiAngelo's books: "Shared culture is the water—cool, soothing, and invisible. It's our food (those salty dried-seaweed packets, those squishy bags of organic goop), our persistent, performative friendliness ... our thirty million words." These moments of "white double-consciousness"—of awareness of how deep her ties are to the insular world she aims to escape—suggest a more interesting and less mawkish book than we get.

But in her interactions with Black people, Martin gets tripped up by the paradox of anti-racist self-help: the challenge, as DiAngelo puts it, of "decentering ourselves as white people," while also being constantly and humbly focused on white ignorance, complicity, built-in advantages, unshared experiences. Avoiding signs

of unearned racial confidence (“credentialing,” “out-working,” and “rushing to prove that we are not racist” are on DiAngelo’s list of white-progressive moves), all the while striving to be a model anti-racist, creates a double bind for the white ally. Martin strains to be transparent about her own “mistakes and shortcomings.” She even includes as footnotes the comments of her sensitivity reader and Black friend, an educator named Dena Simmons, as a way of “showing my work.” When Martin describes a Black man she meets as a “gentle creature,” for example, Simmons suggests, “Maybe let’s not call him a creature, especially from a White narrator.”

Martin admits all her wrongdoings before we can get to her (those footnotes, of which there are surprisingly few, seem to be reserved for glaring missteps). And yet, despite the mea culpas and disclaimers and self-deprecating acknowledgments of all the ways she fails, she goes ahead and writes a book about race barely more than a year into her real-world odyssey of wokeness. And she continually reverts to a binary and reductive racialized shorthand—a sign that she is having a harder time shaking off her white blinders than she realizes.

When Martin finally arrives at the promised land of Black public school and surrounds herself and her child with actual Black people, they come across as flat, kindly stock figures—props who serve to illustrate whatever anti-racist point she’s trying to make. Whereas the white characters in her book come to life as types I recognize, the Black characters are afflicted with the problem that James Baldwin points out in his seminal 1949 essay “Everybody’s Protest Novel,” commenting on *Uncle Tom’s Cabin*. “Uncle Tom ... [Harriet Beecher Stowe’s] only Black man,” he writes, “has been robbed of his humanity and divested of his sex. It is the price for that darkness with which he has been branded.” At first sight, Martin sums up her daughter’s kindergarten teacher, Mrs. Minor, with snap judgments that are the flip side of white suspicion, the kind of romanticized projection onto Black people that can be equally erasing: “She seems totally in command of her craft, like someone with a passion for teaching, someone who grew up pretending to be a teacher to all her stuffed animals all day long.”

Martin is aware of her own white-gaze problem, as when she duly reports that she had “reveled in the unearned familiarity” of her initial “reading” of Mrs. Minor, and she presses to learn more. Martin’s daughter has thrived in her class; she’s learned about Harriet Tubman, and Black friends come for a playdate. But Mrs. Minor is restless. When she leaves her teaching job to start a preschool for Black children in her own home, Martin won’t let her go. She begins showing up for visits, sitting in Mrs. Minor’s kitchen during the preschool’s nap time, peppering her with questions in an effort to enrich her own white moral life.

LEARNING
IN PUBLIC:
LESSONS FOR
A RACIALLY
DIVIDED
AMERICA FROM
MY DAUGHTER’S
SCHOOL

Courtney
E. Martin

LITTLE, BROWN

NICE RACISM:
HOW PROGRES-
SIVE WHITE
PEOPLE
PERPETUATE
RACIAL HARM

Robin DiAngelo

BEACON PRESS

That the arrangement is forced and one-sided, beneficial to her, the white parent-writer, isn’t lost on Martin, yet she doesn’t stop. “It’s naptime again,” she writes from Mrs. Minor’s kitchen table on yet another visit. “Mrs. Minor is trying her best to answer my question. Which was: ‘What would you do if you were in my shoes?’” Martin wants Mrs. Minor to tell her what to think of a white person’s desire to believe that her own and her daughter’s presence in the mostly Black school will magically improve the place. After Mrs. Minor gives her a halting, irritated answer about gentrification and power, Martin decides it is she who has been of use to Mrs. Minor—that by asking these questions, she’s helped Mrs. Minor think through the problem. “I realize that Mrs. Minor is sort of interviewing herself. And I’m here for it. Better her than me.” In the footnotes, the barely-there sensitivity reader is pricked enough by these last two sentences to cross them out and write, “I do not think you need to say this. It feels very colonial or taking-advantage-of.”

Martin’s impulse to idealize Black people as fonts of needed wisdom has a counterpoint: She can’t seem to help pathologizing Black people as victims awaiting rescue. Her account implicitly conflates class and race; *Blackness* is a blanket term that somehow comes to equal poverty, as though wealthy and highly educated Black people don’t exist. Martin recognizes the problem—that the fearful white imagination has trouble seeing Black people as individuals—but she continually reinforces these ideas in her narrative. “Black kids—poor Black kids especially—still seem, and this feels very hard to force my fingers to write, less human. Less textured. Less known. Less real. They are subjects of a new report.” By admitting to her own latent racism, she evidently feels she comes that much closer to a life of recovery.

Martin just can’t shake her patronizing belief that Black people need her to save them. Her effort to build on a friendship between her daughter and the son of a single Black father at the school unfolds like a salvation fantasy. She starts by pushing, awkwardly, for a playdate and, when the pandemic closes the school, loans the pair a laptop and tries to line up tutoring. Having learned that the father is picking up free lunches from the school, she fights the urge to drop a bag of groceries on his doorstep, afraid that will seem like insultingly blatant charity. Instead, she pretends she’s made too much pasta for her family, and offers to leave a container at his door, hoping it will seem neighborly, neutral—but hears nothing back. She gets that the dad may be rejecting her role as helper-with-the-resources. Or rather, Martin gets that she doesn’t really get it: “His silence speaks. I don’t know what it says.”

BLACK PEOPLE in these books are oppressed. White people are clueless and privileged. And never

the twain shall meet, unless it's under the auspices of arranged workshops or, if the cross-racial experiences happen in real life, in interactions so consciously and unconsciously freighted that, as DiAngelo puts it, "we end up engaging disingenuously." Or, as Martin shows, falling into age-old antebellum-tinted dynamics as she yearns to confirm her place in a morally clean white universe. Baldwin writes that *Uncle Tom's Cabin* is "activated by what might be called a theological terror, the terror of damnation"—which in DiAngelo's case is not literal hell but an endless purgatory, no absolution in view, and no real political action, either. She is not interested in police brutality, hate crimes, the criminal-justice system, drug laws, or even what Martin touches on, the failure of public schools to educate all children.

Interracial worlds, friendships, marriages—Black and white lives inextricably linked, for good and for bad, with racism and with hope—are all but erased by Martin and DiAngelo, and with them the mixed children of these marriages, who are the fastest-growing demographic in the country. I found nothing of my own multiracial family history in these books; my husband's Black middle-class family is nowhere to be found either, inconvenient for being too successful, too educated, too adept over generations to need Martin's handouts or DiAngelo's guidance on dealing with white people. The world these writers evoke is one in which white people remain the center of the story and Black people are at the margins, poor, stiff, and dignified, with little better to do than open their homes and hearts to white women on journeys to racial self-awareness.

As our semester at the progressive private school trudged on, my son refused to go to any more affinity-group meetings. They depressed him in ways he couldn't articulate. I worried that all the racial healing was breaking him, and started to feel nostalgic for the big, chaotic public school where he had friends. I went to one parent diversity meeting after another. I wrote an administrator, and she wrote back, telling me about a "Witnessing Whiteness" class she was taking, and asking if she might "lean on" me for help in her ongoing education. We decided to leave. Our son wanted his friends back. It was as basic as that. But it was also more complicated. My husband and I didn't want him to be part of the school's great white awakening anymore. Teachers and staff were acting out their anxieties about past failings on kids who were living in an upside-down world and deserved better than bewildered platitudes. The school did not see my son, only what he represented on its journey. *A*

Danzy Senna is the author, most recently, of the novel New People.

Squander

By W. J. Herbert

I'm still a magpie. If it glitters,
I want it, no matter
the cost—

I don't connect the bangle
I buy online to a gold
mine's cyanide heap

leaching, or the made-
with-fracked-gas plastics
that I throw in the trash

to the survivor in an as-yet-
unnamed epoch
who'll sniff the fossil

bones of a predator
unknown to it, though
the skull that it licks

will likely be ours,
and even if this creature
resembles the rat-size

mammal that evolved when
dinosaurs died, by what blood
chemistry will it breathe?

W. J. Herbert's debut poetry collection, Dear Specimen, will be published this fall as a winner of the 2020 National Poetry Series Competition.

ESSAY

The Radical Feminism of a 17th-Century Priest

*François Poulain
attacked the patriarchy
and considered the
work of motherhood to
be as worthy of respect
as any other form of
labor. Is the world finally
ready for his ideas?*

By
Judith
Shulevitz

What if I told you that the first modern feminist was a man, lived in the 17th century, and was a priest? I'm guessing you'd be especially skeptical about the priest part, so I'll add that when this father of feminism wrote his vindications of women's rights, he wasn't a priest yet. He became one later, probably because he was broke. ¶ His name was François Poulain de la Barre (actually, he added "de la Barre" later in life,



and “Poulain” was sometimes spelled “Poullain”), and he grew up in Paris. His parents decided early on that he would become a priest, preferably with a doctoral degree so that he could rise through the ranks in the Church. He began his schooling at 9 and at 16 entered the Sorbonne, where he was force-fed a dry, Scholastic, all-Latin curriculum straight out of antiquity and the Middle Ages, with a special emphasis on the classics and Saint Thomas Aquinas. We know that Poulain excelled in his studies, and we also know that at 19, armed with his bachelor’s, he left school rather than acquire his doctorate, at which point his parents may have cut him off. For the first half of the next decade, he seems to have been an intellectual-about-town. He immersed himself in the free-for-all of the “Radical Enlightenment,” a more intensely anti-authoritarian strain of the early Enlightenment.

We don’t know much about the young Poulain’s daily activities, but we do know that, even before he left school, he was frequenting a freethinkers’ debate society that sometimes took on topics such as “whether women’s passions are stronger than men’s” and “whether the study of the arts and sciences is useful to women.” He may have gone to salons where the elites of the day gathered to expound upon new ideas and discuss novels, and perhaps even read their own work aloud. Aristocratic or well-to-do women hosted these affairs—some evidence suggests that he may have been a distant cousin of one eminent *salonnière*—and because Poulain probably hadn’t met many women in school, their presence would have offered its own kind of education. He was a man in search of a new worldview, and when he finally came up with one, it was audacious.

While still in his mid-20s, Poulain wrote three books in quick succession (1673–75). They constitute the first rigorously reasoned attack on the patriarchy. Before that, proto-feminist women (there were more of them than you’d think) tended to defend their sex by citing the accomplishments of queens and heroines of history and myth. Poulain instead used logic to demonstrate the absolute equality of women and men, and to make the case for their right to equal treatment under the law, equal access to

education, and equal professional opportunities. (He saw no reason women couldn’t occupy high clerical positions, putting him a good 350 years ahead of a still-resistant Catholic Church.) Poulain rejected a marital contract that granted men dominion over women; he declared that marriage should be between equals, like friendship, and that husbands forced wives into a submissive role for no better reason than that they were “out-and-out bullies.”

On the long list of revolutionary reassessments of conventional wisdom that make the Radical Enlightenment feel eerily contemporary, scholars have left out gender

Poulain’s main insight has lost none of its subversiveness: The subjugation of women is humanity’s first and most consequential injustice.

equality. Until now, Poulain is forcing them to put it in. He saw sexism as systemic, though he wouldn’t have used either term. And he took a position only now beginning to claim a place in the vanguard of feminism: He deemed the work of motherhood necessary, and as worthy of respect and—he implies, though doesn’t say so directly—of pay as any other form of labor. Indeed, withholding education and opportunity from anyone—female, peasant, Turk—squandered human resources: “How many

people remain in the mire when they might have distinguished themselves if they had been given encouragement?” Everyone who contributes to society is useful, and all useful contributions are equally valuable.

His titles were long, in the manner of the day—the subtitle of *On the Equality of the Two Sexes* is *A Physical and Moral Discourse Which Shows the Importance of Getting Rid of One’s Prejudices*—and sarcastic, in the case of his third work, *On the Excellence of Men: Against the Equality of Sexes*. But the books were short and to the point. They were “the most radically egalitarian texts published in Europe before the French Revolution,” in the words of Siep Stuurman, the author of *François Poulain de la Barre and the Invention of Modern Equality* (2004). “Poulain is the first thinker in modern Europe to build his entire social philosophy on a universalist concept of equality.” And his vision of equality began with women.

I STUMBLED upon Poulain at the Barnard library in 2016. I was reading up on feminists of the past because I felt stifled by the feminism of the present, particularly the kind just then embodied by Hillary Clinton, whose presidential campaign leaned hard on the notion that she would shatter the glass ceiling—never mind that most American women were just trying to get by. I wasn’t struggling to get by, but I wasn’t soaring either. Motherhood had slowed down my journalism career, because I had a bad case of what D. W. Winnicott called “maternal preoccupation,” which felt like—and was—love infused with professional insecurity. Enabled by savings and a supportive husband, I had taken refuge in the world of mothers’ groups, playdates, and sippy cups. As my children grew older, I ran a speakers’ series at their school and became an expert in New York City’s labyrinthine public-high-school admissions process. I let writing deadlines float into the ether. At social gatherings, I offered up vague descriptions of a book project that was under contract, but not progressing.

The only feminist writers who made me feel better about myself were those who, rather than being obsessed with professional ascent, set out to challenge

prevailing attitudes toward care. A good society, they said, should not dump the care formerly provided by family members on others or just not address the problem at all. A good society should make a point of prizing that family care—even paying for it, so that outsourcing needn't be a necessity, but can be a choice.

My hero became the sociologist Arlie Russell Hochschild, who for decades had been writing with gentle sorrow about the “depersonalization of our bonds with others,” about parents missing out on their children's childhoods, about grown children who can't afford the time or opportunity costs of tending to the helpless parents who once did the same for them.

Feminism had suffered an “abduction” by capitalism, Hochschild explained. Women got to work long and hard as they staggered under family responsibilities without paid leave or universal child care. From the library, I learned that a slew of largely forgotten feminists had feared this very outcome. Yes, women's entry into the workforce would grant much-needed independence, but it would not inevitably improve their lives. A group of Black mothers who were influential members of the National Welfare Rights Organization made this point forcefully. “There are some ten million jobs that now pay less than the minimum wage, and if you're a woman, you've got the best chance of getting one,” wrote Johnnie Tillmon, then the NWRO's leader, in 1972. But why, she asked, should a 45-year-old woman like her “work all day in a laundry ironing shirts at 90-some cents an hour?” Raising kids at home—with the help of the motherhood subsidy that was welfare—was less oppressive than some of the alternatives. Members of the International Wages for Housework Campaign, a Marxist feminist organization active in the '70s and still around today, argued that traditional housewifery amounted to theft of service, but they, too, worried that feminism was falling for “the myth of liberation through work,” by which they meant proletarian labor.

The rise of the service sector, the decline of unions, the loss of benefits, and the advent of variable scheduling have made blue- (or pink-) collar work as daunting for men and women in recent

decades as it was for Tillmon. Women still outnumber men in low-wage jobs (those that pay \$11 an hour or less). Close to 80 percent of U.S. workers still have no paid family leave. Hard-pressed working mothers who can afford it typically turn to low-wage-earning women caregivers for help. This reinforces gender stereotypes that assign nurturing to the powerless. On the top you have, as Hochschild puts it, “order-barking, fast-paced entrepreneurs,” and on the bottom, “emotionally attuned, human-paced mediators.”

And then came the pandemic shutdowns. There are currently nearly 2 million fewer women in the workforce than before the arrival of COVID-19. Many of those women left jobs to care for housebound children. Working women's annual earnings plummeted after a single year off from work; so, of course, do future earnings and chances of promotion. Freedoms and opportunities that had seemed entrenched vanished overnight. Meanwhile, the entire nation discovered its dependence on caregivers, now understood as everyone who keeps us fed and watered—meatpackers, warehouse pickers, checkout clerks, baristas, and more—in addition to those who nurture and nurse us. As the months passed, Poulain, with his insistence on putting care work on the same footing as all other kinds, seemed less like a historical curiosity and more like a man for our time. He had roughed out the blueprint of a world to come, in which the gendered hierarchy of labor would be turned on its head. The new reality of 2020 and 2021 allowed me to gauge just how original he was, and how relevant he remains.

POULAIN'S MAIN INSIGHT has lost none of its subversiveness. The subjugation of women, he writes, is humanity's first and most consequential injustice. When men usurped the rights and freedoms of the people dearest to them—their wives, mothers, sisters—they unleashed on the world “greed, ambition, vanity, extravagance, idleness, condescension, cruelty, tyranny, deceit, schisms, wars.”

Poulain illustrates his points with a “historical conjecture” in the form of a state-of-nature narrative. This is a counterfactual, designed to force readers to imagine a

society utterly unlike theirs. “At the beginning of the world,” he writes, “there was no government, no learning, no employment, no established religion.” He goes on: “Both men and women, who were naive and innocent, contributed equally to the tasks of tilling and hunting as savages do today. A man went about his business and a woman hers; the person who made the greatest contribution was the most respected.” Naturally, women got pregnant and had to stop tilling or hunting. But mothers suffered no penalties for “the indisposition of pregnancy and its aftermath,” because reproduction equaled production, and children were contributions indeed. “The help of their husbands became absolutely essential to them,” Poulain writes, but husbands didn't assume that they should be treated as lords in return. Wives' attention to the family's well-being was no less essential than husbands'. They leaned on each other: “Dependence was not considered irksome.”

Over time, however, families multiplied and began to compete for resources. In the scrabble of all against all, Poulain continues, physical prowess became more important than fertility. Husbands began to dominate their wives and reduce them to servants. Having bested women, men “imagined they were superior in all respects.” They swooped down upon neighboring tribes, confiscated land and possessions, and ruled tyrannically over the people they subjugated. The mutuality that had defined family life “disappeared at the moment of this invasion.”

In contrast to Thomas Hobbes's characterization of the state of nature as “nasty, brutish, and short,” Poulain's origin story is an alternative Garden of Eden, complete with Adam, Eve, and the fall. In his version, it was Adam, not Eve, who ended the idyll, with violence. Exile from the garden was the shift from family-based communitarianism to a political economy based on private property, which to Poulain was basically theft. As for the state, Poulain dismissed it as the codification of crime, an institution meant to safeguard stolen wealth and ensure that men would continue to profit: “All laws seem to have been made to keep men in their present position of power.”



PERHAPS POULAIN sounds like a character in a fairy tale, the genius too far ahead of his time, the prophet shouting into the wind. But he really was a prophet. “If his ideas seem at first sight marginal,” Stuurman writes, that’s because Poulain pushed “the limits of the thinkable.” Moreover, he helped erase his own name, first by publishing anonymously, then by downplaying his authorship of his books. He wasn’t humble, exactly; he seems to have been disappointed that his books didn’t get more attention. He might be said to have undercut his own authority, writing that everything men say about women “should be suspect, because they are both judges and litigants.” Or maybe he was afraid of being ridiculed, which he was, including by some female readers. That his conservative king, Louis XIV, had a certain scorn for “learned ladies” (the title of a satire by a royal favorite, Molière) and a robust network of spies may have also argued for keeping a low profile.

Fully forgotten by the 19th century, Poulain took a long time to resurface. In 1902, a young French graduate student named Henri Piéron pulled Poulain’s dusty books off the shelves of the French National Library, apparently by chance (the copy of *On the Equality of the Two Sexes* had likely never been opened, since its pages were uncut). Piéron recognized the significance of his find: He was something of a radical himself, and precociously well read in philosophy. In a pioneering essay, he described the experience of reading Poulain: “Sometimes the astonishment is such that you feel the need to return to the first page and make sure that the Roman numerals really do say 1673.”

It took another half century for Poulain’s name to begin circulating, and then only in academia. Look hard and you’ll find a footnote here, a mention there, usually in works about other feminists or in histories of feminism. You can count the

books about him on two hands. Enroll in a doctoral program in gender or women’s studies and you may actually read him, and maybe you’ll find the experience as disorienting as I did. In 2010, a historian wrote that Poulain “seems to crash through his times to offer us nothing less than the full-blown agenda of feminism in our own era.” I’m not so sure. The more closely I’ve considered Poulain, the more he and his work make the agenda of feminism in our own era look far from full-blown.

Poulain was born into a world beset by anxieties about where women fit in. (Of what era could that not be said?) The increase in trade and the growth of cities were loosening old constraints, and daughters and wives with means were learning to read and write. An outpouring of pamphlets and books revived an old dispute dating back to the 15th century, *la querelle des femmes*—“the quarrel over women.” At issue in the debate about female inferiority

were, among other topics, their intellect, or lack thereof, and their morality, or lack thereof. *La querelle* had its formulas: Gallant men overpraised women, then disparaged them, then offered the poor creatures their protection. Female authors objected to their defamation, pointing to the Didos of legend and to Queen Elizabeth.

Poulain broke away from this script. He wanted the freedom “to think of things in themselves,” as a feminist many centuries after him, Virginia Woolf, put it in *A Room of One’s Own*. That, and the freedom to think *for* oneself. The man who gave Poulain those freedoms was René Descartes, who died in 1650, when Poulain was 3, and whose works had been banned by the Church and kept out of universities. When a friend invited Poulain to a lecture on the philosopher in the 1660s, he was hooked. That was “the happiest moment in the world,” he wrote. Descartes, too, had abandoned his academic studies as soon as he could, and grasped, he wrote, that he should not “believe too firmly what I learned only from example and custom.” All knowledge taken on faith paled in comparison to “the simple and natural reasonings of a man of good sense.”

These days, the notion that you can clear your mind of bias sounds naive, but luckily, Poulain was naive. He applied the Cartesian method to himself and concluded that “all my knowledge was of no use whatsoever in the world, except to make a living in a profession which I did not wish to follow.” That revelation freed him—forced him—to see the world from the Martian perspective, as it were. Descartes laid new foundations for the sciences and philosophy. Poulain trained his newfound innocence on human relations. What he saw was prejudice masquerading as the natural order of things. And the oldest and most entrenched prejudice was against women and their work.

POULAIN LEAPFROGS so far over conventional timelines that he lends himself to a parlor game: What contemporary categories can we shoehorn him into? Let the historians disapprove. The comparisons deliver a useful jolt, exposing an unexpectedly long lineage for views we hail as quintessentially postmodern.

Poulain is a cultural relativist. He grasps that European supremacism is belief, not fact. He scoffs at Europeans who swan around thinking they are better than everyone else. He is so aware of the irrationality of norms that he wonders why we feel shame about excretion. “There is no imperfection or baseness about relieving the body,” he writes, meaning that no custom is more or less advanced than any other: “All ways of doing it are equal.” Poulain could have been a feminist art historian. He doesn’t rank the supposedly major arts above the so-called minor arts, especially

*“We offer great
rewards to a man who
can tame a tiger ...
Yet we neglect
women who have
spent years and years
nourishing and
educating children.”*

those traditionally created by women, such as tapestries and other kinds of needlework. “It takes skill to keep the proportions on a canvas, to work the silk or wool evenly,” he observes. “One has to have mastered countless different techniques of needlework to be competent at it.” Poulain is Foucauldian. Power is performative, he says, a chimera of gesture and costume: “Decorations were invented to distinguish certain people, and signs of respect were created to enhance perceived differences.”

Above all, Poulain is, well, a Marxist feminist. He rejects the gendering of the public and the private—men in the streets and on the job, women in the home—that

was in the process of being imposed by early capitalism. He sees a new order supplanting an older one in which the home would serve as its own little factory and husbands and wives would work shoulder to shoulder (unless, of course, they belonged to the nobility). To Poulain’s dismay, the home has become a workplace where the housewife toils alone.

He doesn’t try to determine the price of parenthood in the marketplace of labor (he isn’t an economist), but he grasps that it has value—more than many male professions. “We could do without princes, soldiers, and tradesmen,” he argues, “but we cannot do without women in our childhood.” Therefore, women’s nurturing work should be elevated, not debased. “We offer great rewards to a man who can tame a tiger, admire those who can train horses, monkeys, and elephants, and praise to the skies the author of some modest work,” he writes. “Yet we neglect women who have spent years and years nourishing and educating children.”

He shares a trait with my role model, Hochschild, in that he acknowledges women’s emotional labor as labor. Running households, raising children, and (I would add, though he is not explicit about this) exercising the discipline and self-control required to adhere to acceptable codes of female behavior and keep exacting husbands happy—the enterprise requires the managerial skills of a general: “Military art makes no higher demands than the other arts women are capable of, except that it is tougher, noisier, and does more harm.”

To Poulain’s further credit, he avoids the angel-in-the-house syndrome that would constrain women in the Victorian era. Women can mother, but, he asserts, they can do everything else as well. After all, Cartesians separate mind and body, from which it follows that, as Poulain writes, “the mind has no sex.” Women are as good as men at every endeavor that doesn’t require brute strength. “A most minute anatomical study reveals no difference,” he writes, addressing his male readers. “A woman’s brain is exactly the same as ours.” In his second book, *On the Education of Ladies* (1674), Poulain prescribes scientific training for women—for everyone, in fact. His notion of science privileges women, though, because when he

says *scientific*, he means evidence-based, and he sees women as natural scientists—not because they are born that way, but because in his day and among members of his class, women interacted more intimately with the material world than men did.

He predicts that, given the proper training (by which he means the empirical kind he didn't get), women could be as good as men in law, government, the clergy, and medicine, and might surpass them—especially in medicine. Women understand bodies: “Is it not women who take care of the poor and sick of the parish, who visit the prisons and help in the hospitals?” Medical schools were closed to women, of course—which had the benefit, in Poulain's view, of sparing them the arcane curriculum that had students reading ancient authors such as Hippocrates. Women's “observations about medical practice are so accurate and so precisely reasoned, that they often make all the notebooks of the faculty superfluous.”

SO MUCH that Poulain espoused we now endorse. And yet, as I went down rabbit holes trying to find out what happened to him, I worried that his ideas were still too utopian. He wanted to undo assumptions about gender and work that have been set in stone for millennia—unconscious presuppositions that, to judge from the fact that women still work the second shift, have yet to budge. His egalitarianism was total and uncompromising. Are we actually now primed to listen to him in ways that his peers hadn't been?

Here's what my perambulations through the stacks taught me: Poulain never really went away. He himself sank into near-total obscurity, first as a parish priest shunted from one unprepossessing town to another; he then left the clergy or was forced out on account of his problematic ideas—the record is unclear—at the age of 41. After that, he converted to Calvinism, fled anti-Protestant France, and spent most of the rest of his life teaching French and classics in Geneva.

But his ideas run like a secret, subterranean river beneath the history of revolutionary thought. His inconspicuousness gave license to publishers and authors to plunder his books and arguments without

attribution. This raiding started a few years after first publication and continued into the 18th century. Entire passages were lifted from *On the Equality of the Two Sexes* by the pseudonymous 18th-century feminist “Sophia,” in her *Woman Not Inferior to Man*, which was reissued in London several times over the course of 40 years, and even translated back into French. I wonder whether Poulain would have been peeved at the French Enlightenment philosophers who actually *did* know his name and borrowed from him without mentioning it. I think he would have been highly annoyed by Jean-Jacques Rousseau, whose attack

*Simone de
Beauvoir knew
Poulain's work
well and cited
him by name in
The Second Sex.*

on exploitative social relations helped spur two revolutions, the American and the French. Rousseau almost certainly read Poulain early in his career while conducting research for a magnum opus on the history of women on behalf of a beautiful noblewoman, Louise Marie-Madeleine Dupin. (Rousseau fell in love with Dupin and she shrewdly made him her assistant.) She was one of the few writers of the time to identify Poulain as a major influence, but she never finished her book, so hardly anyone read her until Rousseau scholars recently began rooting around in her papers.

Set Poulain's *Equality* and Rousseau's *Discourse on Inequality* side by side, and the similarities will seem too numerous for coincidence. Rousseau appears to have helped himself to Poulain's ideas, imagery, modes of argument—sometimes entire phrases. But here's the catch: Even as he outlines his version of an egalitarian polity, Rousseau all but kicks women out of it. Political activity is for men only. A woman's job is to raise future citizens.

I feel sure, however, that Poulain would have been pleased by how Simone de Beauvoir made use of him in *The Second Sex* (1949)—if a little disappointed too. Beauvoir knew his work well and cited him by name. She could have introduced Poulain to 20th-century feminists. She didn't, though, because she never acknowledged the extent of his originality. She gave him one of the book's two epigraphs. But the gesture was double-edged. She quotes, or rather misquotes slightly, his self-effacing observation that everything men say about women should be viewed with suspicion. I read this nod in his direction as a soft appropriation. Beauvoir was asserting her right as a woman to make this man's thoughts her own.

Fair enough. Beauvoir was the more expansive thinker and better stylist: dialectical; subtle; fluent in biology, psychoanalysis, sociology, anthropology, political theory, existentialism, phenomenology, and so on. She salutes him as “the leading feminist of the time” (perhaps not the highest bar), and in five sentences explains his hypothesis that men use their strength to arrange society to their benefit, and women acquiesce by habit. But her book contains more echoes of his ideas, such as how women internalize their own subjugation. Perhaps these echoes reflect nothing more than the sad fact that women's lot hadn't changed all that much over the three intervening centuries, but I like to think that she's in explicit dialogue with him. She's the student who surpasses her teacher. *The Second Sex* became one of feminism's foundational texts because Beauvoir had Poulain, plus her immense erudition, plus, of course, her own experiences as a woman.

Beauvoir owes her most memorable insight to Poulain: “One is not born, but rather becomes, woman.” The aphorism

sticks in the mind, whereas Poulain's articulation of the same idea is wordy and forgettable: "The difference in behavior we observe between men and women springs from the education they receive." Still, he elaborates vividly; a girl "is made afraid of everything, told that ghosts lurk in any part of the house where she might be alone." Are women vain? Consider "all the glances, all the comments about the importance of beauty [that] absorb her mind completely, and the compliments she receives about it [that] are her sole source of joy." Beauvoir takes these thoughts and gives them psychological depth. A girl strikes poses in front of the mirror, applying makeup and wriggling into constraining clothes, Beauvoir writes, and as the girl does this, she becomes a self divided, seeing herself as a man would see her. Poulain depicts the influence of family and home. Beauvoir has the panoramic perspective of a modern sociologist. Girls learn to be fearful not just from parents or governesses but from institutions—schools, sporting clubs, workplaces—that discourage adventure and exploration.

AND YET Beauvoir leaves out the part of Poulain's feminism that strikes me as so timely today. She doesn't have many good things to say about motherhood. On the contrary: Maternity—the passions leading up to it, the life changes that it demands—mostly makes her cringe. If Poulain scants the broader social dimension of psychological conditioning, she's positively revolted by the biological dimension. Love leads to dependence, and dependence abases, she writes with some bitterness in her chapter on "The Woman in Love." Later, nurture ensnares. If women want equality, they must not "subordinate existence to life, the human being to its animality." What she is saying in her existentialism-ese is that "existence" (that is, freedom) must be chosen over "life"—that is, allowing oneself to be mired in the repetitive processes of nature. The brilliant and prolific

Beauvoir had no intention of getting stuck in those. Housework, undone as soon as it is done, doesn't build toward "the creation of anything durable." Motherhood at least yields something of lasting value, but—she adds—let women beware of becoming attached to pregnancy and nursing, lest they reduce themselves to "fowls with high egg-production."

That phrase stings, although I understand why she wrote it. Like many feminists who came before and after her, Beauvoir had good reason to run as far as she could from everything women of her generation were supposed to run toward. Domesticity, for Beauvoir, would have been tantamount to having her mind pickled and stored in a pantry. I get that. Even now, "motherhood as experience and institution," in Adrienne Rich's words, constrains and subordinates, despite having become a choice, not a fate. Indeed, that motherhood is chosen rather than forced upon one makes my own choices feel more fraught, not less. In any case, Poulain, who wrestled with the discipline of a Church he disliked, would have known what it meant to live under the threat of intellectual extinction. But the destiny he feared didn't involve dusting and cooking and tending babies (a priest only had to baptize them). So Poulain could give reproduction its due.

"Dependence was not considered irksome": That thought of his is still more uncommon than it should be. Life is dependence all the way down. If we haven't absorbed this by now, we've learned nothing in the past year and a half. Children depend on adults, parents depend on communities and—in enlightened countries—on social policies, and all of us depend on "essential" and "frontline" workers. But Americans were raised to prize self-sufficiency, and we don't find it easy to face the specter of our interconnectedness. My spike of shame when people ask what I do is both typical and ridiculous. What's wonderful about Poulain is that he gives me cover. No, he does more than that. He gives me hope.

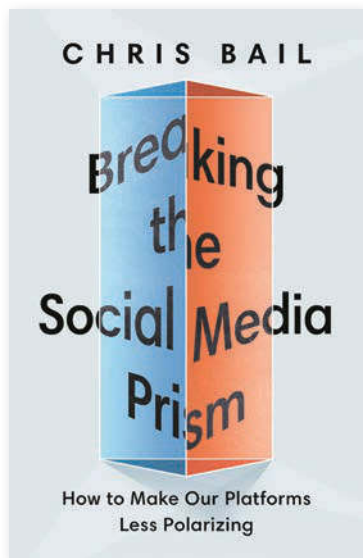
I'm comforted by his refusal to accept that caregiving demeans the caregiver, or that leaning on others is pathetic.

I find his fearlessness inspiring. At the height of Louis XIV's authoritarian and patriarchal rule, this single, childless 26-year-old defended nurture and interdependence against a revulsion that was by then almost instinctive. I wonder what his readers, most of them male, made of these sentences: "God desired to produce human beings dependent upon each other" and "Both sexes are necessary to produce together their offspring." Reproduction is the "highest purpose in the world," and so "it is hard to understand how those who maintain that men are nobler than women justify their arguments as far as children are concerned." Is it because mothers work harder than fathers that women rank lower than men?

That is not a rhetorical question. In 17th-century France, only the lower orders did physical labor; thus anyone doing physical labor occupied a lower order. *Plus ça change!* Poulain doesn't buy that, of course. Just because women's "effort is greater than ours" doesn't mean men should "use this against them to bring scorn upon them," he writes. In a subtle hint that we must reconceive care work as civilization-building equal in stature to any other kind, he pairs "*mothers and fathers* toiling to bring up their children"—the italics are mine—with "good princes working at governing their subjects or magistrates seeking to mete out justice." Who among his peers could have imagined a world that placed parenting on the same social rung as ruling and judging? I would guess none of them. And who among us can fully envision that world even now? Poulain will be vindicated only when we understand that anything less is simply illogical. *A*

Judith Shulevitz is the author of The Sabbath World: Glimpses of a Different Order of Time.

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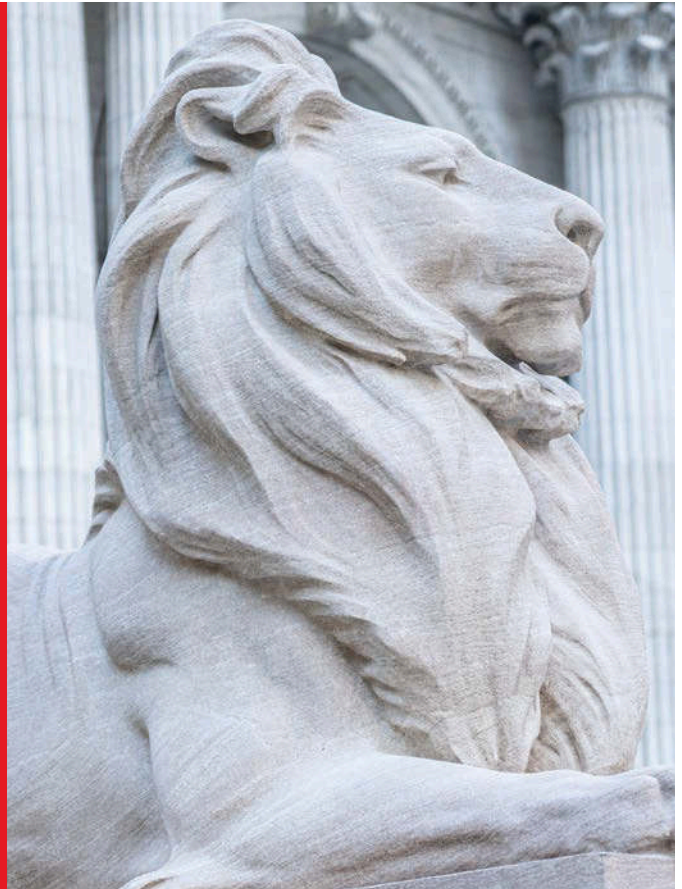
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*Me, I can
fake it.*

Stale as I may be from the night before, one foot—one leg—stuck in the underworld, I can still crank up the sociability. I can manufacture perkiness at an early hour. Good morning! Good morning! Am I even faking it? Perhaps not. It *is* good to wake up. I *do* rejoice in the restoration of consciousness, the grand democracy of daylight. Yes! Good morning!

You, on the other hand ... No faking for you. You're condemned to a splendid and groaning authenticity. Waking is suffering, humans are intolerable, and you cannot, you will not, hide it. You wince, you flinch, you shuffle around. Should you happen, by some mischance, to encounter another person before you've gotten yourself together, you rear back like a scalded troll. The hours of sleep, it appears, have not refreshed you—they have *flayed* you.

And that's what I like about you, non-morning person: your fastidiousness. Your great delicacy of being. You don't bounce giddily from oblivion to wakefulness, taking it all for granted, confident of finding things more

or less as you left them at bedtime. No, no, it's a change; it's arduous; it's *real*. Deflector shields: gone. Resilience: none. The world is upon you as a pressure, an aesthetic offense, a ghastly payload of noise and glare and babbling, galumphing people. You'll be okay, you'll get there, but you need time. Complex operations of personal reassembly are required. There's an essential, existential honesty to what you're doing: Every morning, out of old socks and empty bottles of ibuprofen, you build yourself anew.

Morning person versus non-morning person. It's a classic duality, isn't it? It's Hardy versus Laurel. It's McCartney versus Lennon: *Woke up, fell out of bed, / Dragged a comb across my head* versus *Please don't wake me, no, don't shake me, / Leave me where I am*. And, this being America, we're heavily weighted in favor of productivity and go-get-'em-ness. What politician will confess to having trouble waking up? You're a bit countercultural, non-morning person, sunk in your vibes, crowned with your bed head. You're a subversive.

And here's a truth: Morning people fizzle. They front-load the day, they burn all their energy before 10 o'clock, and the remaining hours are just a kind of higher zombiedom. By mid-afternoon, a morning person is wan and sugar-starved. But you non-morning people get stronger: Like Antaeus, whose power increased every time Hercules took him down, you are nourished by contact with the Earth. You run on heavy fuel. You draw your strength from the slumbering core of the planet, where morning never breaks. *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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— to —

NOT BEING A MORNING PERSON

By James Parker





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